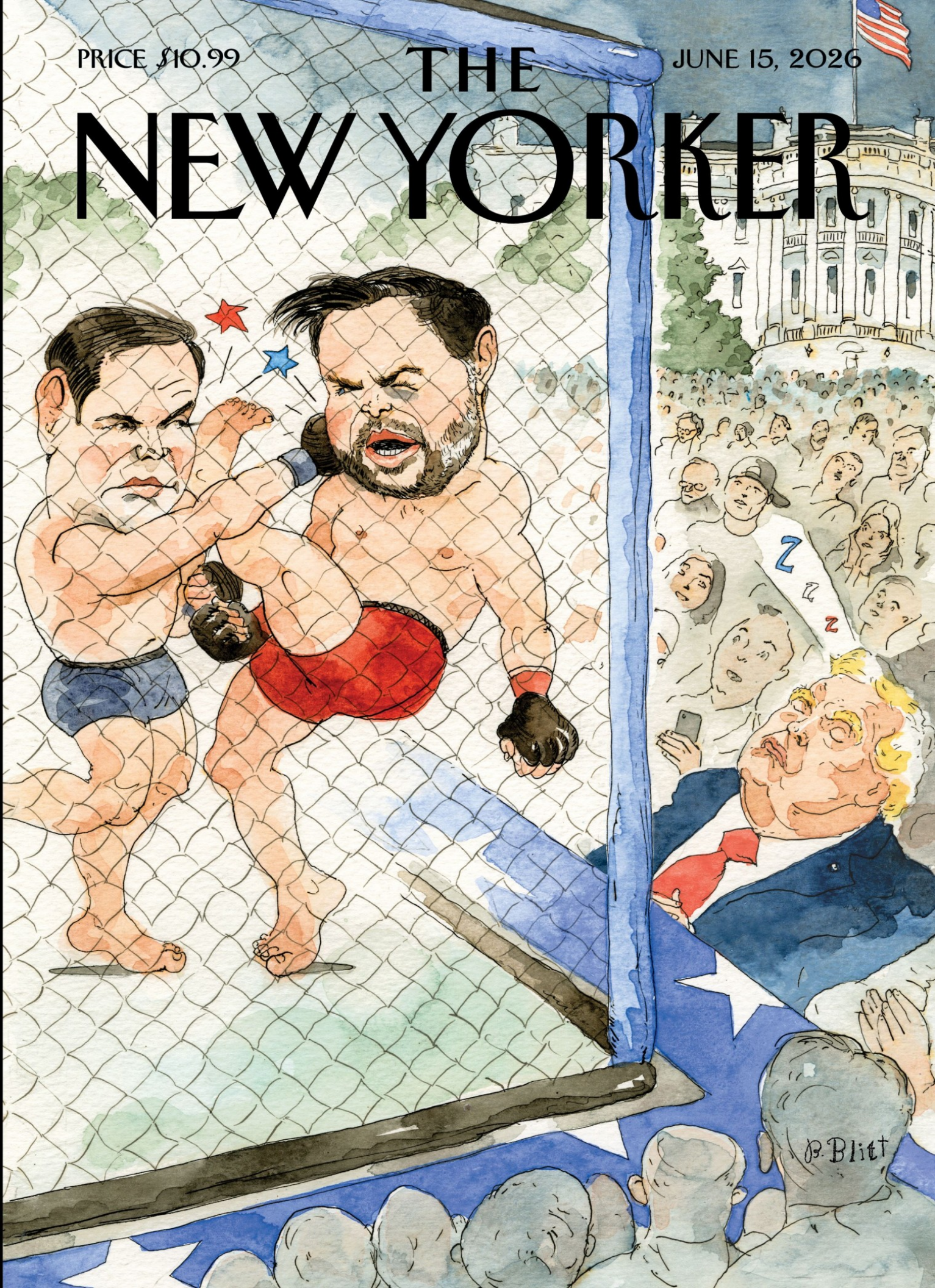


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By [Richard Brody](#), [Sheldon Pearce](#), [Emily Nussbaum](#), [Hilton Als](#), [Brian Seibert](#), and [Rachel Syme](#)

June 5, 2026

[You're reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we're watching, listening to, and doing this week. **Sign up to receive it in your inbox.**](#)

The series "[Universal Westerns](#)," at MOMA through July 3, reveals the fruitful cinematic idiosyncrasies that Universal Pictures, founded in 1912, fostered in its heyday. John Ford, the supreme director of the Western, got his start there, at age twenty-four; in his first feature, "**Straight Shooting**" (screening June 6 and June 16), from 1917, his artistic personality is already on sharp display. The story involves a family of homesteaders—small-time farmers portrayed as peaceful and law-abiding—facing the hired guns of a cattle rancher who wants their land for grazing. The lead gunman (Harry Carey) grows disgusted and changes sides, as does a young cowboy, resulting in romantic complications with a farmer's daughter. Ford, a moralist of high principle, creates an instant legend with his lofty depictions of righteous violence—yet with his next film he quickly punctured the pomp of crowd-pleasing heroism. "**Hell Bent**" (June 6 and June 16), from 1918, starts with a Western novelist getting a letter from his publisher requesting realistic characters with mixed motives. The rest of the movie involves the novelist's imaginings, featuring Carey as a gunman whose actions again—and even more ambiguously—veer between noble and ignoble.



Kirk Douglas and Jeanne Crain in King Vidor's "Man Without a Star," from 1955. Photograph from Universal Pictures / Alamy

In **"Trail of the Vigilantes"** (June 8 and July 2), from 1940, the freewheelingly inventive director Allan Dwan turns an intricate drama into a hectic comedy, starring the urbane Franchot Tone, as an upper-crust special investigator who heads West, from Kansas City, and awkwardly poses as a cowpuncher in order to find a journalist's killer. The action, both loopy and violent, features breathtaking rooftop stunt work framed in starkly graphic images; again, the villains are cattlemen seeking to monopolize land.

King Vidor, who, in 1949, had filmed Ayn Rand's "The Fountainhead," both flaunts and questions his libertarian bona fides in **"Man Without a Star"** (June 12 and June 28), from 1955. It's a dashing flamboyant Technicolor tale of a wandering gunslinger (Kirk Douglas) who heads to Wyoming in search of wide-open spaces and gets embroiled in a range war between a big-time rancher and small cattlemen who fence out big herds—and in the schemes of two powerful women (Jeanne Crain and Claire Trevor). An odd subplot of bathroom humor, involving the invention of indoor facilities, symbolizes the changing times. Vidor envisions irreconcilable conflicts of freedom and order, and shrugs.—*Richard Brody*



About Town

Alternative Rock

The third wave of emo music was in full swing at the turn of the millenium, but the dam preventing its complete cultural penetration wasn't broken until the Arizona band **Jimmy Eat World's** bittersweet single, "The Middle," from its self-titled 2001 album, also known as "Bleed American," came flooding onto radio. The band's previous LP, "Clarity" (1999), was a curious, intricate cult classic that got it dropped from its label; taking note, the follow-up's more straightforward pop songcraft was generational in its articulation of youthful disillusionment. Proving it really wasn't just a phase, the band celebrates the album's twenty-fifth anniversary with compatriots from the heyday of the emo stable Vagrant Records: the Get Up Kids and Hey Mercedes.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([Brooklyn Paramount](#); June 16.)

Off Broadway

"Small" is a one-man show about Robert Montano's brief, blazing, and painful adolescent career as a jockey. It's also a nifty showcase for the resilience of its star, who, with tiny shifts of his spine and eyebrows, embodies each role, mincing flirtatiously as his Puerto Rican mother and adopting a matador's hauteur as his mentor at the Belmont Raceway. The show begins as a corny boomer bildungsroman, but Montano's athleticism and the show's clever staging transform it into something cooler, capturing the high of the ride and the horror of "the monster"—racetrack slang for the scale. As Montano strokes an invisible horse's snout, then crouches as we hear the hammer of hooves, the crowd is catapulted toward the finish line.—*Emily Nussbaum* ([Pershing Square Signature Center](#); through July 24.)

Off Broadway



Lydia Wilson and Phia Saban in “The Maids.” Photograph by Julieta Cervantes

The carbonated, TikTokified modern adaptation of Jean Genet’s 1947 play **“The Maids”** is set in an influencer’s aerie draped in chiffon, with screens as literal walls and iPhones as metaphorical windows. The Australian director Kip Williams recasts Genet’s sister-maids (a rock-solid Phia Saban and Lydia Wilson) as seething Gen Z underlings, pressed beneath the thumb of the awful Madame (Yerin Ha). The original was a shocker, a fable of class warfare that jump-started absurdist theatre; the new production, reusing the tools of Williams’s superior staging of “The Picture of Dorian Gray,” feels less novel, but still has a mesmeric kick. As the maids kinkily cosplay as—and scheme to poison—their boss, you cheer for them, if only to kill the algorithm at its source.—*E.N.* ([St. Ann’s Warehouse](#); through June 14.)

Art

There’s something scrumptious about **Jessi Reaves’s** work, but it’s not ornate. She has a fondness for the theatrical—cushioned platforms that act as beds and stages, both the place of fantasy, of desire—which plays beautifully in her display space, a vaulted classical room. Reaves gives a lot of thought to how the artist reuses materials in order to give them a second or third life. It’s refreshing to observe how she uses objects—water bottles, an old vanity—not to denigrate consumerism but to show how consumerist goods are aspirational objects, and what happens to us, the viewer, when we remake the ordinary into the shape of a dream. You can relax in Reaves’s installation because she wants you to live in the universe she’s created—and enjoy.—*Hilton Als* ([American Academy of Arts and Letters](#); through July 3.)

Dance



The Eyal Vilner Big Band. Photograph by Jerry Almonte

This year, **Lincoln Center’s Summer for the City** is the Summer of Dance. In addition to the usual social-dance occasions on the outdoor dance floor, there’s a brand-new contemporary-dance festival (June 18-July 5) that features a strong lineup of international companies, including those of Rachid Ouramdane and Akram Khan. Before that, on June 10, comes “Rhapsody,” one of Larry Keigwin’s fun mass orchestrations of community members, and a swing-dance party with Caleb Teicher and the Eyal Vilner Big Band. “Inayat: A Duet for Four,” starring the kathak dancer Tarini Tripathi, runs June 10-12. It’s all free or choose-what-you-pay.—*Brian Seibert* ([Lincoln Center](#); June 10-Aug. 8.)

Movies

The stress of a double life weighs heavily on a French teen-ager in Hafsia Herzi’s drama **“The Little Sister,”** based on an autofictional novel by Fatima Daas. The energetic and pensive Nadia Melliti, in her first movie role, plays Fatima, a high-school senior of Algerian descent, who lives in a suburb of Paris. A good student and an athlete, Fatima is attracted to women and begins to act on her desires, keeping her private life a secret: she’s surrounded by homophobic discourse and, as a practicing Muslim, is aware that her conduct is forbidden. Herzi subtly conveys the tension of Fatima’s furtive silence while emphasizing the public systems—educational, medical, religious—that shape her inner life and spark her literary ambitions.—*Richard Brody* ([Film at Lincoln Center](#); opening June 5.)

On and Off the Avenue



Illustration by Bill Rebholz

Rachel Syme slips back into summer's favorite shoes.

The shoe of the summer, like the song of the summer, is a soggy superlative—it shifts with the breeze, depending on where you are and whom you ask. But the fashion world—and those who stand to profit off of it—love a consensus, if only to sell the idea of an unmissable trend. A few years back, the chatter was all about Birkenstocks and the granola-core aesthetic. Then, attention shifted to puffy foam slides—essentially orthopedic pool noodles—which leapt from their traditional use as dorm shower gear to legitimate streetwear. (I am still haunted by the flatulent sound they make while squishing against concrete.) In 2025, it was the mesh ballet flat, spotted on celebrities from Nicole Kidman to Gigi Hadid (it's not too late to try them; **Loeffler Randall** still sells a [demure, cream-colored version for \\$250](#)). This summer, the hot footwear du jour is, somehow, the reliable old flip-flop, a shoe that has been kicking around since 4000 B.C. and comes roaring back every few years like El Niño. The modern flip-flop—with its polyurethane body, thong shape, and signature heel *thwack*—dates to the nineteen-fifties and sixties, when companies began adapting traditional Japanese zōri sandals for beachgoing consumers. Now, the flop has gone high fashion. **The Row**'s coveted [Beach Flip Flop Sport 2](#) retails for \$920. A pair of

sunny yellow [Miu Miu thongs](#) will set you back \$795, while a pair of [YSL Pool Flip-Flops](#) go for \$690. But fret not; cheaper varietals are also trending. Flops from **Rainbow**, a California purveyor launched in the seventies, are allegedly all the rage with Gen Z (a pair of their popular [Flirty Braid style](#) goes for \$71). You can also find fresh-looking flops at [the Gap](#) (\$34.95), [Madewell](#) (\$98), and, of course, at the Brazilian juggernaut **Havaianas**, whose new collaboration with designer Isabel Marant yielded a [handsome ikat pair](#) (\$120) and another [studded with silver balls](#) (\$190). Enjoy your flop era.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [A summer salad](#)
- [The best of “Moby-Dick”](#)
- [The fight to save Ben & Jerry’s](#)

[Richard Brody](#), a film critic, began writing for *The New Yorker* in 1999. He is the author of [“Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard.”](#)

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[The Food Scene](#)

Cote and the Risks of the Clubstaurant

With a soaring new complex in midtown, the restaurateur Simon Kim continues to turn his Korean-barbecue-meets-steak-house concept into a high-status luxury chain.

By [Helen Rosner](#)

May 24, 2026



Cote 550 brings Korean barbecue with an expense-account swagger to a flashy space on Madison Avenue. Photographs by Jutharat Pinyodoonyachet for The New Yorker

[You're reading the Food Scene newsletter, Helen Rosner's guide to what, where, and how to eat. Sign up to receive it in your inbox.](#)

The restaurateur Simon Kim opened Cote in the Flatiron district, in 2017, with an alluring conceit: a marriage of two of the great beef-worshipping restaurant genres, the Korean-barbecue joint and [the American steak house](#). He borrowed Cote's format from the former, with grills inset into tabletops and a classic Korean menu of meat, marinades, and banchan. From the American steak house, he adopted a certain slick-edged expense-account swagger, with dark-leather décor, a dry-aging program, a serious wine list, and European-inspired hospitality. The name itself carried a double meaning—*cote*, in Korean, means “flower,” or “essence,” but the word also evokes “*côte de boeuf*,” the French term for a standing rib roast. Within a

year, Kim's restaurant became the first Korean-barbecue place in the world to earn a Michelin star. In the time since, Kim and his company, Gracious Hospitality Management, have taken Cote global, opening outposts in Miami, Singapore, and Las Vegas—and, as of April, in midtown.

Kim seems constitutionally incapable of doing anything small; his follow-up to the original Cote, the Korean fried-chicken joint COQODAQ, also in Flatiron, became famous almost immediately for its encyclopedic champagne list, created by the group's beverage director, Victoria James, and for its Golden Nugget, a boneless-chicken bite topped with a generous dollop of caviar. But the newest project is his grandest yet, and he knows it. "This is my Sistine Chapel," [he told *Grub Street*](#), referring to the soaring ceilings of 550 Madison, the postmodern tower in which his latest project is housed. Cote 550, as it's called, makes up just one-third of it; the address is home to three new Gracious Hospitality restaurants, stacked vertically. Cote 550 occupies a moody subterranean space; above it is the more casual Bar Chimera, on the cathedral-like main floor; and on the mezzanine level is a not yet open sushi-omakase counter, to be helmed by the super-chef Masahiro Yoshitake, whose sushi-yas in Tokyo and Hong Kong each have multiple Michelin stars.

Diners enter the complex on Fifty-sixth Street between Fifth and Madison, an area that's closed to car traffic owing to the presence of Trump Tower on the block's northwestern corner. Once you're past the barricades, pylons, and hulking N.Y.P.D. mobile checkpoint, and through the door to Bar Chimera (which you must go through to reach the other restaurants), all that jittery energy doesn't exactly dissolve, but it does change form, into supercharged biz-cazh happy hour. The room is enormous in every dimension, with a sixty-foot atrium and vast windows overlooking Madison Avenue. From the center, a twenty-three-foot Norfolk-pine tree ascends, looking unavoidably Christmassy, surrounded by plush booths and three distinct, stage-set bar areas: one for Martinis, with mirrored backdrops and icy-white lighting; one for whiskey, warmly lit, with wooden shelves and a rolling ladder; and one dedicated to the vast and rarefied wine list, which includes a vintage Madeira dating to 1835. High up on an interior wall, in jarring contrast with the muted sandstone tones of the rest of the room, is a

neon work by the artist Martin Creed proclaiming “DON’T WORRY.” Was I worried? Should I be worried?

On all my visits, the room was raucous and packed, the tables full of people who looked like they had just come from an office and were ready to take someone home. The food ranges from snacky to sizable, and the quality of dishes varies widely. Home-Run Balls, named for a popular Korean snack of the same shape, are terrific *gougère* puffs filled with foie-gras cream, and a spring-pea lettuce cup was clean and bright. Fried-octopus bites, though, were like chewing on a knotted hair tie, and a pairing of melon with bresaola—cured beef, standing in for the more traditional prosciutto, in what I assume was a nod to Cote’s reverence of the cow—was flat and fatty-tasting. But these are still early days, and I imagine such kitchen kinks will work themselves out. Notable on the menu is a burger, the first at a Kim joint: it’s modest in size (a plus in my book), with a medium-rare patty that’s textural and complex, plus a slim melt of American cheese with crispy Parmesan. The drinks are beautifully made, even if the multiple-bars situation creates some odd segregations on the cocktail list. (A passion-fruit-tequila cocktail is a Martini, I guess?) My only real quibble is that a drinks list this broad shouldn’t contain just three non-alcoholic cocktails, one of which turned out to just be a canned adaptogen-whatever drink, poured tableside into a glass.

The office-party vibes, thank goodness, do not follow you downstairs. Make a turn at Bar Chimera’s host stand and descend a dark and oddly narrow staircase. Then pass through a night-clubby space—Cote’s bar, where a d.j. spins party beats starting at five—and past the trippy optical-illusion rest rooms, down a pleasingly disorienting blue-neon-framed tunnel that seems to go on forever, and you’ll find yourself at Cote 550. The restaurant is flashier and more glamorous than the original, with moody black floors, discreetly spotlit tables, mirrored ceilings, and walls leafed in living greenery. In the darkness, all eyes are drawn to a small, shining pool at the center of the small, shining room, its turquoise water still and luminous. The over-all effect is intimate, sultry, very eighties, very cokey, very Nagel painting.

As at the original Cote—and all the others—the centerpiece of the menu is the Butcher’s Feast: a prix fixe that includes four cuts of meat cooked for you, by one of the restaurant’s servers, at your table’s grill. The meal comes with a wonderful assortment of banchan and sides, my favorites being a dish of chilled okra, sticky and with a bit of heat, and Cote’s justly famous scallion salad, a marvel of curlicued slivers made sweet and lightly sour from a fermented dressing. The meat, including a nice piece of hanger steak and some oddly gristly rib eye, is fine enough (if you want more and lovelier cuts, you’ll have to level up your order to the Steak Omakase), and it’s served well by the lettuces, sauces, and other bits and bobs with which you’re encouraged to eat it. The feast opens with a shiso leaf bearing a geometric cube of *o-toro*, dramatic and a little awkwardly large, and concludes with a cup of tangy soft serve, petite and satisfying.

Helen, Help Me!

[E-mail your questions](#) about dining, eating, and anything food-related, and Helen may respond in a future newsletter.

The Butcher’s Feast is more than enough for a full meal, but there are other treasures, too, like a beef-noodle soup built on a spectacularly rich, slightly offal-ish broth made with marrow bones, with paper-thin slices of A5-Wagyu rib eye swimming in it like manta rays. (You can get a cup of just the broth, for sipping, upstairs at Bar Chimera.) Also new at this Cote is a luxe *japchae*, whose ingredients are wheeled in on a beautiful cart bearing little bowls—noodles, vegetables julienned to pleasing uniformity, and a frankly enormous portion of sweet Alaskan-king-crab meat. “It’s our take on the tableside Caesar salad,” my server explained. (There is also a Caesar salad, in a *doenjang* dressing; it’s plated in the kitchen.) The *japchae* assembly is more mechanical than dramatic, but the servers who put it together are charming and chatty enough to carry the performance. Also charming: the cocktail menu’s hangover prophylactic, ZBiotics, a vial of clear liquid that tastes like watery yogurt, and—as far as I could tell, after downing a strong cocktail on a mostly empty stomach—actually seems to work.

One of Cote’s winky Asian-steak-house creations, also available at Bar Chimera, is a dish called Oyster “Dynamite,” a hybrid of oysters

Rockefeller and seafood dynamite, the sushi-fusion clubstaurant staple. The result—oysters broiled under a dollop of mixed seafood dressed in spicy mayonnaise—is a clubstaurant dish, through and through, and I can’t really tell whether that’s something Cote is doing seriously, ironically, or totally unintentionally. Kim, a consummate macher, is still operating with more intelligence and better taste than most, and I used to think that Cote was following [the Carbone model](#) (which, in turn, seemed to mostly follow the Nobu model), expanding its business into a high-status luxury chain while maintaining much of the lightning-in-a-bottle magic that made the original so irresistibly compelling. But this latest iteration, and, indeed, the entirety of the 550 complex, makes me wonder if a more apt comparison would be to something like Tao, the ur-clubstaurant, which is so ubiquitous and so party-forward that the “-staurant” part barely registers anymore. At Cote 550, there’s a Midori sour on the cocktail list! There’s a Cosmo upstairs! “Has anyone jumped in the pool yet?” my companion asked our waiter, as he fiddled with some Wagyu on our tabletop grill. No one has. Yet. ♦

[Helen Rosner](#), a staff writer at The New Yorker, has received multiple James Beard Awards, including one in 2025 for her [Profile of the food personality Padma Lakshmi](#).

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The Talk of the Town

- **[For the Nation's Birthday, Making It Harder to Become an American](#)**

By Jonathan Blitzer | The Trump Administration has chosen to honor the Semiquincentennial of a nation of immigrants with a vision that sends the country back in time.

- **[From Sturgeon to Knicks Gear, Barney Greengrass Has You Covered](#)**

By David Remnick | The Upper West Side smoked-fish establishment, beloved by Marilyn Monroe and Irving Berlin, represents the best of New York—great food, family bonds, and Jalen Brunson.

- **[Michael Arden Catches a Flight](#)**

By Zach Helfand | The theatre director's latest show, "The Lost Boys," has its actors dangle high above the stage. At an indoor-skydiving joint, it's his turn to defy gravity.

- **[Inside the Creative Cavern of JR](#)**

By Lauren Collins | Riding in his custom-designed car on the Orient Express, the French artist reflects on his latest large-scale project—turning the Pont Neuf into a giant inflatable cave.

- **[Kurt Vile Gets the Feeling](#)**

By Nick Paumgarten | On the heels of his tenth album, "Philadelphia's Been Good to Me," the musician catches a show at Le Poisson Rouge and reminisces on how Beck and Pavement ignited his passion for live music.

[Comment](#)

For the Nation's Birthday, Making It Harder to Become an American

The Trump Administration has chosen to honor the Semiquincentennial of a nation of immigrants with a vision that sends the country back in time.

By [Jonathan Blitzer](#)

June 7, 2026



Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

Shortly after taking office for the second time, Donald Trump created the White House Task Force on Celebrating America's 250th Birthday, naming himself—"the man who some say is the Greatest President in History"—as its chair. The celebrations start this month, but the party planners seem to have faltered. Musical performers largely pulled out of a concert, so Trump is staging a rally, and a U.F.C. cage match will grace the South Lawn. It is a heady moment to be asking existential questions about what it means to be American. But, as it happens, another member of the task force has spent

the past year and a half preparing a diligent and thorough answer on behalf of the President.

Stephen Miller, Trump's top domestic-policy adviser, has presided over the most concerted effort in a century to recast citizenship as a tool of systematic exclusion. Under his direction, the Administration has chosen to honor the Semiquincentennial by keeping people from entering the United States, by restricting those who have already done so from becoming full citizens, and by trying to strip naturalized citizens of their legal status. It is a vision that sends the country back in time, to some of the lowest points of the past century.

Unlike so many iconic American fights, held in the halls of Congress or on the streets of major cities, this campaign is being waged for the most part in obscurity. Immigration policy gets to the core of the country's identity, yet lawmakers haven't passed legislation for comprehensive reform in more than thirty-five years. Drastic changes have instead come via executive orders, bureaucratic regulations, and technocratic maneuvers. It's an ad-hoc form of policymaking that suits the President's maximalist impulses and gives an ideologue like Miller a broad range of opportunities.

A case in point: between June and December of last year, Trump issued bans on travel from thirty-nine countries, including Afghanistan, Haiti, Nigeria, and Iran. The government went on to suspend virtually all immigration applications filed by people from those countries. In January, a press release from the State Department listed seventy-five countries subject to a similar suspension. (Some two dozen countries appear on both lists, perhaps as an insurance policy in the event of an adverse court ruling.) According to the Migration Policy Institute, immigrants from the countries on the second list received forty-six per cent of all visas issued in 2024. Halting the visas closes the path toward permanent residency for hundreds of thousands of people—in effect, remaking the composition of who can come to the U.S. lawfully. Permanent residents born in those countries who had been approved for citizenship saw their naturalization ceremonies cancelled. (On Friday, a federal judge blocked the suspension of applications by immigrants from the thirty-nine countries in the travel ban.)

Masked *ICE* agents using lethal force against immigrants and citizens have commanded the most attention and generated the greatest alarm. Now there's cause for further concern: the Republican-controlled Senate just authorized another seventy billion dollars for immigration enforcement. But the agency at the center of the Administration's ideological plans is the United States Citizenship and Immigration Services, or U.S.C.I.S., which runs the legal-immigration system. Late last month, the agency released a memo announcing plans to force most green-card applicants living in the U.S. with temporary status to leave the country for an extended period and submit their paperwork from an American consulate abroad. The impact of this would have been seismic. Of the 1.36 million green cards issued in 2024, fifty-eight per cent of them went to people who were already here. The move violated the agency's preferred *modus operandi*: it drew widespread notice. Business groups and C.E.O.s warned the Administration about its effect on employment, according to the *Washington Post*. The U.S.C.I.S. backtracked, with the White House claiming that the memo was a housekeeping matter, rather than a change of strategy. But, according to a source with knowledge of the agency, the policy was prepared last fall.

If the reasoning in the memo struck immigration lawyers as dubious, this may have been because the agency's office of chief counsel failed to properly vet it. According to the source, government attorneys have been reassigned to work with Assistant U.S. Attorneys in investigating people whose legal status the government might be able to strip. Earlier this year, U.S.C.I.S. created the Tactical Operations Division. Some eighty officials are tasked with finding citizens, green-card holders, and refugees to investigate on the ground that the status they lawfully obtained might have been granted either through fraud or in error.

Thousands of people living legally in the U.S. have already been identified, the *Times* has reported. By contrast, the U.S. averaged eleven denaturalizations a year between 1990 and 2017, and these were largely exceptional cases in which a person had deliberately misrepresented a serious criminal history, such as a Nazi past or links to war crimes. Denaturalizations were exceedingly rare in part because they'd once been common, used in response to disfavored political speech or ideology (as in the case of the Russian-born anarchist Emma Goldman) or identity

(Germans and Japanese during the First and Second World Wars). The Supreme Court eventually interceded, with a series of rulings that made it far more difficult to remove someone's citizenship for political reasons. Now U.S.C.I.S. has been instructed to refer one hundred to two hundred cases to prosecutors each month.

The Administration's strategy seems to hinge on a fantasy of radical subtraction—removing people who would dilute the country's white majority. “If you import the Third World, you become the Third World,” Miller has said. There's a model for what the government is doing: the Immigration Act of 1924, which established racial quotas that restricted immigration from southern and eastern Europe and blocked it altogether from Asia. That bill's sponsor, Senator David Reed, of Pennsylvania, promised that “America will cease to be a ‘melting pot.’ ” Nearly a century later, Miller wrote, “That is exactly what most Americans want.” At the very least, it's what the White House wants, and the President is trying to go even further, attacking the most foundational terms underlying the country's understanding of who belongs here. Revealingly, in this summer of lofty celebration, the Supreme Court is expected to issue a ruling on birthright citizenship, which Trump, by fiat, has tried to end.

The growth rate of the U.S. population is slowing, and it's conceivable, even likely, that current immigration policies will tip the country toward a steadier population decline. If returning the U.S. to 1924 is the goal, the Trump Administration is succeeding. Two hundred and fifty years into the national experiment, however, this would mean that the future looks ever more like the distant past. ♦

[Jonathan Blitzer](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker*. His book, “[Everyone Who Is Gone Is Here](#),” received the Hillman Prize and the Robert F. Kennedy Book Award in 2025.

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[Legacy Dept.](#)

From Sturgeon to Knicks Gear, Barney Greengrass Has You Covered

The Upper West Side smoked-fish establishment, beloved by Marilyn Monroe and Irving Berlin, represents the best of New York—great food, family bonds, and Jalen Brunson.

By [David Remnick](#)

June 8, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Moe Greengrass is an entrepreneurial young man of nineteen and the heir to what is arguably the finest appetizing establishment in the city. One day, he will inherit the throne at Barney Greengrass, a smoked-fish emporium on Eighty-sixth and Amsterdam, just across the street from the Belnord, a limestone pile where the late Isaac Bashevis Singer wrote his last short stories in Yiddish and rent-controlled splendor. For lunch, Singer liked the smoked lake sturgeon.

Groucho Marx, Alfred Hitchcock, Jascha Heifetz, Marilyn Monroe—they all knew from Barney Greengrass. Irving Berlin ordered four quarts of borscht there every week. In Philip Roth’s novel “Operation Shylock,” the narrator, a stand-in for Roth, requests “the chopped-herring salad on a lightly toasted onion bagel”—a credible order. James J. Frawley, a Tammany Hall pol and loyal customer in the nineteen-thirties, gave Barney Greengrass its royalist imprimatur: “The Sturgeon King.”

Moe, the sturgeon dauphin, is an impassive fellow with a fantastic shock of red hair. What he doesn’t already know about whitefish is not worth knowing. A student at N.Y.U., he can be seen in the store on weekends helping his dad, an irrepressible kibbitzer named Gary, at the register. Father and son are surrounded by clear plastic boxes of halvah, rugelach, and babka. The perfume of smoked fish—nova and sturgeon, the humble herring, the aristocratic sable—permeates the air. “Even the wallpaper smells like fish and onions,” Moe says. The beloved Greengrass wallpaper, with its incongruous scenes of old New Orleans, has been absorbing the smell for many decades. During the pandemic, Gary called in a team of decorative artists to repair the damage of time. They worked on the wallpaper as if they were reviving a faded Caravaggio.

Moe’s grandfather and namesake was both a master slicer and an amateur magician. When Moe the Elder died, in 2002, the comedian and loyal customer Paul Reiser sent the family a condolence letter in which he tenderly remarked, in Gary’s recollection, “Moe was the only man who could pull a three of clubs out of a herring’s ass.”

Barney Greengrass lands in the *Times* Top One Hundred restaurants as reliably as Atomix and Le Bernardin. Thanks to the quality of the fish, word of mouth, foreign guidebooks, and now Moe’s exertions on Instagram, there

are long lines at the door, especially on weekends. Gary took a stab at expanding years ago; he had an outlet in the now-shuttered Barneys department store, in Beverly Hills. Moe entertains far grander dreams. “I want to grow the brand,” he said, in the parlance of his studies in hospitality.



“Come on in and make yourselves at home, and try not to let all of our pet chameleons bother you.”
Cartoon by Drew Dernavich

But give him time. He is just getting started and has yet to persuade his dad to expand downtown, much less to Kentucky and Kuala Lumpur. In the short term, he is all about marketing. An avid Knicks fan, he has kept tabs on the excitement all over town—storekeepers putting televisions in their windows so people can watch on the sidewalk, fans on the subway complimenting one another on vintage jerseys. On the crosstown bus, Knicks people exchange glances, not of annoyance or seduction but of *fandom*, of common cause: “Wait’ll we get the Spurs to the Garden!” Strangers fall into hushed conversation about the state of Jalen Brunson’s knee and Mitchell Robinson’s pinkie. Predictions are offered, shy fist bumps exchanged.

Moe tuned in to the vibe and decided, “We’ve got to get in on the fun. I mean, people love us and they love the Knicks. So . . .” With Gary’s say-so, he went into action, ordering up batches of black-and-white cookies that would now be colored blue and orange. (The sugar content, along with a cup of Gary’s rocket-fuel coffee, will keep you up through the playoffs and into next season.) More imaginatively, Moe designed a T-shirt that combines the imagery of Neptune, the god of the sea, with Brunson, the lord of the Garden. They have been selling like, well, hot latkes.

“It was an honor to name Moe for Moe,” Gary said the morning after the Knicks’ big win on the road in Game 1. “My father would have kvelled about the T-shirts. He might have teased him and said, ‘What are you doing fooling around with T-shirts!’ But he would have been proud.”

As it happens, the Greengrass dynasty has a historical link to the Knicks. Irving Mitchell Felt, a developer who was instrumental in building the “new” Garden, used to come around the store and give out tickets for prime seats. Gary remembers going to the first Knicks game at the arena, in February, 1968. “I even remember the price,” he said. “Two sturgeon sandwiches and fifteen bucks. A pretty good deal.” ♦

*[David Remnick](#) has been the editor of *The New Yorker* since 1998 and a staff writer since 1992. He is the author of seven books; the most recent is “[Holding the Note](#),” a collection of his profiles of musicians.*

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[The Boards](#)

Michael Arden Catches a Flight

The theatre director's latest show, "The Lost Boys," has its actors dangle high above the stage. At an indoor-skydiving joint, it's his turn to defy gravity.

By [Zach Helfand](#)

June 8, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

The theatre director Michael Arden has a phobia of hand injuries and of flying, but you wouldn't have known it when he showed up at iFLY, an indoor-skydiving facility in Queens, the other day. Indoor skydiving involves lying prone in a vertical wind tunnel. "I was telling people at work that my biggest fear is just that I go in the tube and it doesn't work," Arden

said while signing a safety waiver. His latest show, “The Lost Boys,” which was nominated for twelve Tonys, subjects its actors to a half-dozen intricate flying sequences, including a period of dangling upside down about forty feet above the stage. The skydiving would serve as a kind of “I wouldn’t ask you to do anything I wouldn’t do” directing tactic.

Flying on Broadway is often scary. A missed mark can mean a splat. “Like, inches,” Arden said. “The other night, L.J.”—L. J. Benet, who plays the teen-age protagonist and maybe-vampire Michael—“was off his mark, and he flew up as a platform came down, and he bumped into it. He was O.K. But it’s something we really want to avoid.” Flying can also be scary for investors. In “Spider-Man: Turn Off the Dark,” which premièred in 2011, the actors kept getting injured or stuck in midair. (In the first preview, Spider-Man was left suspended above the audience, and a crewmember tried to nudge him loose with a stick, “like a live Spider-Man piñata,” the musical’s co-writer said later.) The show reportedly lost about sixty million dollars. “I did see ‘Spider-Man,’ ” Arden said. “The issue with ‘Spider-Man’ was—how do I say this? It just wasn’t a good musical.”

Arden began working on “Lost Boys” before he won Tony Awards for “Parade” and “Maybe Happy Ending.” He hadn’t seen the 1987 film version with Kiefer Sutherland, Dianne Wiest, and Jason Patric, and, when he watched it, he found himself surprisingly moved by the familial bonds. “Also, everybody was, like, the hottest they’ve ever been,” he said. In the musical, he emphasizes nontraditional families. “I was raised mostly by my dad’s parents,” he said. This was Midland, Texas, in the eighties and nineties. “I was an only grandchild. I had lots of time for a strange imagination, and I would build stages in my garage and light them. I would explain what was happening in the play, but I wouldn’t do the play because I didn’t have any actors.”

He and the crew designed the flying sequences in Las Vegas, with the company Flying by Foy. “They did the O.G. ‘Peter Pan,’ ” in 1954, Arden said. “Their technology has gotten better. It was probably originally a guy with a rope.” During the show, the stage manager monitors everything on a night-vision camera from above the stage, and a camouflaged stagehand

helps with the harnesses. “It’s literally a carpenter in a velvet ninja suit,” Arden said. “If you watch it in infrared, it’s crazy.”

It was time to fly. Arden, who wore a plaid jacket and laceless black sneakers, headed to the flying area. In the giant tube, an instructor was doing flips. “It’s like Willy Wonka,” Arden said.

The flying coach, Will, introduced himself. “I’ve done about eleven hundred jumps in the past three years, so I know a little bit about this,” he said. “Big question right off the rip: Any previous shoulder injuries?”

Will helped Arden into a red flying onesie, and he advised him to switch to laced shoes. “That’s fourteen hundred horsepower,” Will said, pointing at the tube. “I blew my Vans off a few weeks ago. One went through the return vane and came back in about a hundred pieces.”

Will told Arden that he should lie flat, like a starfish. “All we’re doing is trust-falling into the wind,” he said. “Slow movements.”

“Our mantra at work is ‘Slow is smooth, and smooth is fast,’ ” Arden said.

Will slipped a helmet onto Arden’s head and said, “These are hurricane-force winds. How are you feeling? Nervous?”

“Excited!” Arden said.

“Excited-nervous?” Will said.

“Just excited.”

“A little nerves is O.K.!”

Arden entered the tube and caught the wind. Will kept hold of him, and, eventually, he flew him up toward the top.

Emerging, Arden said, “I didn’t expect that we were going up right away. I was, like, ‘Oh, shit!’ ” After a rest, Arden went in again, and Will showed him how he could turn just by angling his hands. He spun around like a helicopter rotor.

In his acceptance speech for his first Tony, in 2023, Arden recounted being a bullied queer theatre kid in Texas, and then said, “All I can say is that now I’m a faggot with a Tony.” Post-flying, Arden said, “I was more nervous making that speech. *That* was terrifying.” ♦

[Zach Helfand](#) is a staff writer at *The New Yorker*.

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[Paris Postcard](#)

Inside the Creative Cavern of JR

Riding in his custom-designed car on the Orient Express, the French artist reflects on his latest large-scale project—turning the Pont Neuf into a giant inflatable cave.

By [Lauren Collins](#)

June 8, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Somewhere between Venice and Paris, just as afternoon tea was served—raspberry tartlets and biscotti squisiti, coffee poured from silver ewers into porcelain cups—JR, the French artist known for his public installations, was starting to freak out. He wasn't panicking and, in fact, maintained a façade as smooth and zippy as any of the trompe-l'oeil murals with which

he has wrapped famous buildings around the world. Yet, as the Venice Simplon-Orient-Express barrelled west, through the Dolomites to Colico and Bergün and Brenner Pass, he contemplated the risks inherent in his latest project. He would begin installing it shortly after the train pulled into the Gare de l'Est.

The piece is called “La Caverne du Pont Neuf” (“The Pont Neuf Cave”). It was to be free to the public, accessible twenty-four hours a day, and would open forty-one years after Christo and Jeanne-Claude wrapped the same bridge, the city’s oldest, in more than forty thousand square metres of luminous nylon. “I have to say, I never dared to dream of the Pont Neuf,” JR admitted. “I wouldn’t even think of doing it.” He was sitting, legs tucked under him, on a sinuous tangerine-colored velvet banquette in the Observatory, a bucket-list carriage of his own design. It wasn’t that he was afraid that no one would come to the cave. It was that he was sure they would—in droves, and expecting the sort of ecstatic collective experience that the Paris Olympics delivered so ably, in 2024.

“You’ll have a generation of people who will remember it,” JR said. “It’s not the kind of thing where people say, ‘Oh, really? Maybe I was there.’ No, everybody says, ‘I know exactly where I was when I saw it.’ ” As the commander of a sort of public-art moon landing, he needed to make every memory bounce.

JR usually creates things that you look *at* rather than into. But, early on, he decided to approach “La Caverne” as a piece of sculpture. He wanted height. He wanted volume. He wanted scaffolding, until he realized that was a horrible idea. “Where are you gonna find that?” he said. “Buildings reserve scaffolding for years ahead. You’d have to get it in from all over Europe, and then what?” Then he had an epiphany: he could build with air. The result is a giant inflatable structure, fabricated by Air Toiles Concept, a company out of Plougoumelen, in Brittany, that makes blow-up trophies for sporting events like Indian Premier cricket and the *FIFA* Arab Cup. (Funding comes from the sale of JR’s works and from corporate partners.) Visitors can walk its length, entering at Île de la Cité and exiting in front of La Samaritaine. The cave motif has been a through line of JR’s work—in 2019, he “excavated” the courtyard of the Louvre. “When you look back in

time, you realize that the only myth we all believed in was the fact that humans and animals came from caves and cracks in the earth,” he said. “Today, our caves are our phones.”

A cave-raising is a political endeavor as much as an artistic one. In public art, much like in public life, you have to build a coalition in order to get anything done. “We started with Anne Hidalgo, and she said, right away, ‘I’ll do it,’ ” JR recalled, referring to Paris’s former mayor. (Her term ended just before the project’s inauguration, so, to be safe, JR met with the other candidates during election season.) One meeting united more than seventy stakeholders, including the fire and police chiefs. Another presentation was devoted to assuaging the worries of the city’s *bouquiniste* union. Without the buy-in of these bureaucrats and booksellers, JR said, “La Caverne” never would have made it off the factory floor. “They came together and really took me by the hand,” he said. Merci to the Deep State, Municipal Summer-Fun Division.

A few months earlier, JR had performed a trial run in a hangar at Orly Airport. The practice cave had inflated properly, but it was still impossible to predict how, exactly, the piece would take shape on site. “You never know how the light will hit,” he said. (Ultimately, it was the wind that proved to be volatile, ripping tears in the inflatable wrapping that has delayed the opening.) Now there were twenty-one hours till the train would pull into the station. JR would start construction at 9 A.M. the next day. For the moment, he gazed out the window, blue rocks and green fields smearing past. “So, from then to the end of June, I’m in this long cave,” he said. “Eight hundred people are working on it, and what I love about it is that I’ve always created projects I can’t do myself.” If you thought about it, the train was also a kind of cave. ♦

Lauren Collins has been a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2008. Her books include “[They Stole a City: Wilmington’s White Supremacist Coup and the Families Who Live with Its Legacy](#)” (July, 2026).

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[Live in Concert](#)

Kurt Vile Gets the Feeling

On the heels of his tenth album, “Philadelphia’s Been Good to Me,” the musician catches a show at Le Poisson Rouge and reminisces on how Beck and Pavement ignited his passion for live music.

By [Nick Paumgarten](#)

June 8, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Most years, Kurt Vile, the recording artist, plays months’ worth of gigs, either with his band, the Violators, or with various friends and idols, so he’s on the road a ton. But home is Philadelphia, as it’s been for all but a couple of his forty-six years. The name of his latest album, his tenth, is “Philadelphia’s Been Good to Me.”

One of the ways Philadelphia's been good to him is by being close to New York. "I benefit from coming here and not having to pay the rent," he said recently. He was sitting in a corner of Old Rabbit Club, a bar on MacDougal Street, drinking a non-alcoholic beer. He had on a Waylon Jennings T-shirt under a red plaid shirt, and an MF Doom baseball cap that contained a cascade of curly hair that Vile has a tendency to hide behind. A beer-menu lamplight suggested that the color of his Chuck Taylors was lavender. He was hanging out late (a) to make the trip down the turnpike at midnight ("Musicians know, it's an easy shot late at night—it's like teleportation") and (b) to catch another band's gig at Le Poisson Rouge. "In some ways, I like to go to shows more than play. I get the feeling. I'm a fanboy first.

"I can tell you every show I've been to," he said. "My first show, which is a little embarrassing, was on my fourteenth birthday-ish, the Counting Crows at the Tower Theatre. But it was on the day of that show that me and my brother, the one just under me"—Vile has nine siblings—"first heard 'Loser' on the radio. I called in—it was WDRE, the alternative station—and said, 'Can I hear that 'Loser' song again?' The guy was, like, 'Beck! You want to hear Beck!' " That summer, Vile saw Beck perform, on the Lollapalooza tour, along with Pavement, Hole, Sonic Youth, and Cypress Hill, whose music he'd been listening to on a Walkman while skateboarding. He was hooked.

"Before the pandemic, I was so busy with the family"—he and his wife have two teen-age daughters and live in the neighborhood of Mt. Airy—"I didn't know how to leave the house. But the pandemic taught me how important shows are. There are so many people putting out records and touring. It's competitive." He maintains a wall calendar with upcoming concerts and reckons that, if he writes one in, "ninety-nine per cent I'm going." That's a strong N.F.A. (Non-Flake Average) for a middle-aged dad. "As long as there's something up ahead, I won't go insane," he said.

He made his way over to Le Poisson Rouge, on Bleecker Street. The act tonight was the Messthetics, a punk-prog-jazz outfit, featuring the drummer and the bassist from Fugazi (Brendan Canty and Joe Lally), a guitar wizard

(Anthony Pirog), and a sax man (James Brandon Lewis). Vile greeted Canty and Lally at the merch table and then found a spot at the back.

“I think last time I was here was fourteen years ago. J Mascis and Mike Watt were doing a Stooges thing. I got up and sang that song ‘No Fun.’ When I was done, Watt hollered into the mike, ‘No buns, Kurt Vile! No buns!’ ” They were busting on his skinny ass.

The Messthetics came on. “All right, we’re going to play,” the drummer said.

Vile popped in a pair of earplugs. After ten minutes, he darted off, then reappeared. “Come this way,” he said. “Guitar sounds better over there.” He was correct. When Pirog played a flashy line, which was often, Vile let out a cackle, an impish, cowpoke whoopee ti-yi-yo. “This guy sends you to the clouds!” he said. As Pirog’s guitar let out an atonal howl, Vile held up his phone to record it: “Always roll tape.”

The Messthetics went at it for ninety minutes. No one seemed to notice Vile. Afterward, he gave his compliments to the band but didn’t hang out, as he typically would. He said that certain acts made him tear up (he cited a recent Adam Sandler gig), but the Messthetics wasn’t that vibe. “This was more like transporting noise. I get chills, but it doesn’t make me cry.”

Outside, he met up with his guitar tech, who was doubling as his driver. There was stuff up ahead—the calendar entries, and rehearsals with the Violators, in preparation for a tour. (“I was anxious about playing the new stuff, but this record is bonehead simple,” Vile said.) Also, the next evening, a can’t-flake performance of “Chicago,” with his daughter Awilda in the ensemble. He recalled a night in Nashville, years ago, with John Prine and Billy Ray Cyrus, who told Vile, about Awilda, “Listen, man. I’ve got bad news. That one’s got charisma. You’re in trouble.”

Home before daylight: Vile and the guitar tech commenced turnpike teleportation protocol. ♦

[Nick Paumgarten](#), a staff writer, has contributed to The New Yorker since 2000.

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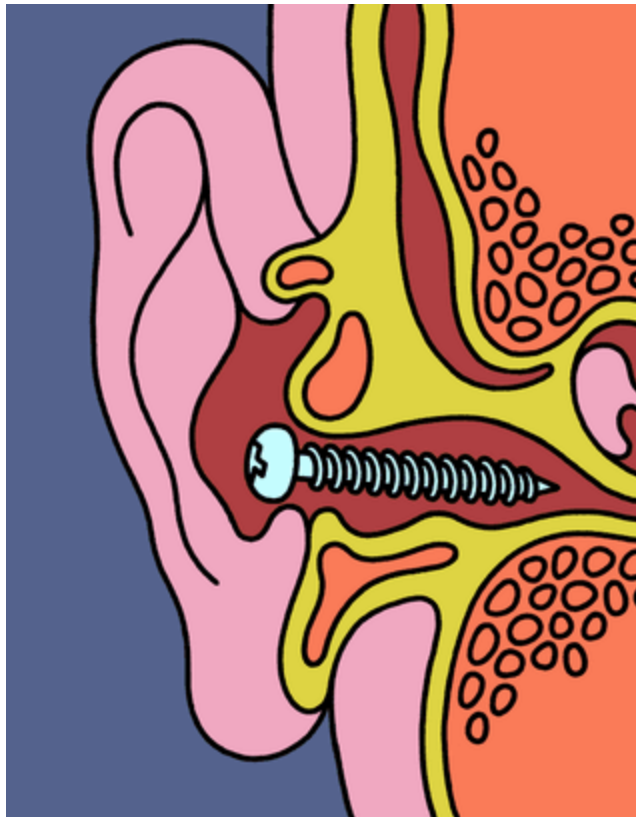
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For People with Misophonia, Everyday Noises Can Be Agony

The neurophysiological disorder is characterized by a severe aversion to sound—and the struggle to convince others of the severity of that aversion.

By [Sloane Crosley](#)

June 8, 2026



According to one study, 4.6 per cent of U.S. adults could have misophonia. Illustration by Miguel Porlan

[Edgar Allan Poe's](#) story "The Tell-Tale Heart" was inspired by a shocking crime with a predictable motive. On the morning of April 7, 1830, in Salem, Massachusetts, Captain Joseph White, aged eighty-two, was found in his bed, bludgeoned and stabbed in the heart. Two distant relatives of White's, a

pair of brothers, had stolen White's will and hired a hit man to kill him. The hit man then hanged himself after he was apprehended. (It was during the brothers' trial that the prosecutor, Daniel Webster, uttered the infamous words "murder will out.") In Poe's gothic retelling, our murderer's motivation is as murky as the cataract in the victim's eye. There are no obvious justifications, financial or otherwise. After dispatching his elderly neighbor, the speaker gives himself up to the police, who he's convinced are pretending not to hear the source of his torment, the incessant beating of the dead man's heart—a "low, dull, quick sound." For most readers, "The Tell-Tale Heart" is a story of madness and guilt. For someone with misophonia, it's a story of restraint. Our triggered hero makes it through a whole interrogation before he starts ripping up the floorboards.

Misophonia is a neurophysiological disorder broadly characterized by two things: a severe aversion to sound and a struggle to convince others of the severity of that aversion. Nameless until the start of this century, when the husband-and-wife neuroscientists Pawel and Margaret Jastreboff coined the term, the condition has become exponentially better known in recent years. In 2024, a study led by the University of Mississippi estimated that 4.6 per cent of U.S. adults met the criteria for misophonia. Loop, a manufacturer of earplugs, markets a range of options to consumers with the condition. The International Misophonia Foundation, a nonprofit, sells six different shades of a "*shh . . . I have misophonia*" phone case. SoQuiet, another misophonia nonprofit, has forty-four apparel options that transmit a similar message.

Subclinical or mild misophonia is so common that there are myriad Reddit threads populated by amateur sufferers, many of whom could not sit through Dennis Quaid slurping shrimp in "[The Substance](#)" but feel a parasocial connection to Daniel Day-Lewis's sonically fussy character in "[Phantom Thread](#)." They, too, wince at the sound of breakfast being consumed. Others can't stand the sound of gulping. Still others would like to chuck lozenges at phlegmy strangers. One of the problems with the condition is that it overlaps with the human condition. During colonial times, people audibly churned butter and spun flax with a heavy foot. [Marcel Proust](#) is not on Reddit, but he did once write a letter to his neighbor, in which he asked her if it would be possible "either to nail the

crates this evening, or else not to nail them tomorrow until starting at 4 or 5 o'clock in the afternoon."

Today, in a time with the loosest definition of trauma of any period in history, it can be especially difficult to parse personality from pathology. Who among us has not experienced an inability to ignore repetitive tapping, clicking, chewing, smacking, and sniffing? Who among us has not lain awake, our consciousness pinched to attention by the nefarious silences between snores, with our earplugs like fallen soldiers on the battlefield of sanity? Who among us has not asked herself: how many potato chips could possibly be in one bag?

What differentiates misophonia from simply being alive is that it's not just about sound. It's about how certain brains process that sound. Poe's narrator insists that "what you mistake for madness is but over-acuteness of the senses." Fiction may demand a macabre deference to this princess and his milky-eyed pea, but people living with misophonia are not defined by heightened auditory perception. Nor do they necessarily have hyperacusis (decreased tolerance to sound volume). Nor are they abnormally attuned to the acoustic properties of sound. Instead, they share a dysregulating visceral response, a cognitive and physiological—chest-tightening, heart-racing, sweating—spiral of alertness and exhaustion more commonly known as "fight or flight."

The clinical psychologist Jane Gregory, in her jaunty book, "[Sounds Like Misophonia](#)," affectionately refers to this segment of the population as "meerkats." The internet may be full of people who want to outlaw leaf blowers, but misophonic triggers tend to share a bodily quality, an aurally traceable culprit such as a person crunching or sighing. A threat from one creature to another. The cerebral circuitry of the human brain—specifically the salience network, which is responsible for filtering stimuli—seems to be more active in individuals with misophonia. [Cognitive-behavioral therapy](#) (C.B.T.) can help with this, just as it can with other disorders that have a sensory-processing component, such as A.D.H.D. or P.T.S.D. But there is no pill for misophonia and no such thing as exposure therapy for instinct. The afflicted are left with a medical-grade inability to just suck it up and, for now, no officially recognized diagnosis.

I belong to a profession to which one can attribute a need for silence. [Joan Didion](#), in her memoir “[Blue Nights](#),” transcribes her daughter’s list of “Mom’s sayings”: “Brush your teeth, brush your hair, shush I’m working.” If you’re a Didion fetishist, this intolerance for disruption might be considered a feature, not a bug. For my part, I’ve always been envious of writers who can focus despite unwelcome sounds, who do not feel betrayed by their ears when they catch the bass of a television speaker. Writers who do not assign blame to noise. I can tell when my carpet-phobic neighbors are wearing heels or boots and remain in awe of their dedication to transferring dirt from the outside of their apartment to the inside of their apartment.

While I have long suspected that I have some degree of misophonia, to live in [New York City](#) is to live at a diagnostic impasse, as with many other afflictions. Are you depressed, or have you spent too much time inside that dark studio that you can’t afford? Is it perimenopause, or should you not be sleeping next to a heating pipe? Is it that sensory-processing disorder you read about, or is it the 8.5 million people with whom you share your city?

In January, the Duke Center for Misophonia and Emotion Regulation hosted a webinar, led by Zach Rosenthal, a professor and a clinical psychologist who would love to see misophonia released from medical purgatory. Rosenthal founded the center, part of the Duke University School of Medicine, in 2018; in addition to misophonia, he and his team also study misokinesia, a condition that was first named in a 2013 study by the Dutch psychiatrist Arjan Schröder. Misokinesia is an aversion to movements in the absence of sound. Very rarely, it can present in isolation, but, like misophonia itself, it’s usually a problem within a problem: if the sound of sipping bothers you, the sight of it likely does, too.

The webinar’s attendees were a mix of researchers, patients, and the parents of children who are grappling with misophonia. As the session began, a message popped up onscreen, directed from one attendee to another: “Lisa M. please stop chewing or turn off camera, thanks.” Everyone was already on mute. Still, to engage in a trigger-associated movement was a bold choice. Chewing gum on a misophonia Zoom is like bringing a knife to a balloon flight.

Rosenthal structures misophonic symptoms according to the acronym *BASIC*: behavioral (escape and avoidance), attentional (vigilance and distractibility), somatic (physical hyperarousal), interpersonal (inhibition, indirect aggression), and cognitive, which can be “sliced into internalizing cognitions versus externalizing cognitions,” he told me. “Either it’s my fault—I’m bad, I’m broken, I’m terrible. Shame, shame, shame. Or it’s your fault—you’re bad, you’re terrible. Anger, anger, anger.” When we spoke after the webinar, he was quick to point out that there is no “E” in *BASIC*. Thrown by the simplicity of this pronouncement, I took a moment to scan the word. His story checked out. But I wondered why he was so adamant about keeping “E,” as in “emotion,” off his list of symptoms when a feature of misophonia is an emotional response.

“Because emotion is not simply one thing,” he explained to me. “It occurs across all the letters. It includes behavior. When we get angry, we have strong underlying biological responses, full stop. You can’t divorce emotion from biology.”

I had not planned on divorcing anything from anything, but Rosenthal is accustomed to the world’s tendency to pigeonhole misophonia, to paint the condition as a manufactured malady and those who live with it as hysterics.

“This is a phenomenon that does not fit into any one clinical discipline, but people want to stick baby in a corner,” he added.

During the webinar, Rosenthal noted an accomplishment of the previous year: the establishment of a World Misophonia Awareness Day, on July 9th, in memory of Michelle Del Valle, a teen-ager from Orlando who died by suicide in 2023, after struggling with misophonia. In addition to the center’s evergreen goal of raising awareness, Rosenthal is hoping that 2026 will be the year that misophonia is finally recognized with a code by the International Statistical Classification of Diseases and Related Health Problems, or I.C.D. Developed by the World Health Organization, the I.C.D. is a global concern, separate from the [*Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders*](#), or *DSM*, a U.S. publication that classifies psychiatric conditions. The *DSM* is more widely known in the States, and sometimes deployed as a barb (i.e., “So-and-So should have their own entry in the *DSM*”). Misophonia might appear in the *DSM* eventually, but, for

now, the focus of the misophonia community is the I.C.D., which is used by pediatricians and primary-care doctors. Rosenthal submitted the proposal arguing for its inclusion.

Misophonia is often diagnosed alongside anxiety, A.D.H.D., and O.C.D., which do have official diagnoses. But, Rosenthal said, “If misophonia is the only diagnosis people meet criteria for, it will enable them to receive treatment with it as the sole diagnosis. If it’s in the I.C.D., it becomes an option in the medical industry’s drop-down menus. It becomes a real thing.”

Lucia Lara, an occupational therapist in Seattle who focusses on pediatric sensory-processing disorders—she recently treated an eighth grader who had to contend with a class science experiment involving bouncing Ping-Pong balls—echoes Rosenthal’s beliefs: the code won’t alter what she does, she stressed, but, when it comes to health insurance, “those codes are important to facilitating the reimbursement process.”

For Jen Dotur, a mental-health counsellor in Alaska whose husband and eldest daughter both have misophonia, an I.C.D. entry is symbolic as well as practical. “It validates that misophonia takes up a real part of people’s lives,” she said. “I think when something isn’t coded, it almost feels like it’s invisible.”

The W.H.O. does not comment on the status of proposals beyond confirming that, indeed, a proposal is under review. But even among those who acknowledge misophonia as an identifiable condition, there is not unanimous support for its inclusion in either the I.C.D. or the *DSM*. Steven Taylor, a clinical psychologist and a professor at the University of British Columbia who specializes in anxiety disorders, told me that misophonia “doesn’t fit neatly in either the psychiatric or audiological realm,” which makes it all the more challenging to classify it in an official capacity.

“There’s still a lot that needs to be learned,” he told me, “and I think it’s premature to stick it in the I.C.D. at this point. I would like to see a little more consensus in the field about what this disorder actually is. Do we put it in an audiological coding manual? Do we put it in a psychiatric manual? Do we put it somewhere else?”

Elizabeth Levine, a twenty-two-year-old pharmacology student at the University of Connecticut, remembers the day that she became aware of her misophonia. So does her twin sister, because they experienced their first trigger “at the same time, the same moment,” Levine told me. The twins were twelve years old and riding in a car with their father when he began tapping his fingers on the dashboard. Levine tried to ignore it, but eventually she couldn’t take it anymore and complained. Her sister followed suit. (According to Rosenthal, there is, as yet, no obvious genetic cause of misophonia, but it can run in families.) A short while later, both girls found themselves so bothered by the sound of their father’s eating that they left the house. “Evidently, we both just walked out and closed the door,” Levine said.

At first, the twins’ parents hoped the girls would get over it—their avoidance was hurting their father’s feelings—but, luckily, they each received an early diagnosis. Levine, who has also been diagnosed with O.C.D., categorizes her symptoms as “through-the-roof severe,” especially compared with her sister, who has a milder case and whose triggers tend to be generated by their mother and, in a croquet-like turn, Levine herself. Levine’s reaction to a triggering sound is instant: “As soon as I hear it, the response is activated. Like, danger, you know? I feel incredible agitation. Basically, I’m holding my breath. I need to tell someone to stop it right away or bolt out of the room. I guess it’s intense rage and panic. It’s kind of hard to compare it to something.”



Cartoon by Liana Finck

Levine has tried C.B.T., talk therapy, E.M.D.R. (eye-movement desensitization and reprocessing), and SSRIs to treat her misophonia. She no longer goes to restaurants because it's "borderline insanity" with all the clicking and scraping. Cafeterias are better because the noise tends to be more background in nature. She and her sister, also a student, live at home, where the utensil franca is plastic. She eats dinner alone in her room. Libraries are not so great because of the way sound carries, coupled with visual stimuli. In class, she wears both noise-cancelling headphones and hearing aids that pick up sound from a microphone on her professor's desk so that she can listen to lectures.

According to Jen Dotur, Levine's scenario, where "a group of people are shifting an entire system around one person," is not uncommon for severe cases. This can often lead to resentment, though Levine's immediate family has been understanding, she told me. But sometimes she has to explain herself to strangers or classmates.

"It's really confusing to them," she said. "I say I have hearing issues. I can't tell them I have misophonia, because no one knows what that is. They don't get it. 'My eating bothers you?' "

"I'm never able to fully just be present," she said, sighing, "I can't just walk into places and be excited or happy. It's done a number on my over-all mood."

"It's like nails on a chalkboard," a fortysomething special-education teacher with misophonia told me. "That's what it feels like, a thousand times a day. Every time, it's brand new, you never unlearn it. Maybe a thousand times a day is an exaggeration—a couple hundred." These moments are followed, the teacher said, by feelings of guilt and shame: "What's wrong with me? Why can't I be better?" The teacher—I'll call him Nick Blackburn—has never divulged his condition to his employer.

Blackburn's misophonia was a factor in his recent divorce; he tried to "preserve the nature of the marriage and sleep in the same bed," he said, but he couldn't. He has slightly more control in the classroom, particularly when he can tuck some helpful strictures under the blanket of test-taking etiquette (no chewing gum, no crinkling of water bottles). Blackburn

acknowledges the irony of devoting his life to people with special needs while masking his own, but, he said, “the fear of being let go” wins out.

“I have a very meaningful job,” he continued. “I take pride in that. So I try my damndest to be as functional as possible. I think it gives me a purpose.”

Blackburn’s misophonia manifests mostly as avoidance. It’s a struggle that’s only increased after he was recently moved into a shared office space. He steers clear of group situations with his colleagues, for example, and uses headphones, he said, “to isolate myself, essentially.” If he spots someone chewing gum in a car next to him during his commute, he stares straight ahead.

In a way, Blackburn is the poster child for an I.C.D. code (even if he would never appear on the poster). He shares two young children with his ex-wife, and his kids try to give him a heads-up if they’re going to “do a big sniff.” A warning takes the edge off the trigger.

“I have brought misophonia up with medical professionals, who say it’s not in the books: ‘There’s nothing we can do. You’re making it up,’ ” he told me. “Or they try to prescribe medications to deal with the symptoms instead of the cause. So I was paying co-pays and deductibles to educate these people, and, since I could hear clearly, an audiologist wouldn’t provide the right documentation to get ear devices covered. The insurance companies were, like, No, but you can hear.”

But what if he couldn’t? Or, rather, what if he could pick and choose? Shyam Gollakota, a Seattle-based co-founder of multiple startups, leads the Mobile Intelligence Lab at the University of Washington. He specializes in what could be called tiny tech, such as sensors he developed, in 2020, that helped combat an infestation of murder hornets in Washington State by enabling the tracking of the invasive creatures to their nests. In 2023, he co-authored a paper on what he dubbed “semantic hearing,” or “a novel capability for hearable devices that enables them to, in real-time, focus on, or ignore, specific sounds from real-world environments.” Gollakota was inspired by a lifelong sensitivity to noise and, more specifically, visits to his parents’ house in India. Every time he’s there, he becomes overwhelmed by

the sounds of cars honking and dogs barking. “I’m, like, How are you people able to sleep?” he told me.

The paper caught the attention of Zach Rosenthal, at Duke, and their collaboration led to Gollakota’s receiving a grant from a charitable foundation, the Misophonia Research Fund, to “enhance noise-canceling headphones that selectively remove triggering sounds.” Instead of designing headphones that allow users to toggle between degrees of sound transparency, an option that Gollakota considers limited, he and his team are using machine learning to develop headphones that augment auditory perception and can quickly target and eliminate irksome audio—an enticing notion for anyone with a short fuse. Gollakota is partial to the scenario of someone sitting on a bench, listening to chirping birds, and being intruded upon by loud talkers. Leave the birdsong, take the chatter.

In addition, his system can create “bubbles” that filter sound by proximity. If you’re standing in line and the person behind you is talking more loudly than the person you’re with, the more distant person, Gollakota said enthusiastically, can be “completely removed.”

Those living with misophonia aside, I wonder if people *should* be able to do this. The mere suggestion of isolating and extracting the thud of my neighbor’s footfalls is a dream that dare not speak its name, but should we be able to tailor our immediate environments more than we already do? So much of today’s technology is built for self-siloing. Should we be handed another gadget that could handicap our social skills? Gollakota smiled and brought up G.P.S. Would I deprive myself of G.P.S.? No, I would not.

Besides, given the nuanced nature of misophonia, technology is not likely to be a magic A.I. wand. Nick Blackburn maintains skepticism about new tools. The hope that “this is going to solve all my problems” can be poisonous, he told me, because some trigger always makes it past the headphones. And his ears can’t protect his eyes from sound-associated movements. Plus, the promise of selective silence puts someone with misophonia in a heightened state of anticipation. Imagine the broken contract of a train’s “quiet car.” Now add physical torment. It’s why Elizabeth Levine finds libraries so troublesome.

By and large, people with acute misophonia want to flee the source of their torture, not attack it. Anger does not necessitate assault. Yet the association with rage may be misophonia's fastest-growing stigma, especially among those who don't have it. This emphasis on Hulk-smash hostility could be viewed as an effort on the part of the general population to differentiate misophonia from better-known disorders (as a rule, one can aggravate a person with A.D.H.D. without ducking). But sometimes this connection is propagated within the community itself to make a salient point about a complex condition.

One recently self-diagnosed friend told me that he can no longer dine with his nonagenarian father without wanting to "rip his face off." Even SoQuiet sells a "misophonia death glare" shirt, featuring a cat with rainbow laser beams shooting out of its eyes. In December, the actress January Jones took to Instagram to film herself hiding from her chip-chomping brother-in-law. She confessed to a lifelong struggle with misophonia and deemed his behavior "very dangerous" ("What I didn't do today was record this video inside a prison.") Her irritation is palpable, and the video is tongue-in-cheek, so to speak, but it's also illustrative of the sort of syndrome fetishization that goes on in certain coastal cities.

"Once a clinical condition becomes widely known," U.B.C.'s Steven Taylor told me, "people will tend to self-diagnose or over-diagnose. Self-awareness is important but if you over-diagnose misophonia, including the more minor symptoms, you run the risk of trivializing the condition."

Levine has observed an uptick in stolen valor: "When people say they have misophonia, like, 'Oh, I have that too . . .' No, you don't. My misophonia is an actual, severe, life-altering condition, 24/7, since I was twelve."

I nodded along but wondered what she would make of me, a person who would prefer to never again hear someone eat an apple. (There's a scene in the 1991 film "Sleeping with the Enemy," during which an actress chooses to make open-mouth gnashing part of her character, and it chills me just to refer to it.) "Prefer" is not part of Levine's vocabulary. But Rosenthal allows for a more generous definition of impairment: "If you think of misophonia as a disease that you either have or don't, and there is no in-

between, you come up with a really different answer than if you think about it the way I think it actually is, which is more of a dimensional spectrum.”

Alas, we do not live in a clinical trial. So it’s easy to understand Levine’s hard line regarding who does and does not have an affliction that’s altered her life. We live in a culture of story-usurpers and one-uppers, of empathy expressed through mirror experiences, if expressed at all. It’s a tough spot to be in for people with misophonia, to have a problem that’s both widely claimed and widely dismissed. If the goal is to raise awareness, the best course of action is probably to let the subclinical cases be counted. But how can this not dilute the credit for the suffering of those who have to contend with severe misophonia? Why should they cede the field to the junior-varsity team?

As a self-identifying member of the J.V. team who has never sought professional help (not for misophonia, at least), I have come to believe that grating noises land in whatever part of my brain is responsible for processing judgment. Probably all of it. But my lowest tolerance has always been for movement: the sight of someone rapidly shaking their leg results in a blazing, uncategorizable feeling akin to revulsion, and nothing can stop it, not even the sure knowledge that glaring is a sign of age.

I have tried to outsmart it. I’ve been known to leave movie theatres packed with visible fidgeters and pace in the lobby until I’m ready to go back in and try again—a slightly more challenging prospect on an airplane. Recently, I went to a restaurant with a friend who was telling me about her breakup. She had her chair pulled snug against the table; I was seated in a banquette, flush to the wall. A few tables down, a fellow-diner vibrated our shared piece of furniture, jiggling his legs as if he’d forgotten all about them. Which he probably had, since leg-shaking is often subconscious. I made my friend switch seats with me so that I could listen to what she was saying.

SoQuiet offers distributable cards for people with misophonia and misokinesia, so that they can explain their situation to strangers. This form of self-advocacy may work for some, but such a card strikes me as a wild thing to have in one’s possession—forget showing people that you have it. Nick Blackburn agrees: “You hand somebody a card and the fear is ‘Go

fuck yourself.’ ” But my deeper issue is what’s printed on the card: “You are doing nothing wrong.”

The fallacy of any annoyance is that it robs you of something positive, that you were bopping merrily along when the beeping began. More often, it robs you of the right to worry about what you find worrisome. It chooses for you. Man-made irritation, in particular, poses a question: Do other people have anything to do with me, or not? Are we living on a shared planet that requires baseline acceptance of one another’s corporeal being, or are we not? Buddhists, socialists, and epidemiologists would say yes. As would I, in the abstract. But when presented with a shaking appendage, my answer is no. No, that person has nothing to do with me. At which point, I’m tempted to smack the leg of a stranger so hard that their mama will feel it.

“But it’s not the other person’s fault,” Rosenthal told me when I asked him about this. “They are just breathing. They’re just eating their food normally. They’re not doing anything actually wrong in any sense of the term, morally, ethically, legally.”

“Counterpoint,” I offered. “They are.”

My righteous belief in fault, not hostile but negligent, is a telltale sign that, to whatever extent I have misophonia, it’s manageable. When you find yourself on the business end of this spectrum, fault is the least of your concerns. People living with severe misophonia want to change themselves before they want to change anyone else. As for misokinesia, I don’t associate leg-shaking with the sound it makes. According to Rosenthal, this means I might have to find a different scapegoat for my outsized reaction. He gave me the parallel example of hair-twirling, a habit that many people find “anywhere from annoying to extremely aversive,” but which does not fall under the banner of misophonia.

As a mind-set, fault “doesn’t even pop up” for Levine. Blackburn, too, is hesitant to “force people to adjust how they are because of me.” He asked, “What are we going to do? Put signs up in every doctor’s office that say ‘If you have to cough, leave the room’? I mean, that seems absurd.”

Perhaps the gene I should be searching for in myself is not one that lends itself to misophonia but one that lends itself to grace. Every once in a while, Blackburn will come across a student who is exhibiting signs of misophonia. He is faced with a dilemma. The parents of the student will “very reluctantly” approach him about their child’s troubling reactions to everyday sounds, because, as the child’s teacher, he is the person they’d approach. But they don’t know what they’re approaching him *with*. Under normal circumstances, Blackburn is hesitant to give himself away. But, in such situations, he feels obligated to share his story. He recalled one afternoon in which he found himself sitting across from a pair of parents after school as they all cried with relief, together.

“They thought, Wow, you’re a functioning adult. There’s hope for my child,” he said. “But, more importantly, I then connected with the kid. Because we really do feel like we’re alone in this.” ♦

[Sloane Crosley](#) is the author of the 2024 memoir “[Grief Is for People](#).”

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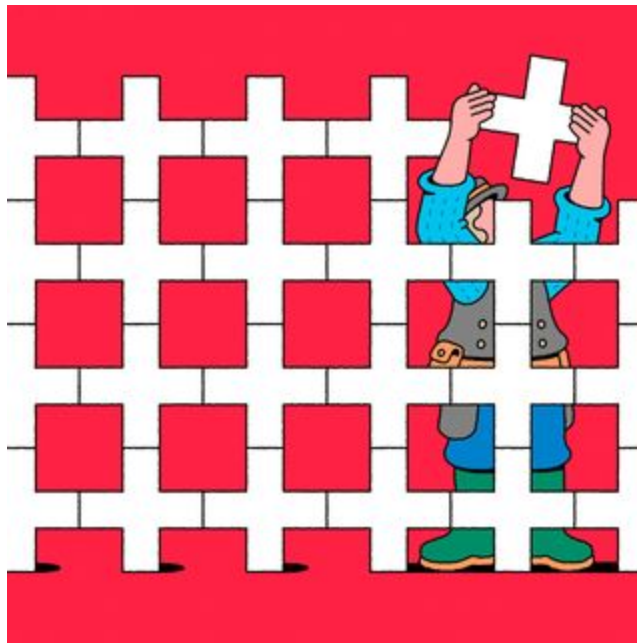
[Letter from Maienfeld](#)

Could Switzerland Become the First Country to Cap Its Population?

The Swiss will soon go to the polls for a novel initiative that could upend the nation's economy and rupture ties with the European Union.

By [Jessi Jezewska Stevens](#)

June 8, 2026



The initiative has been couched in environmental terms, but its first target would be people in the country's asylum system. Illustration by Till Lauer

Once upon a time, in the town of Maienfeld, high up in the Swiss Alps, there lived an orphan with a heart of gold. A cruel aunt sent her off to seek her fortune in crowded, sooty Frankfurt, but city life nearly killed her, so she was swiftly returned to the fresh mountain air.

Since then, the world has come to Heidi. From the train station in Maienfeld, near the border with Liechtenstein, a footpath leads up to Heididorf, a reproduction of the idyllic farm where Johanna Spyri's beloved children's novel—named for its protagonist and published in 1880—is set. On a cold Saturday in late March, two women from Hong Kong hiked up to pay homage to the nineteen-seventies Japanese anime adaptation, which in East Asia has made "Heidi" nearly as famous as "Harry Potter." A family of five from Kerala, India, asked me to take their photograph as they posed against the jagged peaks. The hills resounded with Spanish as another family descended to a "Heidi"-themed restaurant, whose parking lot accommodates double-decker tour buses.

At the base of the mountain, elected representatives from across Switzerland were arriving for a convention whose agenda stood at odds with this international scene. Colorful lawn signs, erected outside a sports center, read "*Keine 10-Millionen Schweiz!*" ("No to a Switzerland with 10 Million!")

On June 14th, Switzerland will vote on whether to become the only country in the world to officially cap its population, with a limit of ten million people until 2050. (The current population is 9.1 million.) The initiative, which was put forward by the Swiss People's Party (S.V.P.) and in recent polls has been supported by as many as fifty-two per cent of respondents, would require the government to curb growth through two main measures. The first, triggered as soon as Switzerland exceeds 9.5 million inhabitants, would lead to restrictions in the areas of asylum and family reunification. If the population surpasses ten million for two consecutive years, the second measure would kick in, requiring the termination of the Free Movement of Persons agreement, which allows citizens of the European Union to work, study, and live in Switzerland (and vice versa). This move would rupture Switzerland's relations with the E.U., its closest partner in trade and security. "The whole package of bilateral agreements would be at stake," Michael Siegenthaler, a labor economist at the public university E.T.H. Zurich, said. "It's quite likely that the European Union would cancel all of them." A population ceiling is more or less unprecedented; the closest comparison might be conservation laws that limit human settlement in ecologically fragile places like the Galápagos Islands.

Switzerland is a direct democracy, in which every federal law is subject to popular vote. Like all of the country's political parties, the S.V.P. convenes several times a year to define its positions on upcoming initiatives—including those which it has proposed itself, like the population measure. In the Maienfeld sports hall, rows of tables extended the length of a basketball court, and waiters weaved among them, balancing trays of coffee and nut torte. The seating arrangement was by canton (the equivalent, in Switzerland's intensely federal system, of an American state), and centerpieces bore the coat of arms of each. Next to Geneva's emblem of an eagle and a St. Peter key, three delegates shared a midmorning bottle of red wine.

Jars of honey that were being sold for a Party fund-raiser came with a warning label: "The EU wants in on our honey pots!" A hundred and twenty thousand Europeans moved to Switzerland last year, drawn by its high wages and quality of life, and four hundred thousand more commute from France, Germany, Austria, Italy, and Liechtenstein. It is this abundant migration which the S.V.P., a right-wing party, hopes to stop.

A brass band accompanied the singing of the national anthem, and then the Party's vice-president, Thomas Matter, widely regarded as the pioneer of the population cap, took the stage. "Our citizens," he announced, "have finally had enough."

In a country as prosperous as Switzerland, one could be forgiven for asking, Enough of what?

The alpine traditionalism on display at Heididorf notwithstanding, Switzerland is among the most cosmopolitan nations in Europe. More than thirty per cent of its permanent residents were born abroad. The working-age population is increasing, owing to consistent employment growth and a steady flow of migrants who are often highly skilled and actively recruited, and tend to come from bordering countries that have significant cultural and linguistic overlaps with Switzerland. In 2002, these people gained the right to work and study in the country without a visa, and since then the nation's population has swelled by nearly two million. Globally, Switzerland now has the sixth-highest G.D.P. per capita, according to the World Bank. (The United States ranks twelfth.) "Most countries in Europe are concerned

about the other issue—depopulation,” Emilio Zagheni, the director of the Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research, told me.

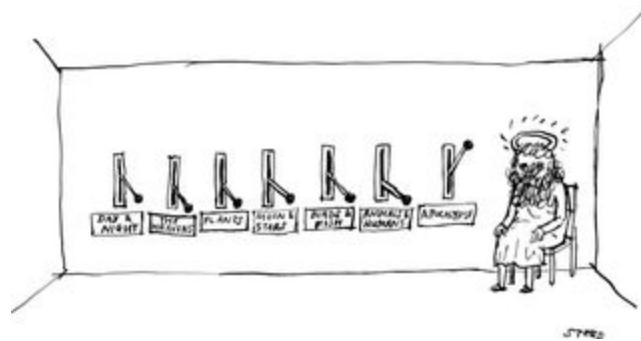
The initiative, whose other official name is the Nachhaltigkeitsinitiative (Sustainability Initiative), is couched in the language of environmentalism. The S.V.P. proposes it as a solution to the consequences of unchecked growth: housing shortages and rising rents in cities, overcrowded trains, clogged roads and highways, and the loss of green space to new construction. In towns such as Maienfeld, the influx of mass tourism gives the impression that even remote valleys have become overrun. “Every major problem in our country,” Matter said from the stage, “is directly or indirectly linked to the incredible explosion of the population.”

Matter, who is sixty, comes from the medieval town of Sissach, twenty minutes by train from Basel. A career banker, he told me that he’d worked at Merrill Lynch in New York and London before returning to Switzerland, in 1994, where he co-founded a private bank. After he was implicated in an investigation into insider trading, he resigned. (Both Matter and the bank denied any wrongdoing, and the investigation into Matter was eventually dropped.) He later co-founded another bank.

Today, Matter is reportedly among the three hundred wealthiest individuals in Switzerland. On his YouTube series, “In the Swamps of Bern,” he sends out dispatches from the Swiss capital, where he serves in Parliament. In a recent episode (titled “Fake News About Mass Immigration”), he stood at a gleaming white enamel desk, like a news anchor, with printed notes before a green screen, and claimed that countries such as Ukraine, Bosnia, Georgia, and Albania were preparing to join the E.U., which would allow their citizens to move to Switzerland. Broad-shouldered and barrel-chested, he wears loose dark suits, with no tie, and carries himself with the confidence of someone used to reassuring clients with large fortunes.

Matter got into politics in the early twenty-tens, almost on a dare. During the lunch break at Maienfeld, as the waiters swapped nut torte for cheesy spätzle, he told me, “A lot of entrepreneurs, friends of mine, they always said, ‘Those politicians, they’re doing only stupid things.’ ” One day, he suggested sending one of their cohort to Bern. “And they said, ‘O.K., O.K., but not me. I have no time.’ And finally I said, ‘O.K., I will run for

Parliament.’ And then I got elected.” Earlier this year, Matter helped lead another controversial initiative, to defund public media, which was defeated. His goal with the population cap, he said, is “quite simple”: “I know if we continue like this for the next twenty-five years, compared with the last twenty-five years, our country is *kaputt*.” He added, “My motivation in politics is really that my children can have the same country that I had.”



Cartoon by Edward Steed

The S.V.P. represents a segment of the population which is straining against the very economic and international legal order that has underwritten the country’s extraordinary success. In Maienfeld, the Party’s president, Marcel Dettling, announced, “We don’t want to become a second Singapore!” Supporters of the initiative, rather than presenting Switzerland as a nation in terminal decline, describe a homeland that has been rendered unrecognizable—like a landscape after a heavy snowfall—by rapid growth. The quality of life was already world-class, so the benefits of the recent economic windfall can feel obscure. “There are no apartments anymore,” a woman named Sabrina told me, at another S.V.P. event. “And if there are they’re hardly affordable.” She was born in 1986, when the population was 6.5 million. Since then, life has simply become more challenging. “Things aren’t so carefree anymore,” she said. “Let’s put it this way.”

Sabrina spoke in vague terms about the “conflict” that comes with an increasingly multinational society. But Matter scoffed at the idea that the initiative has nativist undertones. “We were always diverse. That’s our strength, actually,” he said, citing the nation’s multilingualism. “In Switzerland, we were never xenophobic. And now I start feeling that people are getting *fremdenfeindlich*”—hostile to strangers. “And we don’t want

that, you know? Because we never, ever had anything against foreigners. But it has to be at a speed that we can handle.”

For more than a century, Switzerland has hosted large numbers of foreign-born workers. When the Gotthard Tunnel, a fifteen-kilometre passage linking Lucerne and the Italian-speaking outpost of Ticino, opened, in 1882, it was the longest railway tunnel in the world, and it had been constructed largely by laborers from Italy.

Wage competition with native workers led to riots in Zurich and Bern. But, by 1910, foreigners made up nearly fifteen per cent of the population, a proportion exceeding that of any other European country save Luxembourg. It was around this time that the concept of *Überfremdung* (“over-foreignization”) began to spread through national politics. “One could say Switzerland is a precursor of European populism,” Francesca Falk, a lecturer in migration history at the University of Bern, told me, in part because it was the first European country to establish modern direct-democratic mechanisms capable of translating national sentiments into popular votes.

It takes a hundred thousand signatures to launch an initiative to change the constitution, as the “No to a Switzerland with 10 Million!” campaign aims to do. Initiatives that target the rights of foreigners, Falk said, have typically been most successful during periods of economic expansion. Switzerland was officially neutral in the Second World War, emerging with a robust infrastructure that allowed it to become a main exporter to a rebuilding continent. The subsequent boom fuelled the expansion of Swiss multinational corporations—Nestlé, Roche, what is now Novartis—that are the backbone of its economy. The growth attracted a fresh wave of foreign workers. By the early seventies, foreigners made up sixteen per cent of the population; a few years later, Switzerland had become the richest country in Europe, besides Monaco and Liechtenstein. Despite the prosperity, many Swiss had mixed emotions about the guest workers, who came largely from Southern Europe. As the Swiss novelist Max Frisch observed, “We wanted workers, but we got people.”

The swell of labor from Italy attracted the attention of a reformed Nazi sympathizer and Catholic convert named James Schwarzenbach. He drew

up a proposal, called Against Over-Foreignization (*Überfremdung*), now known as the Schwarzenbach Initiative, that would have limited foreign residents to ten per cent of the population, with an exception for Geneva. Though it was rejected, in 1970, the unease that it articulated has lingered. In recent decades, migration-related initiatives have appeared every few years. In 2014, an S.V.P. measure, Against Mass Immigration, was narrowly adopted, but Parliament managed to implement it without rupturing important arrangements with the E.U. Another S.V.P. initiative, which in 2016 was rejected by an eighteen-point margin, would have stripped foreigners with criminal records of their residency rights, even if they had committed only minor infractions; the measure would have applied even to people born and raised in Switzerland. An infamous poster promoting that campaign depicted white sheep kicking their black brethren out of the frame.

The S.V.P. has maintained some distance from other right-wing parties in Europe, such as Germany's Alternative für Deutschland and France's National Rally. It does not trade in Holocaust denial, and it retains a reputation for coöperating with other parties and institutions at the cantonal level. Nevertheless, in national politics, the Party acts as a clearing house for Switzerland's most extreme expressions of nativism. "There is no party to the right of the S.V.P.," Jakob Tanner, a professor emeritus of modern history at the University of Zurich, told me; the S.V.P. "soaked up" more extreme movements in the nineties. And its use of initiatives to restrict immigration has served as an inspiration to right-wing movements in Europe. "They always say, 'We have to do something like Switzerland,' " Tanner said.

Support for initiatives tends to decline as the vote approaches. The population cap, however, has threatened to defy that trend. Toward the end of April, a former high-ranking federal official told me he believed that there was even more support for the proposal than the latest polls showed. At a dinner party he attended recently, a majority of guests—none of them S.V.P. supporters—were in favor, viewing a yes vote as a signal that they "don't feel at home, at home."

A fifth of Switzerland's population is Francophone. The overwhelming majority live in a narrow corridor of wine country, stretching from Geneva to Montreux, that is almost entirely engulfed by France. The border is rarely more than an hour's drive or ferry ride away. As a result, French-speaking Switzerland hosts more cross-border workers—*frontaliers*—than anywhere else in the country. This transient population resides in France but works and often pays income tax in Switzerland. If the initiative passes, the employment status of the *frontaliers* will suddenly be in limbo, as will the future of the businesses that employ them.

One spring day, David Raedler, a thirty-nine-year-old employment lawyer and a mobility activist, took me by bike down the Route Blanche, a two-lane road that leads through rolling Swiss vineyards before climbing into the Jura Mountains. The road, which connects the canton of Vaud—the home of Nestlé—to France, is an overtaxed thoroughway for cross-border commuters. We passed apartment blocks, a local supermarket chain, and a McDonald's, and then were suddenly banked by farmland. Outside a stone farmhouse, a tractor was partly obscured by an orchard that had erupted in white blossoms. "Those are apple trees," Raedler said. "At least, I'm pretty sure."

Raedler represents the Green Party on the Vaud cantonal council. In 2024, he was a leading figure in a successful referendum to oppose the expansion of national highways, a project developed in response to complaints about traffic jams exacerbated, in places like Vaud, by *frontaliers*. Were it not for this effort, part of the farmland we were biking through would be gone, claimed by extra lanes and a spaghetti bowl of highway exits.

"We used the slogan '*Trop c'est trop*,' " in French-speaking Switzerland, he said, or "Enough is enough," and, in German-speaking Switzerland, "*Zu gross für die Schweiz*," or "Too big for Switzerland." Although a survey indicated that many voters were convinced by the campaign's emphasis on environmental impact and the need for improved public transit, Raedler believes that the victory reflected a broader sense that there are simply "too many people."

Like most politicians in Switzerland, Raedler has a day job, and he had arrived for our bike tour directly from his law office, dressed in a light-blue

oxford shirt and khakis. He studied at the universities of Lausanne and Bern, where he perfected his German, and was a visiting researcher at Harvard before returning to Switzerland, in 2017. Like Heidi, he was homesick: “I missed the landscape. I missed cheese—I missed Gruyère.”

Our destination was a third-generation family vineyard, owned by Maurice Gay. A member of the center-right party Les Libéraux-Radicaux (P.L.R.), Gay serves on the Vaud council, across the aisle from Raedler. He took over the vineyard from his father, and his thirty-year-old son is preparing to inherit it. He greeted us outside wooden gates opening onto the farmhouse and vines, where he grows Chasselas—a Swiss white grape—and a variety of reds. The hum of the highway reached us across an arable field. The proposed expansion would have overtaken this land, sending cloverleaf ramps within twenty metres of Gay’s farm. “I don’t have anything against *frontaliers*,” he said. “But there are many French who come in individual vehicles,” with a single driver per car.

“That’s the whole point of this issue regarding mobility—how to manage with more people,” Raedler said. Gay opposes the population initiative on the ground of excessive state intervention. The S.V.P. aims to “protect our country through border controls and population limits,” he said. “But Switzerland is small compared with Europe. At some point, we have to try to find a solution to live—not just to survive but to live in the midst of this Europe.”

A multilingual, politically idiosyncratic country bordering five other nations, Switzerland can feel at once culturally hermetic and geographically porous. “The percentage of foreigners in Switzerland is very high,” Raedler acknowledged. But, he argued, “there’s also huge assimilation with Swiss values like politeness, or our calm politics.” Raedler, whose mother is British, is a dual citizen, making him among the one in five Swiss who hold two passports. “That’s what in a way makes me sad about this initiative,” he said. “It attacks something that works well.”

Gay’s farm is twenty-five kilometres northeast of Geneva, which hosts many United Nations agencies, the World Trade Organization, the country’s most infamous free port, and one of the world’s largest banking and commodity-trading sectors. It also has the highest number of foreign-born

residents in the country, and one of the most overheated housing markets. Vincent Schaller, a tax specialist and a city councillor representing the Union Démocratique du Centre—the French name of the S.V.P.—is among the roughly two-fifths of the canton’s residents who are Genevan. Schaller used to be a representative for the P.L.R., but he defected in 2017. “The primary reason to be in the S.V.P. is the European question,” he said. The Swiss direct-democracy system is “not soluble with the E.U.”

One rainy Saturday morning, Schaller and other S.V.P. representatives handed out flyers and hot coffee to passersby at a farmers’ market in Rive, an upscale shopping district at the base of Geneva’s Old Town, which was once home to the likes of Calvin and Rousseau. Schaller pointed to a placard that volunteers had hung beneath the coffee station, which showed cartoon yellow cranes—evocative of a construction boom—suspended over a church steeple and a splash of Kelly green. “That could be Geneva,” he said. “That could be anywhere.” He added that the initiative’s threat to Free Movement of Persons, which is popular with Switzerland’s many dual citizens, would arrive at a comfortable delay. It’s not directly “against foreigners,” he said. A shopper with a shock of white hair, carrying two wicker baskets overflowing with fresh greens, called out, “*Du fond du cœur!*” (“From the bottom of my heart!”) to signal his support. Another man, motorcycle helmet tucked under his arm, told me that the population cap was “ridiculous”—it reminded him of the marketing strategy of pricing goods at 9.99 francs instead of ten. “It’s easy to oversimplify a complex issue,” he said.

Given that employed Europeans make up the majority of migrants to Switzerland, it’s hard not to notice that the first demographic to be targeted by the initiative would be refugees and asylum seekers. Tucked into a hillside in the sleepy Francophone village of Matran, a former seminary now serves as La Maison de Formation et d’Intégration, a transitional center for people under legal protection. Céline Stritt, who manages the center’s administration and finances, told me that when the Catholic charity Caritas, which operates La Maison, purchased the site, in 2018, locals “made a petition” to oppose it. We stood in the arts-and-crafts room, on the second floor, overlooking a former dairy, whose date of dedication—1935—was stencilled below the eaves in burnt-orange paint. At the bottom of the

hill, a crane hovered over an unfinished apartment complex rising among traditional single-family homes. Stritt said that relations with villagers have improved. Some craft workshops at the center are open to local children as well as to refugees, and, this winter, everyone got together to make drip-wax candles by hand.

In 2025, Switzerland granted asylum to more than seven thousand people. Applicants who gain admission are distributed to cantons throughout the country, where they are expected to complete workforce- and language-integration programs. Caritas operates such programs at La Maison for refugees assigned to Fribourg, which has a Francophone majority. Residents spend six months learning to navigate the medical and social systems, developing professional skills, and studying French.

In April, when I visited, nearly half of the ninety spots at La Maison were vacant, owing in part to the recent departure of a cohort of Ukrainians who had completed the program. “It comes in waves,” Stritt explained. “In December, we were almost full.” The remaining occupants were mainly Afghan, Eritrean, and Sudanese.

Michel François used to work with Switzerland’s homeless population. He is now a case manager at La Maison, tracking residents during their time at the center and briefly after their departure. He answered my questions with a patience honed by years advocating for social causes. When I asked how most of La Maison’s refugees arrived in Switzerland, he gave a slight shrug, and said, “They walked.” He paused, then added, “Maybe some people from Turkey, they take a plane.”

About half of Switzerland’s refugees—and others in the asylum system—find work within seven years of arriving, fulfilling a national integration target. (The employment rate for the general population is about eighty per cent.) At La Maison, two Eritrean women staff the on-site crèche, or day care. Zeyneb, who came to Switzerland in 2012, told me, in French, that she had been working there for eight years. Across from the chapel—a vestige of the building’s former life—volunteers run a secondhand-clothing shop, where residents can purchase donated items at nominal prices. “It helps them keep a relationship to money,” Stritt explained. We admired a maroon Jacquard jacket fit snugly over a half-bust mannequin. Then she pointed to

a pair of gray sneakers in a row of women's heels. "Those are my son's," she said.

My tour began in a small conference room, set with sparkling water and biscuits, where I was led through a thorough PowerPoint presentation about the Swiss asylum system. A nervous charge hung in the air. Though for many voters the initiative's measures are veiled in the hypothetical, pegged to demographic projections, refugees, such as the residents of La Maison, and others within the asylum system will feel its effects in the near term.



"And you say the hockey puck just came out of nowhere?"
Cartoon by Frank Cotham

Switzerland currently hosts more than two hundred thousand people under some form of legal protection. A third of them are Ukrainians who have entered the country since 2022. Another forty thousand have been allowed into the country on "provisional admission," a status that applies overwhelmingly to people who don't meet the narrow criteria of the Geneva Convention on refugees, from 1951, which do not necessarily include people fleeing armed conflict, such as refugees from civil war. Provisional admission can be converted into a regular residency permit after five years, provided that applicants meet language and other integration requirements.

After the country surpasses 9.5 million people, a scenario expected as soon as 2029, the initiative would strip those granted provisional admission of any possibility of gaining residency rights. "They would only be left with the bare minimum," Anja Klug, the head of the office for the United

Nations High Commissioner for Refugees for Switzerland and Liechtenstein, told me. Under the principle of non-refoulement, it would be illegal for Switzerland to deport these individuals to their countries of origin if they risk “irreparable” harm. The result would be a shadow population, Klug said, that would be impossible to integrate either legally or socially. The initiative’s call to restrict family reunification is written in such a way that it could affect everyone in the asylum system.

Both Stritt and François told me that La Maison focussed on its daily work rather than on policy discussions. As a voter, however, Stritt was unconvinced by the initiative. “Where does the ten million come from?” she said. “Why not seven million? Why didn’t we say it at six million?” Switzerland had a population of seven million in 1995. “Are we sadder, poorer, than we were? It’s not because there are more people that things are more difficult.”

The canton of St. Gallen is named for a celebrated immigrant, the Irish monk Gallus, who settled on the site of its famous abbey—now a *UNESCO* World Heritage site—in 612.

Flanked by Austria and Liechtenstein, and separated from Germany by a glacial lake, St. Gallen is another border canton that plays host to *frontaliers*, here known as *Grenzgänger*. On a Wednesday evening in April, three hundred people crammed into the lime-green auditorium of a high school to hear representatives from across the political spectrum debate the population cap. It was one of dozens of public events scheduled before the vote.

The evening’s headliner was Beat Jans, who serves on the Bundesrat, or Federal Council, a seven-member body that is the country’s highest level of government. Parliament elects members to the Bundesrat, and the role of President rotates annually among the councillors.

Part of the Bundesrat’s mandate is to offer recommendations on whether to adopt popular initiatives that, if passed, will be incorporated into Switzerland’s ever-evolving constitution. (Walter Thurnherr, who was the Federal Chancellor, or chief of staff of the Bundesrat, until 2023, told me that he used to explain the system to his European counterparts by saying,

“You have a fixed constitution and regularly change your government. We regularly change the constitution but keep our government.”) The Bundesrat’s position on the population cap is an unambiguous no. “This initiative would endanger Switzerland’s prosperity, hamper the functioning of society, and jeopardize the bilateral path with the EU,” the council—which includes two members of the S.V.P.—warned in an official message to Parliament. It has fallen to Jans, who is the head of the Department of Justice and Police, and therefore oversees immigration, to convince the voting public.

Jans, who is sixty-one, grew up outside Basel, the son of a metalworker. He trained in agricultural engineering and in the eighties worked in sustainable development in Haiti and Paraguay with the Swiss non-governmental organization Helvetas. Witnessing the effects of the dictatorships in those countries motivated him to enter politics, as a member of the Social Democratic Party, in 1998. “I realized how absolutely crucial it is to have a constitutional democracy based on the rule of law,” he told me. He was elected to the Bundesrat in 2023. Above his desk in Bern hangs a mosaic of small canvas paintings, each a Fauvist variation on an abstracted fleur-de-lis, symbolizing diversity within togetherness. “That’s my motto,” he said. “We work better together.”

The initiative’s use of the word “sustainability” has put its opponents, especially left-of-center parties, in a tricky position. In a country as rich as Switzerland, the standard sales pitch for immigration—that it boosts the economy—appears less and less persuasive. By attacking relations with the rest of Europe, the S.V.P. has also forced the opposition to defend an international order with which many voters are already disillusioned—a drawback that similarly hampered the Remain campaign, in advance of the Brexit vote, in 2016.

“It’s so easy to think this one measure—keeping foreigners out—will solve all the problems,” Jans said. “But this is not going to happen. I think the opposite might be true.” He noted that post-Brexit Britain saw an increased number of asylum seekers, because applicants whose dossiers were rejected in the E.U. suddenly became eligible to reapply in the United Kingdom, an opportunity likely to be available in Switzerland.

Jans's core message, however, was that the population cap would increase uncertainty in already unstable times. When the initiative was submitted, in 2024, he reminded the audience in St. Gallen, the world was a different place. "At the time, international trade was still following clear rules," he said. "The U.S. and Europe stood united against the Russian aggressor. NATO was an intact military alliance. That world, ladies and gentlemen, is history." These changes, he argued, leave Switzerland more in need of reliable partners than ever before.

The government's highest estimates for population growth put Switzerland on track to reach ten million people by 2033. The cap would then impose an effective net-zero immigration flow—one person out (or deceased), one person in. "Imagine a society in which a Swiss citizen is permitted to live with their foreign partner in Switzerland only when another person leaves the country," Economiesuisse, an influential business federation, has said, calling the cap the "Chaos Initiative." Dominik Hangartner, a political scientist and a director at the Immigration Policy Lab, a joint venture between E.T.H. Zurich and Stanford University, told me that the initiative, by locking the country into a fixed path, would render Switzerland "a little like Ulysses, when he was bound to the mast to not follow siren calls." This might be wise for a seafarer set on a specific destination, but it is a poor way to run a country, Hangartner said, "given how fast the world is changing."

John Springford, a fellow at the Centre for European Reform, has estimated that by mid-2022 Brexit had shaved five per cent off the U.K.'s G.D.P. and reduced over-all trade by ten to fifteen per cent. The hit to trade would be especially painful for Switzerland, which has an export-dependent economy. Its financial-services sector is also globally entangled: forty per cent of the world's coal and sixty per cent of its gold are exchanged by traders in hubs like Geneva, Ticino, and Zug. And reducing immigration would exacerbate existing labor shortages. Though the initiative would technically allow firms and small businesses to hire foreigners on short-term work permits—a return to the guest-worker model of the twentieth century—lack of residency status for these workers would make it difficult to recruit from abroad. "You're competing with other European countries to bring in labor," Springford said. "That's quite difficult. Migrants respond to

those kind of incentives.” Nearly three-quarters of new doctors in Switzerland were trained outside the country.

Onstage in St. Gallen, S.V.P. representatives dismissed these concerns, referring to a snowball effect: more people means more demand for housing and services. “Growth continues unabated,” Lukas Reimann, an S.V.P. representative for St. Gallen, said. “If you don’t find ten million too many, is fifteen million too many? Twenty million?”

“Growth is not a dogma, or an end unto itself,” Stefan Schmid, the editor-in-chief of the *St. Galler Tagblatt* and the moderator of the debate, said. Acknowledging those voters who, he said, had a sense of *Unbehagen*, or unease, about the recent growth, he asked Jans, “What do you say to them? Do you understand their concerns?”

The word *Unbehagen* came up frequently in my interviews. In German, it carries deeper resonances of repression. One might say that Heidi is struck with a bad case of *Unbehagen* in Frankfurt: too ashamed to tell her host family that she wants to return to Maienfeld, she simply lies in bed, wasting away. “You have everything you can possibly want here,” the housekeeper scolds her. “It’s because you are too well off and comfortable that you have nothing to do but think what naughty thing you can do next!”

To the late Swiss literary scholar Karl Schmid, Heidi’s malaise might have embodied the “conditions of the small state,” as he wrote, in a globalized world. In 1963, Schmid, who was a professor of literature at the University of Zurich, published an influential study of modern Swiss authors, “*Unbehagen im Kleinstaat*,” or “Unease in the Small State.” (The name is a play on the German title of Freud’s “Civilization and Its Discontents,” “*Das Unbehagen in der Kultur*.”) For generations of Swiss writers that came of age in an increasingly global order, Schmid argued, to hail from a “small state” such as Switzerland was to be haunted by a kind of “fatelessness.” The sense of a loss of control, the feeling that one has no veto or decision-making power on the world stage, was exacerbated by Switzerland’s neutrality in the Cold War, and by its aloofness to the broader project of European integration. The small state, Schmid wrote, feels relegated to “a space *in between the great nations and cultures*.”

“We’re not big, but we’re also not tiny,” David Raedler said. “We’re not Luxembourg, but people have that feeling of being a small country. You’re defending it.” ♦

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Andrew Tate's Empire of Abuse

How the defining figure of the manosphere built a fortune—and became a political force—by systematically exploiting women.

By [Heidi Blake](#)

June 8, 2026



"I've done this with over 100 girls," Tate said, about compelling women into sex work. "I almost sound evil. But I'm not." Photo illustration by Kensuke Koike; Source photographs from Getty; Shutterstock

Just north of Bucharest is a neat development of red-gabled houses known as American Village. It is an unlikely place to be the center of an international criminal intrigue, but on its western border is a sprawling compound, patrolled by armed guards, that belongs to the British American

influencer Andrew Tate and his younger brother, Tristan. The Tates moved to Romania a decade ago to build an online-pornography empire, and American Village was where they kept their recruits.

One day in April, 2022, Iasmina Pencov was in a villa near the compound, recovering from surgery. A slender, dark-haired former psychology student, she had met Andrew Tate the previous year and agreed to move across Romania to be with him. Tate had told Pencov that he considered her his wife, and when he first asked her to strip on camera she was appalled. “I’m old fashioned and I do believe in God,” she texted him. “My body is intimate and only my husband should be able to touch and see.” But he had worn her down—“identified the objections and destroyed them,” he wrote in private messages describing her recruitment. “She never believed in god. Women never believe in anything.”

Tate presided over an online network called the War Room, in which, for a fee of about eight thousand dollars a year, he promised to “free the modern man from socially induced incarceration.” Members learned how to recruit women into “sexual slavery” in a series of tutorials that Tate called his Ph.D., or “Pimping Hoes Degree.” He had used Pencov as a teaching case, reporting on her subjugation over the secure messaging app Telegram. “I’ve done this with over 100 girls,” he told members. “I almost sound evil. But I’m not. I’m a shepard. Leading the sheep.”

Pencov had become an online sex worker who staged live shows through the night and posted pornography on OnlyFans. The Tates had paid to have her teeth fixed, and then to have her breasts enlarged. The words “Tate Owned” were tattooed in swirling letters across her upper arm, along with a cobra, Andrew’s personal insignia. She remained passionately devoted to him. “I love you enough to fight for you, compromise for you, and sacrifice myself for you,” she texted him.

Pencov was not alone in her devotion. The Tates used the same method to recruit all the women who came to American Village. “You have to fuck them, and they have to love you. It’s essential to the business,” Andrew explained in a video sold to War Room members. “You have to be militant with your fucking pimping.” (I have pieced together an account of Tate’s activities from thousands of private messages, internal documents, sealed

prosecutorial files, and court records—as well as scores of interviews with the Tates, their associates, and more than a dozen alleged victims.)

The Tates had moved to Romania from the United Kingdom in 2015, after three British women accused Andrew of rape and strangulation, and the brothers seemed to operate there with impunity. Court records show that local police sat on at least two reports indicating that the Tates were coercing Romanian women into sex work. Andrew openly discussed bribing law-enforcement officials in War Room chats, and bragged on social media about his connections. “*EVERYONE* wants to be friends with the pimp,” he wrote in a since-deleted tweet. “Doubt me? *EPSTEIN HAD ACCESS TO PUSSY*. Look at his fucking friends list.”

Pencov had been entrusted with supervising new arrivals at a villa in American Village where the brothers housed sex workers. Tate called her his “mafia wife,” and told her, “it’s important you and I work together and just control them all.” She had become an eager accomplice. “We’re the power team,” she told him.

Pencov was concerned about the latest recruit: a twenty-year-old aspiring musician whom Tristan Tate had romanced on a recent trip to Miami. The musician had refused to strip on camera, insisting that she had come to Bucharest to teach Tristan piano. Pencov found her demeanor “weird and secretive”; she had caught her talking furtively in her bedroom with another reticent newcomer.

That day in 2022, Pencov heard a hammering at the front door. Another recruit went to answer it, and a voice asked if the American woman was inside. When the worker said yes, there followed a cacophony of voices, radios, and pounding boots as police stormed the property.

It turned out that, soon after arriving in Bucharest, the American had begun sending distress messages back home. “These guys are actually evil,” she had written. “They are definitely trafficking women.” The other women in the house seemed “brainwashed,” she said. The U.S. Embassy was alerted, and swiftly notified local police. A SWAT team was deployed to take the women in the villa into protective custody.

The Tates were questioned, and one of Romania's leading organized-crime prosecutors opened an investigation into suspected human trafficking. But the brothers were quickly released, and Andrew waved away reports of the incident, claiming that it had been a prank. He had been saying for years that he was "above the law," and he saw no reason to doubt it now.

At the time of the raid, Andrew Tate was on the cusp of becoming one of the most famous men on the planet. He'd amassed a vast following on social media, mixing posts about diamond watches, cigars, and supercars with jokes and misogynistic rants. He told alienated young men that they were the victims of a feminized society determined to crush their male essence, and urged them to get fit, get rich, and reclaim their "natural masculine imperative for power."

Often, that imperative seemed to equate to sexual violence. In one video, Tate described the "basic moves of pimping" while lying on his bed waving a machete. "*Bang* out the machete, *boom* in her face, then grip her up by the neck," he said. "The machete's on the floor, her panties are all wet, and you go fuck her. That's how it goes. Slap, slap, grab, choke. Shut up, bitch. Sex."

Tate had risen to prominence in the online realm of incels, pickup artists, and red-pill believers known as the manosphere—and he'd engineered an ingenious way to expand his reach. Not long before the raid, he had launched Hustlers University, an online school that, for \$49.99 a month, taught "modern wealth creation" methods, including an affiliate-marketing program that functioned as a gigantic content factory. Members were given access to a library of Tate's videos, and earned commissions by reposting clips to attract new subscribers. More than a hundred and sixty thousand students enrolled, pumping Tate's content into algorithms already primed to amplify extreme ideas.

In the months after the raid, videos tagged #AndrewTate were viewed more than twelve billion times on TikTok alone, and he became one of the world's most Googled people. His followers spread his rhetoric to millions of homes and classrooms. Teen-age boys around the world barked Tate's slogan "Make me a sandwich" at female teachers, and reports spread of sexual aggression by his followers.

Tate's enormous reach made him a political force. He had always been an enthusiastic supporter of Donald Trump—"He's grabbing bitches by the pussy. I like that guy," he'd once said—and he became a singularly influential proponent of masculinism: a creed, devoted to countering feminism and restoring the patriarchy, that helped unite the disparate factions of the *MAGA* coalition. Tate called for women to be stripped of the vote, barred from the workplace, and forced to procreate. By comparison, conservative politicians' efforts to erode reproductive rights and roll back gender-equality laws seemed moderate. "I have shifted the Overton window heavily since I became famous," Tate bragged.

In the summer of 2022, feminist and antifascist groups mounted a campaign to deplatform Tate, and he was ejected from mainstream social media. But the bans only enhanced his fame, with conservative pundits hailing him as a free-speech martyr. "We're adults and Americans, and we'll listen to anyone we want," Tucker Carlson said as he welcomed Tate onto his Fox News show. Tate played his part adroitly. "When somebody who's championing men's issues like myself comes forward and finally manages to garner huge percentiles of the public support, I'm silenced," he said.

Tate made a deal with the right-wing streaming service Rumble, which had recently received major investments from Peter Thiel, the tech billionaire, and J. D. Vance, Trump's future Vice-President. The details have not previously been confirmed, but a confidential contract shows an agreement to pay Tate at least six million dollars a year for a weekly quota of five short videos and a thirty-minute live stream. His presence inspired a forty-five-per-cent increase in active users, sending Rumble to first place on the Apple and Google charts. A few months later, Elon Musk bought Twitter and reinstated Tate's account.

When Tate was arrested on human-trafficking charges, his allies defended him. Donald Trump, Jr., called the case "absolute insanity," and Musk suggested that the authorities were targeting the Tates while ignoring "actual sex trafficking." Carlson, who had just released a documentary called "The End of Men," devoted hours of airtime to proclaiming Tate's innocence; so did the right-wing podcaster Candace Owens. The activist

Charlie Kirk praised him onstage. “What he says is so powerful,” Kirk said. “Our society is configured towards collapsing the American man.”

Prosecutors went on to allege that the Tates had trafficked dozens of women by using romantic relationships to lure them into sex work. Though the brothers were released from custody, they were barred from leaving Romania. Tate issued a defiant statement: “The Matrix has attacked me. But they misunderstand, you cannot kill an idea.” To fight the charges, he hired an expensive team of lawyers, P.R. operatives, and private detectives.

Tate’s representatives claimed that he hadn’t really meant what he’d said online about sexually exploiting women—he had simply been playing a character “for entertainment.” At the same time, they devised a campaign to attack his accusers with scores of legal filings, while Tate’s affiliate network harassed and smeared them online. Even one of his team members described it as “textbook victim intimidation.”

As the 2024 U.S. election approached, the team saw an opportunity. Tate forged relationships with Barron Trump and Donald Trump, Jr. In the weeks before the vote, he pumped out pro-*MAGA* content, mobilizing young men in such large numbers that Kamala Harris later named him as a key factor in her defeat. When the result was in, Tate posted jubilantly on X: “*THE PATRIARCHY IS BACK.*” After the Inauguration, he added, “The Tates will be free, Trump is the president.”

Weeks later, under pressure from the U.S., Romania lifted the Tates’ travel ban. Since then, the brothers have travelled the world, while the case appears stalled and the evidence remains sealed. When I met them earlier this year at a cigar lounge in Bucharest, they assured me that the prosecution was doomed. “It’s just garbage out of a corrupt country,” Andrew said, puffing a Davidoff and flashing pearly veneers. “Show me a victim. Show me a hurt girl. Show me a bruise. Show me a girl chained up. Show me something.”

“The times I struck a woman (in passion) I never left a mark,” the Tates’ father wrote on Facebook in 2011. “Super control of the human animal. They love me still.” Emory Tate was a celebrated Black chess master who served as a staff sergeant and a linguist in the U.S. Air Force; he met their

mother, a white British woman named Eileen Ashleigh, on a brief posting to the U.K. The couple married and moved to America, and in 1986 Andrew was born in a military hospital in Washington, D.C. Tristan came a year and a half later, followed by a sister, Janine. Andrew has described his father's influence in scores of posts, podcasts, and videos. "My dad was my hero in every way," he has said. "I feared my dad. As if he was God himself."

Emory was brilliant, charismatic, and mercurial. In 1992, he was discharged from the Air Force after being diagnosed as having conditions that "interfere with military service," including narcissistic personality disorder. Back in civilian life, he was convinced that he was being monitored by the C.I.A., that the family car was being tailed, and that he was under attack by assailants from Eastern Europe. "The world he lived in was a scary world," Andrew has said. He remembered Emory telling him, "You're a Tate. They're going to come for you like they came for me."

The family relocated to Elkhart, Indiana, to be close to Emory's mother. The brothers spent hours playing around their grandmother's house—climbing trees, building forts, and racing through cornfields—but their home life was fraught. Emory drank heavily and was prone to terrifying rages. Tristan told me that if he stepped out of line his father beat him with a belt, sometimes whipping him until his skin was striped red. Andrew has described lying awake at night in terror. "I must have been the most awake child on earth," he said in one video. "I was so afraid of the beatdown." In his telling, this violence was an essential part of becoming a man. "I can't wait to kick my kid's ass if he gets fresh," he has said.



"Would you mind charging my drill?"

Cartoon by Stephen Raaka

In Indiana, Emory worked low-wage jobs—at McDonald's, a car wash, a park—but funnelled his ferocious intellect into chess, often staying up all night drinking and practicing variations. He started leaving the family to play in tournaments around the country. He would arrive by bus, wearing his trademark trilby, and hustle for spare dollars in chess parks. A dazzling attacking player, he became a folk hero on the circuit—bringing “the flair and swagger to chess often seen on the basketball courts,” the chess writer Daaim Shabazz noted—but he lacked the discipline to reach grandmaster level, where serious winnings kick in. “As smart as my father was, chess doesn't pay,” Andrew has said. “He also loved gambling, women, and booze. So you add all that up, we were very, very poor.”

When Emory returned to the family after an eight-week absence, Eileen confronted him over an infidelity, and he walked out again. “When you're older, you'll understand,” he told Andrew. “Your mother won't shut up.” As the marriage broke down, Andrew rationalized his father's abandonment. “You're a better role model to your son if you barely see him and live life on your own terms,” he later wrote. “A dad is a super hero. Not a full time carer. Don't sit and become a Bitch like the woman wants.”

In 1997, the year Andrew turned eleven, Eileen moved the children to her home town of Luton, an impoverished and overcrowded municipality north of London. They stayed in a hostel for homeless women and children. “It was a horrible place to live,” Tristan told me. Eileen got a job washing dishes in a school cafeteria, and he remembered that “her hands were always bleeding and cracked.”

Eventually, they moved to the Marsh Farm estate, a housing project plagued by crime and violent riots. The Tates went to a failing school, where they were bullied for their American accents and shabby clothes. Emory occasionally sent money, and the brothers would walk to a pay phone to call him. “My father raised me over the phone,” Andrew has written. “I was *STILL AFRAID* of him, 3000 miles away.”

As a teen-ager, Andrew was dogged by a feeling of unease. “I always had this sense that something wasn't quite right about the way the world

functioned,” he has said. He thought of himself like the character Neo in “The Matrix,” restlessly searching without knowing what for. When the brothers walked to school together, they sometimes saw a Ferrari drive by, and Andrew became furious. “He’s hacked the Matrix!” he said. “How does he have four hundred grand for a car? He knows something we don’t know!”

By seventeen, Andrew had left school and was working in a fish market, waking up at dawn to lug boxes of ice. He described being encumbered by a “crippling perpetual boredom” that yielded only to danger. Seeking a remedy, he enrolled in a kickboxing gym run by a former Special Forces soldier from Bosnia. Soon, he was competing, and Tristan started training, too.

Kickboxing is not much more lucrative than professional chess. The brothers initially fed themselves on canned sardines and chicken scrounged from abandoned KFC buckets. But, in the ring, Andrew exhibited his father’s gift for showmanship. He called himself King Cobra, got a cobra tattooed on his chest, and developed a patter about drinking snake blood. In one post-match interview, he was red-faced and furious, fumbling with his mouth guard. “This is not sport to me,” he seethed. “I’m in there to kill. That’s it. Pain. That’s all I know.”

As Tate’s fighting career gathered momentum, his father showed an interest. In 2011, Andrew won his first world championship, and Emory wrote online, “Destruction itself rides in his very fingertips.” He also posted musings that seemed to provide his son with an ideological road map. He warned against “enemies of alpha males,” “the Matrix,” and “the insanity of the ruling elite.” He mocked the notion of gender equality and argued that “mature men” should be allowed to have sex with pubescent girls.

Emory was still travelling between chess tournaments, and his posts were interspersed with blurry photos of hotels and dark city streets. He wrote about drinking vodka at 3 A.M. and inhabiting a state “between ennui and dejection.” At times, his tone was valedictory. “I could clone myself. I would not,” he wrote. “The better versions of me already walk the planet.” At others, it approached introspection. “Many animals are immune to their own poison,” he wrote, in 2012. “The toxic *HUMAN* realizes that his toxin

kills even himself, toxifies his kids.” He died three years later, succumbing to a heart attack during a chess match. Andrew posted a tribute. “He created a monster,” he wrote. “As a father should.”

At the peak of Tate’s fighting career, he spent part of each year competing across Europe, and he often based himself in Košice, Slovakia, an elegant medieval city of pastel town houses and Gothic spires. During one visit, he met Bibiana Hruskova, a high-school student with hazel eyes and blond hair, who was working as a waitress. Tate has said that they met in 2012, the year he turned twenty-six and she turned fifteen. He had taken to collecting girlfriends on his travels, and Hruskova became one of them. “I had a girlfriend in Slovakia, I had a girlfriend in France, I had a girlfriend in England,” he later said. “Do they know about each other? No.”

Hruskova was besotted with Tate. “You’re the best thing ever happened to me,” she texted him. “I want babies and get married.” In 2014, when she turned seventeen, Tate summoned her to England. She left her family and went.

By then, Tate was a three-time kickboxing world champion, but, even at the top of the sport, he generally made only about fifty thousand dollars for a title fight; after he paid his manager and his trainer there was little left over. In early 2014, he sat down to make a list of everything he owned. It was a dispiriting exercise. He and his brother shared a run-down apartment with barely any furniture. He owed money on his car. But then he had what he considered a flash of entrepreneurial genius. “I had about five girlfriends, all smoking hot—and females are an asset,” he recalled, in a video. “Pussy is the only reason that empires were started and wars were waged. . . . I had to find a way to monetize the assets.”

Tate knew some street pimps, and he contemplated that route, but he didn’t want other men touching what he saw as his property. Opening a strip club was too expensive. Then he stumbled on an ad for a webcam-porn site. He flew all of his girlfriends to Luton and assembled them at a restaurant, where they learned of one another’s existence. “I said, ‘Listen, young ladies, I’m starting a webcam business,’ ” Tate later recalled. “ ‘This is going to change your life.’ ”

Most of the women left, but Hruskova stayed. Tate set up a profile for her on a site called MyFreeCams, which allows users to watch models for free, then pay them to perform specific sex acts or private shows. Filming sexual imagery of anyone under eighteen is illegal in the U.S. and the U.K. On camera, Hruskova became a Russian woman in her twenties, performing under the username KissofaCobra. Tate persuaded her to get a tattoo of a cobra down one side of her body and another reading “Tate Property” above her crotch.

Webcam porn, now a multibillion-dollar industry, was then a nascent phenomenon, and Tate considered himself a pioneer. “We started doing fifteen-, sixteen-, seventeen-hour days,” he said. “I’d wake up to go piss, and by the time I finished pissing I was awake enough to say, All right, two hours’ sleep, that’s enough.” He realized that he could extract bigger tips from customers if he wrote them seductive messages off camera while Hruskova pretended to type on a disconnected keyboard. “I had these guys selling their houses, life savings, loans, all of it,” he later said. “I put together an apparatus of genius behind the avatar of beauty, and we fucking conquered.”

With Tate controlling her performances, Hruskova became a fan favorite. “I think I’ve fallen in love (again),” one user wrote. For a price, Tate would have sex with her on camera. In one video, he keeps his face out of view as he penetrates Hruskova from behind, but the distinctive cobra tattoo on his chest and arm is clearly visible. “She will perform anal sex in front of hundreds of viewers, who will keep tipping to push her boundaries,” a review site noted.

Tate has claimed that, in the first month with Hruskova on camera, he made more than a hundred thousand dollars; the brothers bought an Aston Martin. That April, Andrew won the kickboxing world championship for a fourth time. But he soon stepped back from the sport to focus on expanding his webcam business, telling a kickboxing magazine that he was now a “pimp superstar.”

As Tate warmed to his new career, he adopted a motto: “There are only two categories of people—pimps and hoes.” He was quoting the infamous Chicago pimp Ken Ivy, who published a book called “Pimpology” and

another titled “The Art of Human Chess.” Tate studied both volumes closely.

“Seduction is a chess game and to the victor go the spoils,” Ivy wrote, in a treatise on recruiting sex workers. “To master someone completely, they have to depend on you for everything,” he instructed. “Most hoes have low self-esteem for a reason. A pimp looks for that weakness, and if it isn’t on the surface, he brings that motherfucker out of them.”

Webcam work, unlike prostitution, is generally legal. But it is illegal almost everywhere in the world to recruit sex workers using force, fraud, or coercion—including psychological manipulation. Tate wasn’t concerned. As he started searching for new recruits, he bought a replica of the gloves that featured in O. J. Simpson’s murder trial and got the word “pimp” embroidered on the palms.

At the end of 2014, he reached out on Facebook to a twenty-year-old British woman whom I’ll call Maya Navarro. He sent a recruiting video of Hruskova sprawled on a bed, tapping on a keyboard. “Just typing to some guys is the easiest money in the world,” he said.

Navarro was living with her mother, who had worked for years in a warehouse, and her younger brother, who had learning difficulties. Her father had recently become homeless, and since leaving school she had been precariously employed. She agreed to meet Tate for coffee to find out more.

Navarro told me that Tate was “very charismatic, very confident.” He showed her screenshots of the money coming into Hruskova’s webcam account and said that he would make her rich, so that she could travel the world and help her family. “I don’t think I’d ever spoken to anybody in my entire life that had said those kinds of things to me,” Navarro told me.

Soon afterward, Tate picked Navarro up from her mother’s house and drove her to a block of apartments above a convenience store. Up a dark stairway lit by flickering bulbs, he showed her into a room with a mattress on the floor and a computer station in the corner. “It was skanky,” she told me, but Tate assured her that they would soon be moving to a penthouse. He plied

her with wine and directed her to lie on the mattress, pretending to type, while he messaged customers from the computer. That first night, he let her keep her underwear on, and it didn't feel so bad.



“For the anxiety, I’m prescribing the familiar comfort of rewatching the same series until its outcomes feel more knowable than your own.”

Cartoon by Sarah Akinterinwa

When Tate picked her up for the second shift, there was a young woman, whom I’ll call Emilia Walker, in the back seat. Navarro knew Walker a little from school and felt more at ease with her there. Between stints on camera, they laughed and drank bottles of rosé that the brothers supplied. At the end of the week, Tate gave each woman several hundred pounds in cash—more than Navarro had ever held. She said that he drove them to a shopping center and declared, “You’ve got money now. Start spending it.” Navarro bought a Michael Kors watch and, after a few more shifts, a pair of Louboutin heels; it was such a thrill that she kept the receipt as a trophy. “I felt really, really proud of myself,” she said. “It was kind of, like, Oh, this is what my life can be like if I stay here.”

But Tate was already coming to resent paying Navarro and Walker a cut of their earnings. Hruskova let him keep “100% of the fucking money,” he later said. But, he complained, “once you get bigger, you start hiring girls

who don't love you." He decided on a strategy: "I have a financial incentive to fuck as many as I can."

Before long, Tate told Navarro and Walker they would now be working from a room in a Hilton hotel in Luton. On the second night, the women fell asleep there, and Navarro said that she woke up to find Tate behind her, touching her legs. Then, she said, he pulled down her underwear and grabbed her throat, forcing himself inside her. "You're such a good little girl," she remembered him saying, while he choked her until she struggled for breath. Navarro said that she repeatedly told Tate to stop, and tried to loosen his grip on her throat, but he continued.

Navarro recalls that she passed out afterward, and woke up beside Tate feeling "disgusting, ashamed, dirty." She left and returned to her mother's house, but resuming normal life was hard. "My crappy house, my crap bedroom, and my tiny little bed—that definitely put it into perspective," she said. "Slowly, I was, like, I should go back, because that's the most money I've ever made." She told herself that she'd be firmer with Tate: "I was, like, Maybe he won't do it again. Maybe he'll just leave me alone."

By March, 2015, Tate had moved his webcam operation to Hitchin, a market town outside Luton. He'd rented an airy four-bedroom apartment, with a roof terrace overlooking a quaint stone church and a riverbank of willows. When Navarro returned, she thought that it was the nicest place she'd ever stayed.

Tate was now calling Emilia Walker his girlfriend, and they were sharing a bed. Navarro found Walker spirited and funny, a good companion. "She kind of made the place like home," she told me. The two women retreated to the rooftop whenever they got a break, to smoke, joke around, and get some sun.

Tate had hung up a poster commissioned from a local artist. It depicted him on a throne, holding a cane that he called his "pimp stick," with three women leaning over him in stilettos and thongs. "Big Tate carries a cane to keep his hoes sane," it said, in pink bubble writing. He'd also had a poster made for his brother, who was recruiting webcam workers of his own. Tristan's poster depicted him dressed as a buccaneer, above the words "The

captain's word is *LAW*." Navarro said that Tristan would walk around the apartment wearing a tricorne hat and waving a foam sword, declaring, "I am the captain of the money ship." There was an absurdity to it all that took the edge off the menace.

There were half a dozen women working in the apartment—including Hruskova, whom Navarro recognized from the video that Tate had sent. Tate was "horrible" to Hruskova, Navarro said, calling her "fat and ugly." When he was around, Hruskova seemed to vie for his attention, "trying to be the alpha female in the house." When he was gone, though, she seemed "like she didn't want to be there, but she was scared."

The hours were grueling, and Navarro downed several bottles of wine during each shift, trying to stay disinhibited enough to do what customers asked. By the time she finished, she was drunk and desperate for sleep. At first, the brothers drove her home, but after a while, she said, they refused and she had to sleep over. There were only two beds in the apartment, and Tristan slept upstairs with several women he'd recruited—so Navarro ended up crashing in the bed that Walker shared with Tate.

One morning, Navarro woke up to Tate and Walker having sex next to her. She shushed them, and Walker got up and went into the bathroom. When she was gone, Navarro said, Tate put her in a choke hold and raped her for a second time. Though she clawed at his arms, he wouldn't release his grip. "I was scared that he was going to kill me," she told me. Then Walker emerged from the shower, and he rolled off her.

Later, Navarro said, she was working on camera when she heard strange noises and went to investigate. Through the open bedroom door, she saw Tate strangling Walker on the bed. Walker's face was red and puffy, and her body was limp. Navarro said that she felt a strange paralysis. "I was, like, There's nothing I can do about it," she told me. She went back to work.

The following morning, Navarro and Walker were putting on makeup in the bathroom when they noticed clusters of red spots around their eyes. Walker searched online and saw that petechiae—burst blood vessels—can be a sign of acute pressure in the head from strangulation. The women began to panic. Hearing a commotion, the Tates came to the door. When they saw the

marks, they laughed. “You’re such dumb bitches,” Navarro remembers them saying. “That’s from sleeping on the silk sheets.”

Navarro said that Tate started attacking her at random moments. Multiple times, when she slept late, he whipped her with a belt. Time became a blur, and the world outside the apartment seemed to recede. But, one day, Navarro had a moment alone, and something snapped: she walked out the door and never went back.

Walker left soon afterward, and the two women gradually began talking about what had happened. Though Walker had started sleeping with Tate consensually, she said that he had attacked her many times, choking her till she almost passed out. That summer, the women contacted the Hertfordshire police.

As it happened, Tate was already known to the authorities. The previous spring, another woman had gone to the police to make similar allegations. The woman, whom I’ll call Hannah Price, said that she had briefly dated Tate the previous year but told him that she wasn’t ready for sex. In the course of several weeks, she said, he raped and strangled her twice. Price showed police a series of messages from Tate discussing the alleged assaults. “I love raping you,” he had written to her. “Monsters are monsters.”

(Tate says that he did not strangle any of the women, and that the sex was consensual. But he has repeatedly advocated throttling women during sex as a way to assert masculine power. “Choke her so she can barely fucking breathe, tell her she’s yours forever,” he said in one podcast. “You just have to be a large enough force to program her.” Price and Walker declined to be interviewed, but have described being assaulted by Tate in court filings.)

Tate was arrested on suspicion of assault, but he denied everything and was quickly released. Back at the apartment, he arranged for several webcam workers to give statements on his behalf. “We’re going to bury this shit and carry on with our lives,” he told them. Then, before the case could move forward, he and Tristan left for Romania. “Fuck England,” Tate said. “I’m bouncing.”

The Tates' compound outside Bucharest lies behind heavy security gates. Inside is a courtyard with an underlit swimming pool and a line of parked supercars—Aston Martins, Lamborghinis, and Bugattis. The house is a vast converted warehouse, clad in gleaming black panels, with the name “Tate” mounted on the wall in huge white letters, next to an emblem of a chess knight. A wrought-iron samurai statue stands by a bulletproof door.

When I visited, this March, Tristan showed me around. He is physically imposing—six feet four and about two hundred and thirty pounds—but his manners were polished. He ushered me into a cavernous space, where the brothers' kickboxing belts hung on a wall, alongside a photograph of their father. Glass-topped display tables held a replica handgun, gold bullets, and brass knuckles. In a wood-panelled cigar lounge, Tristan showed me a towering safe sheathed in burgundy leather, which he said had contained “watches and millions of dollars in cash and gold” before the raid. Security cameras covered every inch of the compound, except the bedrooms. “I’ve made it into a fortress,” he said.

In 2015, when the Tates decided to leave England, Andrew’s plan was “I’ll just run around the world, and I’ll be above the jurisdiction of any one place.” Then a friend from his kickboxing days called from Romania. Sebastian Vieru ran a mixed-martial-arts company with backing from two brothers, Mihăiță and Sorin Doroftei, who were later indicted for heading one of the largest criminal cartels in Romanian history. (They deny the allegations.) Tate was fascinated by his friend’s connections. He became a partner in the cage-fighting business, and then began investing in real estate. Tate boasted in texts about how easy it was to “hide” cash in Romanian property. “Turn up with money in a bag,” he wrote. “No banks no mortgage no bullshit no tax.” He later partnered with the Dorofteis to open a series of casinos, which he described as “big time mafia shit.”

To Tate, Romania seemed like a gangster’s paradise. He bragged about bribing officials, filling his house with guns and machetes, and hiding money from the authorities through cryptocurrency. He repeatedly claimed to have used mafia and police contacts to hunt down people who had crossed him. “Please do not underestimate how connected I am in

Romania,” he tweeted. “MPs Police chiefs Street thugs *ANYTHING* can be fixed.”

The Tates had brought Hruskova and several other women from the U.K., and put them to work in properties around Bucharest. They hired a former member of Romania’s security services, who recruited dozens of guards to protect them. Tate said that he also consulted a local lawyer about the potential implications of being accused of assaulting a woman, and was assured that without “physical evidence” she would have no case. “This is probably forty per cent of the reason I moved to Romania, because in Eastern Europe none of this garbage flies,” Tate later explained in a video. “I’m not a fucking rapist. But I like being able to do whatever I want.”

During my visit, the Tates strenuously denied that they had hurt a single woman. “I’ve never done anything wrong in my life,” Andrew told me. He insisted that none of the women he’d recruited had accused him of crimes, adding, “They’re still my friends.” By the time police raided his properties, he said, “the webcam business—which, by the way, is not illegal—had been closed for ten years.” He showed no trace of emotion as he lied.

In Romania, the Tates turned their small-time webcam enterprise into a kind of industrial operation. Their approach to recruiting resembled what trafficking experts call the “lover-boy method.” They trawled dating apps and social media for young women, blasting out hundreds of identical messages and frequently changing their location to expand their reach. Women who responded were romanced. Tate sent one a flurry of questions: Where did she want to travel? Had she ever been skydiving? Had she ever seen a Dubai sunset? Those who proved susceptible were groomed for sex work. “Every day, I sent twenty Instagrams. Every day, I was on a date. I was fucking four girls, five girls a week,” Tate said in a War Room video. “I built my business off the back of my dick.”

Tate had learned from Ken Ivy, the “Pimpology” author, the importance of having a “bottom bitch.” He needed a recruiting sergeant who could lure in other women, and he assigned this role to Hruskova. After he slept with a woman, Hruskova would come in to “sell the dream” of webcam work, he explained in a War Room video. “Before this, I was a waitress, and it was shit,” he coached her to say. “Now I do this, I make so much money.”

In fact, Tate said, Hruskova saw little of the money she generated. He reported in private chats that her live streams had made him around two million dollars, but all she got was pocket money for coffee and manicures. “She works hard to please me. To get attention,” he said. He was certain that she would never leave him. “I own her mind,” he told associates. “If I died, she would commit suicide.” (One worker from that time told me that Hruskova seemed to have lost the capacity for independent thought. “She’s not herself—she’s like an extension of Andrew,” she said. “We were all brainwashed.”)

After the initial pitch, Tate would get his target and Hruskova drunk and have sex with them. “Martinis, Martinis, Martinis. Bam. Threesome. Slam them both,” he said. “That’s how you recruit.” The compulsory group sex continued once the women were employed. “Every day after work for me was a threesome, foursome, fivesome, orgy,” Tate said. He wrote to one eighteen-year-old about a threesome with Hruskova, “You can be little sisters and hold hands while you get dick.”

The women lived in the brothers’ properties, and the most prized workers were not allowed to go out unattended or to have relationships with anyone but the Tates. Otherwise, Andrew explained, “that other person she’s fucking is going to have the control over her mind.” Each brother had a personal “harem.” Tate called the women his wives, and ordered them to address him as “king.”

Often, the recruits came from troubled homes or were living in poverty. One former member of Tate’s “harem” told me that she had found his initial love-bombing intoxicating: “You go along with it, and, before you know it, you’re in absolute hell.” Tate had a way of “casually peppering the abuse through day-to-day life,” she said. “He kind of serves it to you in a tongue-in-cheek, humorous way, but it’s deadly serious.” Physical abuse was often disguised as “rough sex.” Once, she said, Tate beat her so hard that she sustained lasting injuries to her eye and breast. “You’re a sexually violent person,” she texted him afterward. He replied, “You never told me to stop.”

In Romania, Tate rarely seemed to face consequences for his actions. In the summer of 2016, though, he risked returning to the U.K. to appear on the

reality show “Big Brother.” People who had seen his early sex shows with Hruskova remembered him, and some of the footage was leaked online.

In one video, Tate lay on a bed and ordered Hruskova to show the camera her tattoo. “Why does it say ‘Tate’?” he asked.

“Because I’m his whore,” she replied.

“Why’s your ass got a bruise on it?”

“Because my daddy hits me.”

Tate picked up a belt and began whipping Hruskova as she lay in the fetal position, sobbing. “Bitch, look at the camera,” he told her, yanking her head back by the hair. “This is what happens when you don’t fucking listen.”

The *Sun*, a leading tabloid, reported on the footage, and Tate was forced out of the “Big Brother” house. He posted a protest online: “We were having a laugh? The sun are morons.” He said that Hruskova was an ex-girlfriend, and shared a photo of her holding a belt inscribed with the words “But I love when Andrew spans me.”

In fact, Tate’s removal from “Big Brother” had nothing to do with the videos. The Hertfordshire police had contacted the producers to inform them of the assault allegations from Navarro, Walker, and Price. But officers apparently missed indications of another crime: child pornography. Tate said that the belt video was made in 2012, at the start of his relationship with Hruskova. That year, she turned fifteen.

As the webcam business expanded, a British entrepreneur named Naomi John was brought in to help. John had grown up in Bedfordshire, not far from the Tates, and as a young woman had opened a swimwear store called Sandstorm Boutique. The store became a sponsor of the Miss World beauty pageant, and John served as a judge for Miss Universe Great Britain, a significant recruiting pipeline for models.

In 2016, the Tates persuaded John to move to Bucharest. They had launched a recruitment agency called Model Stars, and they wanted their role in it to

be obscured. Model Stars was described in promotional materials as an “all-female business,” in which “women help other women to escape the 9-5 work schedule and earn life-changing amounts of money.”

John’s job, according to sealed court filings and interviews with women who worked for her, was to help recruit webcam workers and control their profiles on streaming sites. “I don’t want them to have passwords,” Tristan texted John. “I want the money to be used by me and you, fuck them.” John directed the women on camera, telling them which positions to adopt and which sex toys to use. “She was the brain, and I was the looks,” one recruit told me. Another worker—in her late teens, with pink hair and braces—was renamed Chloe Skittles and posed in a room with jars of candy above the bed.

One of John’s first recruits, Abigail Tyson, was working in a bathroom-supply store in the struggling English port town of Grimsby when she got an Instagram message from Model Stars. Tyson told me that she spoke to John over Skype and found her “really lovely, like a friend that I’ve known for a long time.” The shop paid about three hundred pounds a week; John assured her that she would earn much more from Model Stars.

In Bucharest, Tyson was brought to a house where the brothers were staying with several other women. She’d never had a serious boyfriend, and she was mesmerized by Tristan. “I’ve never met someone who is so, so intelligent like him,” she said. They soon started sleeping together.

Tyson proved to be a relentlessly hard worker, streaming for seventeen hours straight and sometimes performing live sex shows with Hruskova. Tristan described her in private messages as his “main income,” adding that after several years she was “*STILL* in the dark” about how much money her streams made. According to court filings, she went on to earn him close to a million dollars. She also bore him a child.

Tyson is one of several former workers Tristan put me in touch with, saying that they would vouch for his innocence. Talking to me over Zoom, while her five-year-old daughter with Tristan played in the background, Tyson told me that the Tates were “just big, cuddly Teddy bears.” The other women Tristan recommended also rejected the idea that they were victims.

But even one of the Tates' defenders described Tristan as behaving like a "dictator," and said that, when she decided to leave, he attacked her verbally and hacked her social-media accounts. One of his associates threatened to set fire to her car.

The Tates' messages show that they repeatedly ordered associates to punish women by hijacking their social-media accounts and posting pornographic images of them to their followers. When another worker fled the operation, Tristan told Naomi John to log in to her Instagram account and "burn it down."

"Cool I feel like burning stuff down," John replied.

At the peak of the webcam business, the brothers reported, they had seventy-five women working for them; Andrew said that more than thirty women had his name tattooed on their skin. John returned to the U.K. and established a webcam house for the brothers in Hertfordshire. She couldn't be reached for comment, and it is unclear how much she knew about the Tates' recruitment methods. But several women who worked for the operation offered the same theory about her motivations. "Obviously, she was benefitting from it—she got her percentage," one said. "But I'm pretty sure she was in love with Andrew and trying to please him." At one point, Tate's messages show, he recorded a video about "only seeing a girl part time but loving her" and sent it to nine women, leading each to believe that it was exclusively for her. The names attached to the women's numbers in his phone included Jackass, Useless, Crazy Bitch, and Naomi.

Tate flaunted his growing wealth on social media, and a following coalesced. He showed a gift for pop-culture provocation, with posts that often went to the top of the trending charts. One of his first viral sensations started with a series of gibes at fans of "Star Wars." "Everyone who's ever watched star wars in human history is absolutely dirt poor," he posted, alongside a photograph of himself on a yacht. "Even watching a star wars trailer may leave you homeless, on the street, with aids." Tate also taunted vegetarians ("The souls of dead animals power my massive wang"), lovers of Japanese cuisine ("You know who eats sushi? Little fucking soy boys. Little fucking Democrats"), and people who preferred to drink still water ("You scared of bubbles, you little bitch?").

His fans looked to him for entertainment, but also for inspiration. Tate projected a credo of masculine excellence that revolved around self-discipline, physical prowess, and mental fortitude. He insisted that “depression isn’t real” and told sufferers to stop complaining and start working out. For young men feeling dejected by the public conversation about toxic masculinity, Tate’s celebrations of manhood were galvanizing, and his mocking assaults on feminism felt bracingly irreverent. “The reason feminists think men are losers is because the only men that bother to interact with feminists *ARE* losers,” he posted.

At the height of the #MeToo movement, Tate tweeted that women should “bare some responsibility” for being sexually assaulted. During the controversy that followed, his disdain for women began cohering into a political identity. He appeared on Infowars and then at the Conservative Political Action Conference, where he was photographed with Candace Owens, the right-wing television personality Jack Posobiec, and the far-right British politician Nigel Farage.

After the 2016 election, Tate had posted a string of pro-MAGA tweets, and he began messaging with Donald Trump, Jr. Eventually, he secured an invitation to Trump Tower. “That was the first time he had ever had any kind of interaction with anyone that big,” his former “harem” member told me. “It was like a drug to him.” After the visit, he posted a photograph of himself in a gold-embroidered blazer, clasping hands with a grinning Trump, Jr. He wrote, “The tate family support trump *FULLY. MAGA!*” Tate started selling an online course called Network Brilliance, in which he declared, “I have access to the president’s son,” and claimed to know “every big person in politics on the right.”

Tate’s longest-standing political connection was to Tommy Robinson, a far-right agitator whose Islamophobic rhetoric and inflammatory claims about Asian sex-grooming gangs have stoked violent unrest across several British cities. Robinson also grew up in Luton, and he and Tate knew each other well.



Cartoon by Mick Stevens

Tate was intrigued by one of Robinson's allies, the Canadian activist Lauren Southern. She had become a darling of the manosphere at the age of nineteen with a video titled "Why I Am Not a Feminist," in which she argued that men were the real victims of an unjust society. She followed up with a series of videos in which she trolled women who marched against sexual violence, ridiculing their views and holding up a sign saying *"THERE IS NO RAPE CULTURE IN THE WEST."*

In February, 2018, Tate asked Robinson to bring Southern to Romania to discuss a business venture. She told me that she flew to Bucharest without knowing much about Tate; Robinson had simply said that a kickboxer in Eastern Europe wanted to finance her work. When they arrived, Tate was waiting in one of his supercars, and he insisted on taking her out for lunch alone. Over steak, he told her "everything that you would want to hear as a conservative right-wing woman," talking about the importance of family and praising her work. "You're saving Western civilization," she remembers him saying.

After lunch, they headed to Tate's compound. At a long table, Southern listened as the brothers laid out their proposal: they would fund a new right-wing media venture, with her and Robinson in charge, if she would use it to pump a cryptocurrency they were planning to launch. The idea, she recalls, was, "basically, we're going to create a European-nationalist outlet to fleece all these idiots for money."

That evening, the Tates took Southern to a club, where they ordered bottle service. After a couple of shots of vodka, she recalls, she suddenly felt “like my consciousness was collapsing.” Tate carried her to his car, and when she came to they were on the bed at her hotel.

Tate started kissing Southern and pulling off her clothes. She told me that she tried to push his hands away, but he wouldn’t stop. Then he hooked his arm around her neck and started to squeeze. She remembers thinking, “Oh, shit, this guy actually is going to rape me.” Southern was anti-abortion, and was terrified of getting pregnant. She began pleading with him: “I know what you’re gonna do here. Please just wear a condom. Please.”

Southern remembers fading in and out of consciousness as Tate raped her unprotected and choked her. Afterward, he sat on the edge of the bed and said, “Don’t tell the press I raped you.” She remembers saying, “My whole brand is literally talking about how stupid bitches get themselves in situations like this. There’s nothing I can say without destroying my career. So congratulations.”

In the car to the airport, Southern said, she discovered burst blood vessels around her eyes and marks on her neck. Back in Toronto, she was examined by a nurse who specialized in sexual assault. On an assessment form, the nurse recorded that Southern had been raped and strangled by a “well known male” at a hotel in Romania and had suffered an intimate injury. She noted that Southern seemed to be experiencing “personal struggles with her belief system” as a result.

Southern told me that she tried to apply her political convictions to her experience, telling herself that she was at fault for drinking with a man she didn’t know. A month later, she texted Tate. “It was really shitty what you did that night in Bucharest,” she wrote. “I’m not going to tell anyone obviously because I was an absolute moron, but I hope you don’t do that to anyone else.”

“What did I do?” Tate replied. “I expected tons better from you. This msg is some liberal #metoo bullshit.”

“You literally strangled me when I said I didn’t want to have sex,” Southern wrote. “You literally told me in the morning ‘don’t tell the press I raped you.’ ”

“You’re absolutely embarrassing yourself,” he wrote.

Tate denied raping Southern, but he bragged to the War Room about spending the night with her, saying that he had invited her to Romania to discuss a business deal but “didn’t invest a fucking penny.”

Southern came to wonder if his proposal had been just a pretext. She thought back to her confrontations with women protesting sexual violence and felt regret. But, she told me, “I knew one hundred per cent there was no world in which I spoke about this where I got to retain my status within the right-wing world.” For years, she remained silent.

In 2019, Britain’s Crown Prosecution Service informed Tate that he would face no charges from the allegations of rape and strangulation that had caused him to flee the U.K. The police had let the case lie dormant. At the time, conviction rates for reported rapes hovered at around two per cent.

For Tate’s accusers, the long wait had been excruciating. “We were just so sick of having him in our minds,” Maya Navarro told me. “It’s always there—him, and us needing to go to court and get justice. Finding out that nothing was going to happen was very defeating.” The women were not told why it had taken four years to decide not to act. But prosecutors did write to all three of them, setting out reasons why *they* were apparently to blame for the collapse of the case.

Police officers had searched Navarro’s and Walker’s phones for anything that might compromise their credibility; prosecutors noted text messages, sent in the months after leaving Tate’s apartment, in which they talked about feeling “hoe-ish” and discussed “dick sizes.” Navarro was baffled. “Sorry, are we never allowed to talk about dicks ever again?” she said.

The letters also cited messages in which the women worried that police would find photographs of them surrounded by wine bottles, taken while they were working for the Tates. Navarro had reassured Walker in a voice

note, “We can just turn around and say that, with the alcohol, they used to get us drunk all the time.” Prosecutors appeared to view this as evidence of bad faith. They did not quote the rest of Navarro’s message: “I needed to be drunk to actually be there . . . ’cause I couldn’t take it.”

In Hannah Price’s case, prosecutors made no mention of the messages in which Tate had declared, “I love raping you.” Because she had slept with Tate again after the initial incident, they concluded that she had no case.

Finally, prosecutors noted that several women had gone to the police to support Tate’s story. One of them had produced a T-shirt reading “Tate is my daddy and I am his whore,” which she claimed belonged to Walker. Navarro told me that the T-shirt was actually Hruskova’s. “She’s just blatantly lying,” she said. Still, Navarro comforted herself that the investigation had served as a warning to Tate. “I genuinely thought, O.K., maybe this has scared him to not ever do this to somebody else,” she told me.

In fact, the C.P.S. decision had the opposite effect. “The strong conquer the weak,” Tate texted War Room members. “This is the way of the universe.” He started tweeting incessantly about sexual violence. “Only time you can beat her up without going to jail is during sex,” he wrote. “I have big hands because I was bred for violence. Like an attack dog. Do you understand?”

Tate went on to start Hustlers University, making tens of millions of dollars a year in subscription fees. He launched a podcast, “Tate Speech,” and an online show, “Tate Confidential.” He appeared on dozens of other manosphere and far-right shows. Suddenly, his face and his voice were everywhere.

Then Tate started openly taunting his accusers. In one interview, he addressed Walker. “I kept you for the money,” he said. “You weren’t all that, but you made me enough. You put the leather in the Ferrari, bitch. And now you’re sitting there broke as a joke. I’m still free.”

The women watched in horror. “Seeing him all the time, having him come back into my life unconsensually,” Navarro said. “That really pushed me to the edge.”

The Tates' most prized project was the War Room. Andrew billed it as "the most powerful network of men in the world," but mainly it was a series of group chats in which members learned how to make money by exploiting women. New entrants were inducted into the main group, the Great Hall, by an account called the Master of Scrolls and Decorum. They were sent a list of required reading, known as the Survival Scrolls, which included Ken Ivy's "Pimpology."

Tate's Pimping Hoes Degree course was the core of the curriculum. "Some women are more susceptible to being molded," Tate told pupils. To gauge a woman's malleability, members were taught to dismiss her harshly after sex and then demand an act of service—buying coffee or chocolate, cooking a meal. If she complied, she was through to the next level.

Once students had found a susceptible target, they were encouraged to move up to the webcam and OnlyFans courses, where they learned methods that the Tates had honed over the years. Tate filmed the OnlyFans course from a leather chair in his compound's cigar lounge. Beside him sat Hruskova, whom he introduced as "my not-so-beautiful assistant." She perched on her chair in a black turtleneck and a pleated skirt, blank-faced and fidgeting slightly as he denigrated women. "Girls are fantastically lazy," he said. "Girls have something wrong with them in their brains."

Tate was assisted in his teachings by Tristan and several other associates, whom he called the War Room Generals. Chief among them was a California-based hypnotist named Miles Sonkin, who went by the alias Iggy Semmelweis. Sonkin billed himself as an expert in neurolinguistic programming and cultivated a mystical affect, with a ponderous gray beard; in promotional videos, he appeared in a fedora and a cape, shooting rings of animated fire from his hands. His main role was to advise on how to hypnotize women into "sexual slavery"—often by uttering incantations during sex, a process he called "installing spells." Through his teachings, he said, members could keep women "soul-locked." (Sonkin did not respond to requests for comment.)



"Still too cold."

Cartoon by Michael Maslin

Tate leaned into Sonkin's pseudoscientific lexicon. He spoke about getting women to "self hypnotise" by demanding that they write him pledges of devotion, and shared screenshots of some that he'd received. One woman begged for the "honor of being your slave to serve you and worship you like you deserve . . . like a king, like a god." He told War Room members, "This is the level of locked I enjoy. Anything else is boring." (The chat logs were obtained by an independent journalist named Nick Monroe, who shared them with me.)

War Room members from around the world met at "summits" to compare notes. In Los Angeles, attendees were promised an evening of tutorials, including "Installing Spells & Sexual Magic," accompanied by "the best grass-fed Steaks grilled to perfection on an outdoor grill, fine aged whiskey, smoking Cuban and Empalador cigars." Another summit was arranged in a turreted castle in the mountains of Transylvania.

The Pizzagate conspiracist Mike Cernovich was a member, as was the far-right lobbyist Jacob Wohl, who bragged about supplying women to U.S. politicians, claiming that "these men will always want to win your good graces in hopes that you might toss them a girl or two." Wohl was later convicted of running a voter-suppression scheme targeting Black neighborhoods during the 2020 election.

The Tates shared "receipts" of the women they'd cultivated, often including intimate photographs. Over time, their recruitment efforts became more brazen. They began reaching out to high schoolers, and hosted parties for

teen-age girls at their compound. Andrew shared a video of one such event with the War Room. “16 year old hoes are all over the house,” he wrote, adding, “More girls = more money.” In a journal called “The Players Year,” Tristan documented scores of conquests, several of whom he said were teen-agers and virgins. One was wearing a school uniform. He wrote about another, “Inexperienced as she was, it caused her a lot of discomfort.”

Among the most vivid tutorials offered to the War Room was a play-by-play account of how Andrew Tate recruited Iasmina Pencov, the former psychology student. They had met in her home town of Timișoara, and Tate spent weeks love-bombing her over WhatsApp. When she arrived at the compound, though, he wasn’t there. Instead, he had deputized a blond woman named Beatrice Anghel to greet her. Anghel was a former producer for Romanian TV who had switched to online sex work after falling in love with Tate. He had texted her an assessment of Pencov: “She’s very dumb. . . . But will be good on camera.”

The Tates were now keeping many of their workers in American Village, the development beside their compound. Pencov was instructed to take her bags to Villa 67, where she would live with Anghel. Tate showed War Room members screenshots of his texts with both women, explaining that he had told Anghel that he loved her, and that Pencov was “just for cam”—while telling Pencov the same thing about Anghel. “They’re both spying on each other,” he wrote, with a crying-laughing emoji. “And when I’m home I’ll just fuck them both and make them work.” (Both women declined to speak with me, but they disputed this account through their attorney.)

In the next few weeks, Tate reported that Pencov had “lost her support networks at home” and was “talking about staying forever.” But, when he insisted that she start making pornography, she was less pliable than he had hoped. He turned to a trusted strategy: inventing a reason to get angry so that he could “tighten the screw.” Tate accused Pencov of having worked in a sex club back in Timișoara. “I literally totally made this up from the sky,” he told the War Room. “Started calling her a liar and threatening to kick her out.”

Pencov was horrified by the accusation. “I’m freaking crying alone in a room,” she texted him. “I’ve left everything and everyone behind.” He

replied, “You are never going back to Timisoara even to visit,” adding, “We are together. Always.” In the War Room, Miles Sonkin urged members to “look *CLOSELY* at what Tate has done here,” noting that he was “taking *SOLE AUTHORITY* over her life.”

When Pencov texted Tate that her Christian faith prohibited her from making porn, he wrote to the group, “This is about the maximum difficulty that you experience in the business.” If she didn’t crack within a few days, he said, he’d kick her out. Then Tate surveyed the chessboard. He knew that Pencov was running out of cash. “She’s broke,” he wrote. “And she can’t leave the house.” This gave her “no negotiating room,” he reasoned. “If there’s no goodbye, there is only comply.”

The next move was for Tate to distance himself from the notion of webcam work. He texted Pencov that he didn’t want her to think that he’d moved her to Bucharest to make porn for him. “I don’t need girls to work for me. I have plenty of my own money,” he said. She wrote back, “This literally made me cry.” Then he noted that there was a way she could make money of her own: a Romanian woman named Georgiana Naghel was running an OnlyFans operation. “Her business. Not mine,” he wrote.

In fact, Naghel had been working for the Tates for several years. A former hostess at cage-fighting galas, she was tall, with an air of sleek severity; Tate thought that she resembled Cruella de Vil, and called her his “very own full time witch.” He wrote to her, about Pencov, “Get her on only fans. I want money from her.” Then he told Naghel to send him messages about how much money could be made from porn, which he passed on to Pencov.

Pencov wrote back, “I don’t know what to say. I’ve never done anything like this before.” Tate noted to the War Room that this was “a very soft rejection.” Then he went in for a “hard close,” telling Pencov that webcam work was the only job that he would allow her to do. “A normal job puts men all around you,” he said.

“You are sure you want me to do this?” she asked.

“I want to believe you’re serious about us,” he said. “We’re either together always working as a team or we’re not.”

Members of the War Room followed along in delight. “It’s all a beautiful, beautiful game of chess,” one wrote. Sonkin identified the mind games Tate was using: “7 different Reframes in play. And a shit ton of presuppositions. . . . At least 2 undermines and a bunch of Skewers.”

Pencov texted Tate once more before capitulating. “I don’t ever sit around and feel sorry for myself nor let people mistreated me,” she wrote. “I’m a badass with a good heart, soft but strong. . . . But only with people that deserve to see this part of me.” Forwarding this to the War Room, Tate wrote, “Women talk so much bullshit it’s incredible.”

Naghel reported that Pencov started posing for OnlyFans within four days of vowing that she would never make porn. Next, Tate demanded that she have a threesome with him and Anghel, and she agreed. Anghel texted a friend that Pencov had told her beforehand that she was afraid, and that during sex Tate had hit her, spat in her face, and called her a whore. But Tate also told Pencov privately that she was his “wife forever” and that he loved her. “It’s so hard to believe,” she wrote back. “I have never been loved this much before.”

Within a couple years of launching the War Room, Tate reported that at least a hundred and forty students were making money from pornography. “Everyone in here is banking 10/15k extra a month,” he wrote. Members shared screenshots of women they had recruited. “Fucking *CASH WATERFALLS*,” one wrote. Another, who called himself A God Amongst Men, talked about scouring college campuses across San Diego for women to “smash” and then recruit. He was hoping to “get to millionaire status this year.”

One star pupil was a Texan man who said that he was making six figures while his girlfriend streamed for thirteen-hour stretches. He posted a photograph of her bent over a stool in a grimy workspace, next to a table set with what appeared to be lubricant, wipes, and sex toys. “Got her on Chaturbate, and sleeping in the concrete floored garage with no A/C, spiders, and roaches,” he wrote. “Absolutely legendary work,” Tristan responded.

The most zealous pimp was a meaty, shaven-headed Romanian named Vlad Obuzic, who ran a webcam studio in Bucharest. Obuzic was starstruck by Tate, who he said was “way above my level.” He enthused that “using his mindset helped me *ALOT* at ‘exploiting’ females.” Previously, Obuzic said, he had been careful not to “mix love with business,” but, since Tate had taught him that a woman is “loyal only to the dick that’s curenly fucking her,” he had started having sex with his top worker. In his estimation, the arrangement was going well. “She’s always crying because of me witch is a good thing,” he wrote. “I have control 95% over her mind.”

When another member asked Obuzic how he subdued recruits, he gave a recent example. “I took her keyboard and hit her in the head with it. She went in the room and worked 7 hours without any break,” he said, later adding that he had beaten every woman he had been with. Some users were perturbed by Obuzic’s stories. “That just sounds like abuse to me,” one wrote. But the Tates elevated Obuzic; he got his own channel, the Revenge Room, where he taught “raw, uncensored methods of pimping and handling women.” As his status grew, he dispensed lessons on handling local law enforcement. “I had multiple charges for beating people up, hitting them with bricks in the head etc and I just paid 500-1000\$ and nothing happened,” he said. “If you position yourself right, corruption suits you.”

In the compound, the influence of the Tates’ father lingered. Andrew’s former “harem” member said, “His dad told him that he needed to procreate as much as possible and spread their genes.” Women became pregnant, and Andrew has said that both he and Tristan have “double-digit” children. “I’m the big gorilla,” he said. “I take the fertile females and I impregnate them.” Mothers were moved to their own apartments, where they kept working on camera. The brothers sometimes visited, and Andrew has described meting out harsh discipline. “My kids obey me like fucking soldiers,” he said. On his orders, his five-year-old son would sit for hours in silence: “Doesn’t fucking move, doesn’t say a fucking word, because he’s scared for his fucking life.”

Elsewhere in American Village, discipline was often administered by two Romanian women. Tate had assigned Georgiana Naghel to “keep the farm animals on task,” and a former police officer named Luana Radu was

brought in to work alongside her. The two were a ferocious team. They issued instructions through a WhatsApp group called Suspicious Death, and punished workers who failed to comply. Women could be fined for failing to work their required hours, or for committing various offenses on camera, including crying or wiping their noses.

According to women who worked in the house, Iasmina Pencov racked up thousands of dollars in fines, effectively keeping her indentured. One day, Tate wrote her an accusatory note about her productivity, calling her a “cunt.” She replied that she had been “tired and sick,” with “too many thoughts” to fall asleep. She wrote to Naghel that she blamed herself for disappointing Tate: “I’m scared of a lot of stuff and I’m going crazy.” Another morning, when Pencov failed to meet her target, Naghel texted her while en route to the villa. “Punch yourself in the mouth till I get there, then I’ll give you 10 more, you hopeless lazy bitch,” she wrote. *“I HAVE A BAD FEELING THAT INSTEAD OF BREAST SURGERY YOU WILL GO TO THE MORGUE.”*



Tristan Tate wants to be known as “a clean-living, industrious, hardworking businessman.” Photograph by Mattia Balsamini for The New Yorker

At times, Radu and Naghel made good on their threats. When one woman, whom I’ll call Lorina Dobre, announced that she wanted to leave soon after the brothers funded her breast enlargement, Tristan instructed the enforcers to keep all her money and belongings to recoup their investment. “Hit her if you have to, I don’t care,” he texted, according to sealed court files. “Throw her out of the house with nothing.” The women were eager to oblige. “I want my money back or I’ll cut her tits off,” Naghel vowed.

Dobre later told police that the enforcers arrived at the villa and dragged her outside in her underwear, yanking her arm so hard that it wrenched a scar from her breast-enlargement surgery. “Georgiana wanted to kill her,” Radu wrote to Tristan. “I kept saying ‘beat her without leaving any marks, please.’ ”

“I love you girls,” he replied.

Dobre said that she waited outside for an hour, until another woman darted out to bring some clothes and her cellphone. Then she went to the police—but so did Radu, the former officer. Afterward, Radu reported that the police had said that they knew the Tates and didn’t want any trouble. (Naghel and Radu deny engaging in any criminal conduct, violence, or threats.)

The Tates were delighted by their enforcers. “There’s none of this ‘female’ team bullshit,” Tate tweeted about Naghel. “She obeys the boss.” For her birthday, the brothers threw a party at the compound. They presented her with a cake glazed in black icing, with the words “Queen of Hell” written in red letters. She cut it with a samurai sword.

In April, 2022, there was a new arrival at the compound: the young musician from Miami. The newcomer, whom I’ll call Ella Hadley, had met Tristan in Florida the previous November. She found him dashing and cultured—they talked about books, music, poetry, and art—and she felt that they were connecting deeply.

In WhatsApp messages to her mother, she wrote that she had made an “amazing friend” and sent a photo of Tristan in a crisp white shirt. He

owned “beautiful homes” in Romania, Monaco, and Miami, and was building a mountain residence near Dracula’s castle. Her mother sounded skeptical. “He’s v good looking,” she wrote. “Sure he’s got girls pining all around.” But Hadley insisted that he was a “true gentleman.”

Like other women the Tates cultivated, Hadley had a difficult past. She had been sexually abused as a teen-ager, and a former boyfriend had recently died by suicide. In Tristan’s room at the Mandarin Oriental, she confided in him about her ex-boyfriend’s death. He said that he’d once lost someone he cared about, too—a girlfriend had died in a car accident—and they discussed the strange contours of grief. “You’ve made me feel things I haven’t felt in a long time,” she texted him.

As their courtship progressed, Hadley texted Tristan, “Part of me wants to do anything you ask.” He replied, “I love how submissive you are.” One night, he invited her to a bar where members of the War Room were gathered, and she played piano for them. He told her that she dazzled him. Back at his hotel, they had sex, and he choked her till she lost consciousness. “I remember when you passed out,” he texted her afterward.

Hadley told her mother that Tristan wanted to bring her to Romania and take her to visit waterfalls and cultural festivals. “Awesome plans! Makes me dream,” her mother replied. “But keep your feet well anchored.” Tristan texted Hadley that she’d live in a big house, close to his own. She would teach him piano, and he would help launch her music career. After paying for her flights, he laid out some ground rules. The first was that he would not tolerate body hair. But the most important was that she must never talk to anybody in Romania unless he introduced her. “Romania is my world,” he wrote. “No friends from outside.”

When Hadley landed in Bucharest, Tristan picked her up in a blue Rolls-Royce. On the drive to the compound, she recalled, he made a joke about kidnapping her, and she was unnerved. When he took her into his bedroom, she later told police, “I simply froze and had sex with him.”

Hadley soon learned that Tristan was having sex with several of his workers. “I did not cry, nor did I complain,” she said. “I was scared.” He urged her to start posting for him on OnlyFans, but she resisted. “I can’t

show my body,” she texted him. “I want to teach you music and find a job nearby.” Still, after three days, Tristan moved Hadley into Villa 67 with the other recruits, who she thought looked unhappy and malnourished. Later, she said, she heard Naghel threatening to beat them if they broke the rules.

Hadley noticed another newcomer at the villa: a young Moldovan woman whom I’ll call Liana Vintilla. She seemed constantly upset, and Hadley decided to talk to her. At a party at the compound, she found a moment to draw her aside.

Hadley learned that Vintilla had been working as a restaurant hostess in London when Andrew connected with her on Instagram and began bombarding her with flattery. When she found videos online of him talking about pimping, he assured her that it was just “show business.” But, when she moved to American Village, he insisted that she post on OnlyFans. After several weeks of coercion and confinement, she succumbed. “Your wife goes live today,” she texted him.

Vintilla said that she was alarmed by life at the villa, where her housemates had “nightmares, spasms in their sleep.” She told Hadley that she wanted to run away, but Tate had forbidden her to leave. She was terrified of him. He had told her by text that he had mafia connections who might try to find her, and that he had the same blood chemistry as a serial killer. A few days earlier, after she wrote him that she was miserable, he had summoned her to his bedroom. There, Vintilla said, he punched her in the face and raped her, squeezing her head painfully between his hands. She said he threatened to get her pregnant and then lock her in a house—so that she would “definitely go crazy.”

That night, Hadley texted her mother, “Tristan and his brother are terrible people.” She said that she was making a plan to leave, along with “a girl who’s been stuck here.” Her mother replied, “I told you. Now try to get out of there quietly.”

Hadley booked seats on a flight to London, departing in two days. She texted Vintilla that they would have to be careful with the brothers, to “make them believe we are in love” so that they would “not suspect us of leaving.” Vintilla agreed to “play it cool.” They imagined that one day they

would look back on the experience and write a movie. Vintilla wrote, “We need a fucking Oscar.”

While the women prepared to flee, Hadley texted a family friend who was a marine. She said that the Tates were keeping her in a house with other women who acted as “groomers and handlers.” Her friend, who had learned to spot signs of trafficking during his military training, concluded that her life was in danger. He called his superior officer, who urged him to report the situation to the U.S. Embassy.

When Hadley learned what he had done, she panicked. “This is super scary,” she texted him. “They will kill us.” As the raid team approached, she ran upstairs and locked herself in her bedroom—which is where they found her when they broke down the door.

Mateea Petrescu was at her grandfather’s funeral outside Bucharest when her phone began buzzing with news: the Tate brothers had been accused of forming an organized-crime group to traffic women, and were being held in jail. Petrescu was a P.R. consultant in her late thirties who vaped continually, dressed in couture, and swore with creative flair. She knew all about the Tates; her cousin Eugen Vidineac was their local lawyer, and he’d been asking her for advice. Petrescu looked over at Vidineac, who was weeping as the casket was lowered into the ground. “Orthodox Romanian funerals are in a league of their own,” she told me. “They try to squeeze the last ounce of pain and suffering out of you.” Vidineac seemed too distraught to deal with the news, so she told him that she’d handle it.

In Bucharest, Petrescu joined the Tates’ team as the spokeswoman. She was thrilled. Many of her clients were nationalist Romanian politicians; the Tates were global celebrities. “It was the case of the moment,” she told me, and everyone she knew was “in awe.”

One of her first tasks was responding to a report that the Taliban were concerned about Andrew Tate’s well-being. The brothers had been trying to secure residency in Dubai, and Andrew had announced that he’d converted to Islam. When the Taliban seized control of Kabul, barring women from work and girls from school, he had tweeted approvingly, “Dinner will be

ready on *TIME*. The Taliban restores order. Inshallah.” Now the group was apparently calling for his freedom.

Petrescu’s initial counsel was “We don’t want to associate with the Taliban,” but, she conceded, “we don’t really want to upset the Taliban, either.” Privately, she thought, “Wow, this is my life now. I don’t want to upset the Taliban.”

For Petrescu, that kind of cognitive dissonance was part of the thrill of the job. She loved being the only woman on Tate’s crisis team and prided herself on being paid more than the men. While Tate was in jail, he had no access to the internet, but his “Tate Speech” newsletter and his posts on X kept appearing. Petrescu told me that she had written many of those words. She got a peculiar “amusement” from ventriloquizing the world’s most notorious misogynist, she said. But she was also impressed by Tate. “I’m absolutely fascinated by the balls he has, to say the things he says and not have an ounce of a sense of ridiculousness or guilt,” she told me.

The weeks after Tate’s detention were chaotic, Petrescu said. She could hardly keep track of the lawyers and advisers clamoring for a role in the case. “Everybody saw the goose with golden eggs,” she told me. She had expected someone as famous as Tate to have a well-structured operation, but what she encountered seemed to run on “a long chain of impulses and the deep belief that there is some sort of godlike inspiration that cannot go wrong.”

The Tates had a deputy managing their affairs while they were in prison: their cousin Luke Leilas, who had moved from the U.S. to work for them. On Andrew’s instructions, Leilas had been directing impassioned videos in which Hruskova, Pencov, and Anghel denied all the charges. “Don’t let them get lazy and wake up in the morning and look like shit,” Tate told Leilas. “No one cares what ugly girls say, they have to look amazing.”

Anghel gave an interview to Antena TV—the company where she had been a producer before Tate made her abandon her career—insisting that she was not a victim. Asked why she had Tate’s name tattooed on her arm, she said, “Out of respect.” Hruskova appeared in her own video, flawlessly made up in a fur-collared coat. “Imagine how outraged and mad would you be if this

happened to your son or your brother,” she said in English. “This is just a massive, massive violation against human rights.”

Tate was pleased. “Keep going!” he told Leilas, adding, “We need the girls to cry.” But their communications created a vulnerability: prosecutors had access to transcripts of the prison calls. Tate’s lawyers were dismayed when they found out. “I explicitly said to him that *EVERYTHING IS RECORDED*,” one complained in a chat. “I told him not once, but 5 times and still.”

Nonetheless, the lawyers successfully petitioned the court to release the Tates, on the condition that they stay in Romania and check in periodically with the police. When Andrew got out of jail, he announced, “I believe in God, and I think that the fire of truth will eventually destroy all lies.”

Romania has long been regarded as the European capital of human trafficking, and official corruption plays a significant role in the trade. But the prosecutor leading the case against the Tates, Rareș Stan, had an unsullied reputation. He was known as a pugnacious investigator who had dismantled some of the country’s most violent gangs.

As the brothers’ assets were seized, Ferraris, McLarens, and Lamborghinis were towed through their compound’s gates. Inside, investigators discovered guns, knives, and stacks of cash. They also seized phones and computers, containing a vast trove of digital evidence that Stan’s team used to track down dozens of the brothers’ recruits.

When the police interviewed Hadley, she urged them to help the other women who still supported the Tates. “These girls are not themselves,” she said. In Romania, victims in criminal cases can be eligible for damages running to hundreds of thousands of dollars, but Hadley didn’t want the money. “The only things she wants are peace and quiet,” investigators noted.

Vintilla gave a similar statement, and the two women agreed to coöperate with the authorities. They handed over their phones, underwent psychological evaluations, and provided sworn testimony. Afterward,

prosecutors arranged for them to be transported to a safe house in the South of France. Hadley posted a picture of herself wearing white linen by the sea.

In June, 2023, Stan filed an indictment of more than three hundred pages, detailing evidence that the Tates, Naghel, and Radu had trafficked the women housed in Villa 67. (The indictment was sealed, but I obtained a copy, along with an extensive cache of prosecutorial records.) The same month, prosecutors raided thirteen properties linked to Vlad Obuzic, Tate's disciple. He was arrested on suspicion of trafficking. Obuzic denied the charges, and is currently awaiting trial.

Meanwhile, Stan was building a wider case, involving at least thirty-five suspected victims—some of whom were minors. He established that Hruskova had been underage when Tate first compelled her to make pornography. He also pursued a case involving a girl I'll call Irina Pavel.



Many of the Tates' workers were housed in a development near Bucharest known as American Village. One said that Andrew Tate forbade her to leave, warning that he had mafia connections who knew what she looked like. Photograph by Mattia Balsamini for The New Yorker

When Pavel was fifteen, she told investigators, she had accompanied a school friend to a party hosted by the Tates, which was full of young girls. Her friend paired off with Tristan, leaving her with Andrew, who was so drunk that he spat as he talked. He pulled her into a bedroom and raped her, she said. Afterward, some of Tate's "female friends" persuaded the girls to stick around for several days, and Tate kept having sex with Pavel. "We had normal, oral, and anal sexual relations, but I mention that the anal sexual

acts were traumatic for me because I was in pain,” she told investigators. “Even though I asked Andrew to stop, he continued.”

The girls eventually had to go back to school, but, Pavel said, the Tates sent a taxi every few weeks to bring them to the compound. Tate was “often aggressive,” beating her with a belt and choking her—but he also bought her Teddy bears. Finally, he discovered that she had been chatting with a boy online and became furious, throwing her phone into the pool and kicking her out.

After Tate’s arrest, Pavel said, he took her to dinner at a restaurant called Arogant and tried to make amends. He told her that he hoped she would be “a good girl” and say nothing to the authorities, offering to pay her five thousand euros, with half up front. He also bought her a dummy phone to give to investigators, rather than her own. Pavel took the phone and the money—but ultimately decided to tell investigators that Tate had raped her. She wrote in a text, “You take her so young, you fool her and make her your slave? Fuck you.”

Ella Hadley spent a while recuperating in France, then decided to keep travelling. Eventually, she made it to Sydney. She was fearful of the Tates’ connections, and often disguised her appearance, but she liked spending her days outside, hiking and shopping at an open-air market.

A few weeks after the brothers’ arrests made the news, Hadley got a text from a former boyfriend in Florida, Marlin Fisher. He wanted to know if the man who had taken her to Romania was Andrew Tate.

“His brother,” she replied.

“Holy shit! I’m sorry,” Fisher said.

“I survived,” she wrote, “and there are other women who are now able to hopefully receive justice.”

Hadley had dated Fisher when she was seventeen and he was in his thirties. She had initially lied about her age, and the relationship had ended acrimoniously. Now his apparent sympathy didn’t last. A month after his

first note, he sent a more alarming one. “I’ve been asked to provide anything I still have from when we dated,” he wrote. “What I have from that time is a backup of my phone documenting everything you said about a ton of people.”

The people asking for Fisher’s phone were allies of the Tates. In the previous month, the brothers’ team had devised a strategy to push for Hadley’s “full surrender.” Their lawyers had threatened to sue her family for three hundred million dollars if she did not recant her testimony. When that had no effect, they sent private investigators to hunt for information to discredit her. Some were former F.B.I. agents, others fellow-influencers—including a British man named Sulaiman Ahmed, who had volunteered to travel to Florida.

Petrescu told me that she was dismayed by the decision to send Ahmed. “He was dumb as a rock,” she said. “Everything was done with a big sledgehammer.” He turned up at Hadley’s family home and tried to talk to her parents, then found his way to Fisher. (Ahmed disputes this account.)

When Tate’s team learned that Fisher had alerted Hadley to the visit, they were furious, calling him a “loser” and a “highly volatile asset.” Now they had to contend with Hadley’s lawyer, who wrote to Fisher, urging him not to participate in a “conspiracy to silence” her client, and pointing out that he had slept with Hadley when she was a minor. He turned over the phone data anyway.

Meanwhile, private detectives probed Hadley’s vulnerabilities as a witness. They discovered that, when she was fifteen, she had been repeatedly raped by her fifty-seven-year-old yoga teacher, who was later jailed for molesting her and another child. In her late teens, she had become entangled in a series of fraught relationships with older men, several times lying about her age and inventing fanciful stories about her life as she sought their affection. All of it went into the dossier.

Tate’s most bellicose advocate was Joseph McBride, a lawyer who’d made his name defending several January 6th rioters. McBride was a star in *MAGA* circles, dining at Mar-a-Lago and befriending Donald Trump, Jr. He filed a defamation lawsuit against Hadley in Palm Beach County, describing

her as a serial liar and “a predator who has a long history of baiting men into sexual relationships for the specific purpose of destroying their lives.” Another one of the Tates’ lawyers filed a claim on Fisher’s behalf, accusing Hadley of entrapping him. Pencov and Anghel filed their own claims against her, through the same lawyer. The Tates also sued Hadley’s parents and the family friend who’d initiated the raid.

As the case progressed, McBride reached for a startling variety of arguments to discredit Hadley’s claims about the Tates. He accused her of playing “on age-old stereotypes” about “men of African American descent,” saying that such allegations “may have been effective weapons in courts of segregation, but they have no place in today’s world.” He maintained that Hadley must have known that Tristan liked “rough sex,” and said complaining that he had choked her was “like getting into the boxing ring with Mike Tyson . . . and being surprised when you get punched.”

To publicize the case, McBride appeared on “Fresh and Fit,” a popular podcast in the manosphere. He called Hadley “pure evil” and said that she had used sex to “lure men in” for ten years—that is, since she was twelve. “One guy is serving a sentence he should not be serving in jail,” he claimed. “Another guy arguably killed himself due to his interactions with her.” If the case went to trial, he said, “I will rip her to shreds . . . body bag, for sure.” Or, he said, she could rescind her testimony, “and the whole thing just stops.” (McBride denies engaging in witness intimidation.)

McBride published Hadley’s name, birth date, and passport number, along with her parents’ address. Then Ahmed shared a distraught voice note that she had sent to Fisher years before, after her ex-boyfriend died by suicide. The post was headed “Unveiling The Woman Who Targeted Unsuspecting Men.” Candace Owens devoted an episode of her show to unpacking the claims about Hadley. McBride arranged for Tucker Carlson to fly to Romania for a fawning interview with Tate, which drew a hundred and twelve million views. McBride later said in a private chat that it had taken him “2 years of relentless work to shift the J6 narrative,” but that he was already “75% there on completely shifting American thought on Tate.”

In the next few months, posts attacking Hadley went viral on social media, and her accounts were deluged with threats—“I’m getting a hitman,” “You

deserve to die.” The Tates’ advisers warned them not to publicly take part in the smears. Instead, they proposed a “pussy” strategy: letting the affiliate network “have fun with the subject” while the brothers maintained a plausible distance.

Hadley was forced into hiding. In a court filing, she wrote, “The abuse I witnessed and experienced while in Romania was traumatizing. But the harassment and threats I have received in retaliation for cooperating with law enforcement have been even worse.” She added, “I am constantly fearful, sad, and alone.”

With the Tates’ webcam business dismantled and the travel ban holding them in Romania, they were struggling to fund their life style and pay their legal bills. They could never admit it—their brand was built on flexing their wealth—but, Andrew confided to advisers, “Nobody seems to understand we don’t have money.” Without the brothers travelling to create videos and promote themselves, subscriptions to their online school were declining. “Content is stale,” their cousin Luke Leilas said. “We need Andrew and Tristan free.”

In 2024, as the U.S. election approached, Tate pinned his hopes on Donald Trump. Barron Trump had been tasked with reaching a young male audience, and Tate intended to help him deliver. Justin Waller, a close associate who has called himself the Tates’ “third brother,” agreed to be the intermediary.

In April, Waller secured an invitation to Mar-a-Lago and began courting Barron. He offered dating advice and introduced him to a tailor, who made the suit that Barron wore to his father’s second Inauguration. During the fitting, Waller later said, Barron spoke with Tate over Zoom.

That summer, after the assassination attempt on Trump in Pennsylvania, Tate said that he had spoken to Barron again. “I’m very close with the Trump family,” he said. He and Donald Trump, Jr., also appeared on a live stream to promote a *MAGA* meme coin. “You’ve got people attacking you, as far as I’m concerned,” Trump, Jr., said.

Tate spent the day of the election live-streaming, ordering his followers to vote. “America is over if Trump loses,” he tweeted. When the results came in, Petrescu said, the Tates were overjoyed: “Oh, the celebration! Trump is now President. We’re going to be fine.”

Afterward, J. D. Vance followed the brothers on X. Then Donald Trump selected one of their lawyers, Paul Ingrassia, to serve as the White House liaison to the Department of Justice. Ingrassia, a twenty-nine-year-old associate at the McBride Law Firm, had worked on the case against Hadley. He had previously tweeted that Tate was “the embodiment of the ancient ideal of excellence,” which was why he had been targeted by “the satanic elite that attempt to systematically program and oppress all men.” The President’s counsellor Alina Habba appeared on a podcast with Tate, telling him that she was a “big fan” and declaring, “I’ve got your back.” She said, “I think you go through a lot of the same ‘Show me the person, I’ll find the crime’ that President Trump has gone through.”

A few weeks after the election, the brothers received more good news: their Romanian indictment had been sent back to prosecutors. The Bucharest Court of Appeal had identified several procedural errors that needed fixing, which meant that the case would be seriously delayed.

The travel ban was still in place. But Rareș Stan had been replaced by a less experienced lead prosecutor, Cezar Profira, whom the Tates and their Romanian lawyers apparently considered a softer touch. (Profira did not respond to requests for comment.) The brothers told me that Profira had joked with them about Hadley during an interview, saying, “You should have bought her a handbag.” In private messages, their advisers talked about needing Profira “on our side.”

Three weeks after Trump’s victory, Romania held its own Presidential election, and again the Tates played an unusual part. The brothers had been backing a right-wing candidate named Călin Georgescu, who was a virtual unknown until he won the first round of voting. Georgescu was stridently pro-Russia, and the Kremlin celebrated his victory—but Romania’s Constitutional Court annulled the result, citing evidence of interference.

The ensuing controversy gave U.S. officials a pretext for taking an interest in Romania's internal affairs. J. D. Vance, Elon Musk, and other right-wing figures suggested that liberal élites had stolen the election. Trump's special Presidential envoy Richard Grenell accused Romania of joining a global conspiracy to silence "people and politicians who weren't woke."

Petrescu told me that the team had been lobbying Grenell to help the Tates, and that he was willing. "Ric was rooting for the boys," she said. Soon after the cancelled election, Grenell met at Mar-a-Lago with a Romanian politician named Victor Ponta, who later told the Times that they had discussed the Tates' case. (Ponta told me that he no longer remembered this and had no involvement with the Tates. Grenell denied aiding the Tates or speaking about their case with Ponta, though he has publicly affirmed, "I support the Tate brothers.")



"It says, if you don't have certain ingredients, you can substitute two double cheeseburgers, a fountain soda, and fries."

Cartoon by Jeremy Nguyen

Then, Petrescu told me, the Tates' team devised a P.R. gambit. The Munich Security Conference was approaching. If Grenell could discuss the case with the Romanian foreign minister, Emil Hurezeanu, they would make sure that a reporter was positioned to overhear the conversation. When Grenell met the minister, Petrescu recalled, "Ric only asked, 'Hey, how are the Tate boys?' That's all they needed. It went into a media frenzy immediately. 'The Americans are pressuring for the release of the Tate brothers!'"

Meanwhile, Vance went onstage at the conference and denounced Romania for annulling Georgescu's victory. He argued that there were "entrenched interests, hiding behind ugly, Soviet-era words like 'misinformation' and 'disinformation,' who simply don't like the idea that somebody with an alternative viewpoint might express a different opinion."

Hurezeanu, the foreign minister, told me that the government "took this criticism by Vance very seriously," not least because Romania borders Ukraine and relies on the U.S. for its defense. He said that, when he saw Grenell at the conference, he raised the Tates' case preemptively. It seemed clear to him that Trump's people were backing the Tates, because of the "electoral support" that they'd provided in 2024; now the brothers seemed to be "playing a role within the bilateral relations" of the two countries. (The White House denies this.)

After the conference, Petrescu said, prosecutors reached out to the team and asked, "O.K, what do the Americans want?" The answer was that the brothers must be cleared to travel. "Literally the next morning the restrictions were lifted," Petrescu said. A senior Romanian law-enforcement source told me that the decision appeared to have been imposed from "outside the judicial system," adding, "It is not normal for individuals accused of child trafficking to be able to travel freely." The longtime Trump ally Roger Stone tweeted, "Richard Grenell secured the release of the Tates," then hastily deleted the post.

A source who was present when the Tates learned that they were free to travel told me that the message was delivered by a senior Romanian politician—one who had recently been to Mar-a-Lago. The politician turned up at their compound at night in a black S.U.V. "The Americans are asking questions now," he told them. "Here's your passports back. Happy flying."

On February 27, 2025, the Tates flew from Romania to Florida. Thousands of fans tracked their private jet as it crossed the Atlantic. When it landed in Fort Lauderdale, a crowd of journalists and onlookers was gathered outside the executive terminal to watch the brothers arrive. "They were expecting this grand tour—the martyr comes home, a free-speech hero," Petrescu told me. There was a hitch, though: border officials seized the Tates' phones. They were working on behalf of the Department of Homeland Security,

which had quietly opened an investigation into the brothers under the Biden Administration.

Tate made a furious appearance on Candace Owens's show. "You think I sleep with a phone full of evidence?" he said. "You think I don't wipe my phone every night? You think I'm dumb? Come get me." Petrescu told me, "I had never seen him so unhinged." She felt grimly vindicated, having advised the brothers against flying to Florida, where Hadley and her family lived. It seemed to Petrescu like blatant witness intimidation. Only a couple weeks earlier, Hadley's pro-bono lawyer had filed a counterclaim against the brothers for human trafficking, coercion, defamation, and harassment, alleging that they were attempting to silence her.

Tate embarked on what amounted to a publicity tour of right-wing America. He and Tristan were photographed puffing cigars with Roger Stone, whom Andrew hailed as the "lawfare OG." In Las Vegas, they were greeted ringside by Dana White, the president of the U.F.C., who hugged them and declared, "Welcome to the States, boys!," before greeting other guests, including Grenell and Kash Patel, the F.B.I. director. In Los Angeles, Tate met with Kanye West. He tweeted at California's governor, "I'm in LA. Please begin criminal charges."

Later, he headed to the Beverly Hills Hotel to spend the night with a model named Brianna Stern. He had met Stern a year earlier, when she came to Romania for photo shoots to promote his meme coin, \$Daddy. Tate's seduction followed his familiar pattern: he said that he loved her and called her a whore, demanded that she have his baby and told her, "I want to beat the fuck out of you." At the hotel, Stern alleges, Tate choked her and battered her head and face, telling her repeatedly that he would kill her if she ever crossed him.

Afterward, she went to a doctor, who diagnosed post-concussion syndrome. Stern waited for Tate to leave the country, then told the Beverly Hills police that he had assaulted her. She also filed a civil suit, attaching her medical report and a series of texts in which he'd threatened to beat her.

When Petrescu learned of Stern's allegation, her reaction was "You gotta be fucking kidding me." She said to colleagues, "We all have kinks. But can he

please, please, please have some vanilla sex for six months?” Petrescu told me she was predisposed to accept Tate’s explanation that Stern was an opportunist looking for money. But the texts attached to the lawsuit made for grim reading. “There’s stuff I know about the Tates, from reading a lot of the depositions, declarations, text messages, that one doesn’t really want to know about their client,” she said. As a P.R. person, she added, “you don’t question—you can’t.” But she began to worry that she was normalizing Tate’s behavior: “I started wondering, Is that seeping into my subconscious? Am I becoming that?”

The Tates were in constant motion in the following months, posting from pricey hotels in the Bahamas, Turkey, Kazakhstan, and Hong Kong. Still, Andrew seemed bored. “I miss human trafficking,” he tweeted. “The emotions ran high. Been chasing dopamine ever since.” His online rants were becoming increasingly extreme. He responded to the release of the Epstein files by posting that “women have become such lying whores that it’s impossible to take any of these unsubstantiated claims seriously.” Despite his mixed heritage, he promoted the great-replacement theory, declaring, “The west is collapsing because it’s full of disgusting traitors. White people who beg to be erased.”

In the American courts, Tate was enjoying a run of good fortune. The L.A. district attorney announced in June that he would not be prosecuted for his alleged assault on Stern, citing insufficient evidence. McBride claimed that he’d given the D.A. a “do-not-prosecute packet” demolishing the case; he promptly filed a fifty-million-dollar defamation suit against Stern. In Florida, Judge G. Joseph Curley dismissed most of Hadley’s counterclaim, including the allegations that the brothers had harassed her and attempted to coerce her into sex work; he, too, cited a lack of evidence. “Thank God for U.S. justice,” Tate tweeted.

There was a threat from the U.K., though. British police had been investigating the origins of the Tates’ webcam business, and had charged them with a combined twenty-one counts of rape and trafficking. But a Romanian judge ruled that the brothers could not be extradited until the local proceedings were complete—and, two years after Cezar Profira took over, the trafficking case seemed to be going nowhere. Prosecutors hadn’t

even fixed the procedural errors in the initial indictment. In chats with advisers, Tristan acknowledged that he and Andrew were effectively being “protected by Romania.”

Romania has recently been rocked by a judicial-corruption scandal: a documentary called “Captured Justice” revealed that judges were being pressured to dismiss or delay politically sensitive cases. More than nine hundred judges and prosecutors have since signed an open letter warning of systemic abuses, and protesters have marched through Bucharest, demanding reform. One of the country’s most senior prosecutors called Romania a “paradise for criminals.”

This April, the Tates were released from all bail conditions relating to the Romanian indictment. The brothers were jubilant. “Case never made it past trial. Innocent,” Tate wrote to advisers. “Yeah we spin it as this. If we can,” Tristan replied. “Then when we’re reindicted they look stupid.”

Their lawyer responded with three sweating-laughing emojis. “Noooo,” he wrote. “Remember, we need cezar on our side.”

“Cezars a piece of shit I hope he dies,” Tristan wrote. “Me being nice to him has done me no favours.”

In March, Tate addressed the British government in a video posted from a harborside balcony in Hong Kong. “Come extradite me if you have such a strong case,” he said. “You know you have nothing. Everyone else has tried. Everyone else has failed.” He added, “I am the main character of Earth.”

In the political landscape that Tate helped create, women hold an increasingly precarious position. These days, the far-right podcaster Nick Fuentes will openly say that women should be kept in “breeding gulags,” and the ultra-popular Joe Rogan will host a just-asking-questions discussion about whether the feminist revolution was a huge mistake. Influential Christian leaders are calling to repeal women’s suffrage. A man was elected President after being held liable for sexual assault.

Even in this milieu, Tate’s violent rhetoric stands out. “I saw a woman crossing the road today but I just kept my foot down,” he posted after

Trump's reelection. "Right of way? You no longer have rights." His influence is being felt around the world. Last year, a seventeen-year-old boy in New Jersey allegedly drove his car into two teen-age girls, killing them both, after joking on a live stream about women getting raped by Tate. In Britain, a man who had recently watched about ten of Tate's videos raped his ex-girlfriend and murdered her, her mother, and her sister using a crossbow. British police have warned that Tate's teachings are radicalizing young men in a "terrifying" manner and declared that violence against women is a national emergency. Reports of rapes and sexual assaults in British schools—some involving victims as young as five—have soared in the past five years, and education leaders describe violent misogyny spreading on an "epidemic scale." Similar concerns have been reported across North America and Asia.

Yet Tate could have faced justice more than a decade ago, when Navarro, Walker, and Price accused him of assault, if British police had taken their allegations seriously. "They failed to protect the initial victims and created this problem," the senior Romanian law-enforcement source told me.

In my reporting, I discovered something that the British police had hidden for years: their officers bungled the investigation from the start, making it almost impossible to bring Tate to trial. When Price first came forward, officers neglected to take a statement and discouraged her from pressing charges, telling her that it would be a long and difficult process. They also failed to make a digital recording of Walker's initial statement, instead jotting her words down on paper so sloppily that Tate was at one point referred to as "Michael." This introduced discrepancies that undermined an account she later gave on video. Multiple items of evidence were also stored incorrectly—including Tate's phone, which was left lying around the station while the case stalled.

When the phone was eventually searched, it apparently contained important evidence—Tate later said that officers had found proof of twelve "bad things I did"—but the chain-of-custody lapse made it practically useless. Prosecutors, hoping to salvage the case, gave police a list of leads, but they failed to act on them. A longtime Hertfordshire detective blamed the malfeasance on "overworked, overstretched" officers who failed to take the

women's allegations seriously, partly because two of them were sex workers. "It was one of many cases that were completely cocked up because of poor policing," he told me.

This spring, after I reached out to current and former officers about the investigation, the Independent Office for Police Conduct suddenly announced that it had launched an inquiry into gross misconduct in the case. The next day, the Hertfordshire police declared that they were reopening their own investigation, more than a decade after the women first came forward.

Tristan panicked. "New charging decision = new warrant," he wrote to his advisers. "Means we're not protected by Romania at all and he can be picked up at anytime from anywhere." In a voice note, he added, "We're just gonna have to fucking stay in Dubai and the United States and stop traveling and fucking get some extradition lawyers."

Navarro, Walker, and Price were already pursuing a civil claim for damages. After the brothers were arrested in Romania, the journalists Jamie Tahsin and Matt Shea reported on the women's stories for Vice News, and another woman said that she, too, had been strangled and raped by Tate in 2014. The four women launched a crowdfunding campaign to "Bring Andrew Tate to Justice in the U.K." and filed a claim against him in Britain's High Court.

The Tates were dismissive of the civil case. Andrew wrote to his advisers, "Nobody cares besides 50 retards," adding, "I'm too important to give them relevance." But when Tate checked on the crowdfunding campaign, this spring, he was shocked to find that it had raised more than three hundred thousand pounds. "Go get him," one woman wrote under a ten-pound pledge. Another, donating five pounds, wrote, "Your bravery is astounding. We are all with you." Looking at the total, Tate wrote, "That's a lot of money." Then he snapped back into character: "I don't acknowledge my cases. . . . I ignore all this none of it's real."

Soon afterward, Petrescu quietly resigned. "I am not leaving because he is a misogynist. I am leaving because the tragedy has become too cringe to watch," she wrote, in a proposal for a book that she plans to write about

working for the brothers. “They lie like there’s no tomorrow,” she told me. “I stopped believing in Andrew.”

When the British civil case goes to trial, one of the witnesses will be Lauren Southern, the former far-right activist, who has since disavowed many of her past views. She told me that she’d decided to get involved after watching Tate’s other victims fight for justice. “The idea that I had evidence, I had medical records that could be added to these cases, and I was doing nothing—that was really eating me up inside,” she said. Last year, she self-published a memoir that detailed her experience with Tate. She broke into tears as she told me that speaking out was “the only way to actually heal anything.”

Tate has always relied on Hruskova to support his story. Since the brothers’ webcam operation was dismantled, she has been living in Dubai, where she has trained as a gemologist, specializing in lab-grown diamonds. She declined to speak to me, and has remained publicly loyal to Tate, but there are signs that her perspective may be shifting.

Hruskova recently launched a Telegram channel, *Viviens Wonderland*, which she describes as a “safe space” for women to discuss topics including recovering from traumatic relationships, sexual assaults, and leaving the sex industry. I joined the channel via a public link this January. Inside, Hruskova presided over chats with sisterly energy, dispensing reassurance, pep talks, and relationship tips.

She bristled when members asked about her past. “If any of you mention Andrew or remarks regarding him or our past relationship youll get kicked out,” she once declared. But at times her guard slipped. When one member asked her how it had felt to be in a relationship with someone who slept with other women, she replied, “Horrible, do not recommend it to *ANYONE*,” and added, “No woman can stomach it for long period of time.” She wrote that Tate was the only man she had ever been with, and that since leaving him she had committed to celibacy. It had taken seven sessions of tattoo removal to erase his branding from her skin.

When a group member wrote about missing an ex-partner who had abused her, Hruskova’s response was fiery. “what exactly is it you miss?” she

wrote. “How you felt literally worthless? How youd cry with him every day? And then knowing how *TERRIBLE* you felt and he made you feel, add this—he *KNEW* what it would cause you and still did it. Thats not love, never was.”

One afternoon in Bucharest, Tristan met me at a surf-and-turf restaurant overlooking a lake. He wore a wide-lapelled burgundy suit and purple alligator winklepickers, made by King Charles’s shoemaker. At the table, he took off a gold Rolex and invited me to feel its weight. He ordered grilled octopus, followed by two steaks.

Tristan told me that he was determined to clear his name. “I’m Tristan Tate, the human trafficker—that’s what everyone says about me. Everyone thinks I’m a horrible person. Everyone thinks I commit crimes against women. Before my daughters grow up, I need to prove that I’m not that guy,” he said. “My life has been destroyed, and this should not be my story.” He denied using calculated seduction to recruit women, but acknowledged that he’d had sex with many of his workers. “I’ve got beautiful, naked women in my house,” he said. “What do you think is going to happen?”

The whole webcam business was a distant memory, he insisted. “I learned a lot about the nature of men, how perverted and weird they are,” he said. “It made me like men a lot less. It certainly made me hate pornography and understand that it’s a toxic influence.” When I asked about his own proclivity for choking women, he scoffed. “ ‘Fifty Shades of Grey’ is the most popular female book ever,” he said. “The idea that this book sold hundreds of millions of copies, and that there aren’t women who will ask a tall millionaire who likes to wear suits to choke them during sex like it’s my idea, is a wild leap of faith.”



“Remember, it’s illegal to use your phone while driving. Instead, use the giant iPad built into the car.”

Cartoon by Natalie Horberg

After lunch, Tristan beckoned for the bill and refused to let me pay—“I’m a misogynist. You’re not allowed.” Outside, a bodyguard led me to a waiting Aston Martin, and Tristan nosed the car out onto the street. As he sped across town, he told me that he retained high-placed connections in Romania who were “very apologetic” about the case. We pulled up outside a Davidoff cigar emporium. Inside, Tristan breezed past the front desk, calling out, “A big one for me, a small one for her,” before leading me into an elevator. When the doors closed, he quipped, “Now you can’t leave.” A few floors up, they opened to reveal a low-lit lounge with heavy green curtains and black leather armchairs.

Over cigars, Tristan brought up Ella Hadley, the young woman from Florida. “She has drastically altered the course of my life,” he said. “I should be known as a sportsman, a clean-living, industrious, hardworking businessman.” When he thought of Hadley, he said, his mind was “clouded by the fog of war.”

He wanted me to interview Hadley, as well as her pro-bono lawyer. “I hope you get in touch with these retards,” he said. “I super-duper-duper hope they talk to you, because I will use your article to get more money out of their asses in court.” He also urged me to include a “tribute” to Hadley’s ex-boyfriend who died by suicide. (Hadley, who has never spoken to the media, declined to be interviewed.)

The elevator door opened, and Andrew Tate walked in. “The bad guy, the bogeyman,” he said, grinning, as he shook my hand. He was dressed casually, in a green suède jacket and black sweats, but his watch was heavily iced with diamonds, as was a chain around his neck. “Kill the music,” he told Tristan. “I’m low on time, so let’s go.”

Tate started by telling me that his reputation as a misogynist was “completely unfair.” He explained, “What I am is a realist who has certain world views on how men should act, which is with honor and duty, and they shouldn’t be hurting women in any way. Of course, on the internet, you use hyperbole, and you exaggerate sometimes for comedic effect.”

He told me that the case against him had been cooked up by his political foes. “What they’re trying to do is to attach heinous allegations to my name so that people talk about the allegations instead of my ideas,” he said. “The Western world’s on the edge of collapse, and they’re very afraid of that.” Both brothers dismissed the War Room messages as “unmoderated chats,” and claimed that the thousands of incriminating texts filed in court had all been mistranslated from English to Romanian.

When I asked how the travel ban had come to be lifted, Tate denied that Donald Trump had personally intervened, but said he had learned from powerful people in Bucharest that the restrictions were removed because of American pressure. “Romania just overthrew its election. Too many people are looking at our processes,” he said he had been told. “It’s too messy. They want you gone.” Now he was certain that the case would fail. “The chance of this getting to trial is zero,” he said.

Tate deflected most of my questions with well-worn arguments, but when I asked about Hruskova he seemed caught off guard. “If I’d ever hurt her, why has she released all those videos defending me?” he said. Soon, he announced that he needed to leave. He bumped into my photographer on the way out, but refused to stick around for pictures. “I didn’t like some of her questions,” he said.

With his big brother gone, Tristan settled into an armchair under a gold spotlight and posed for photos with apparent contentment. “Supermodel, huh?” he said, puffing on his cigar. Then he was struck by a thought. “You

know who ruined the ‘I don’t need to rape women because I’m handsome’ excuse?” he asked. “Ted Bundy.” He went on, “Ted Bundy ruined it for fucking everyone, because he was a psychopath and he killed a bunch of women and he was handsome and charming. If it wasn’t for him, that would still be a plausible reason.”

When the photo shoot was over, Tristan headed for the elevator. Then he suddenly turned back. “Come on, give me a hug,” he said, striding toward me. In the moment before his arms encircled me, there seemed to be no choice. ♦

*[Heidi Blake](#) is an investigative reporter for *The New Yorker* based in the U.K. She hosted the podcast series “Blood Relatives” with *In the Dark*.*

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- **[Ticks to Fear This Summer](#)**

By Jay Ruttenberg | Physically resembling a crossbreed of a gremlin and Stephen Miller's soul, the Gray-Legged Tick can be found wherever it is even moderately interesting to vacation in the Northeast.

[Shouts & Murmurs](#)

Ticks to Fear This Summer

By [Jay Ruttenberg](#)

June 8, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

Gray-Legged Tick

Physically resembling a crossbreed of a gremlin and Stephen Miller's soul, the Gray-Legged Tick can be found wherever it is even moderately interesting to vacation in the Northeast. These arachnids hatch from eggs incubated in moist woodchuck feces, then affix themselves to the nearest dupe naïve enough to leave the city. Although the ticks are otherwise harmless, note that, once bitten, you will smell of rodent diarrhea. Forever.

Red-Bodied Dog Tick

Has your idiotic dog wandered onto a bucolic patch of grass that hasn't been freshly treated with toxins? Then he may be carrying a Red-Bodied Dog Tick and her thirteen thousand about-to-hatch eggs. Once you have returned to the city, from which you clearly never should have strayed in the first place, the tick larvae will emerge, bearing grotesque little fangs. Who knows what they'll choose to latch onto? Your bed linens? Your sugar bowl? Your pubic hair? Best to wash everything in fire, just in case!

Mid-Atlantic Longhorned Tick

One brush with this guy and—honestly, you don’t want to know. Have you heard about that autoimmune disorder that renders people deathly allergic to happiness? You’ll only wish you had that one. The good news is that there are several precautions you can take to avoid this virulent tick. When in sight of a tree, make sure to wear two pairs of thick socks—pulled up over your pant legs so that you look like a complete asshole—and meticulously spray your entire face with insect repellent. (To insure that it’s effective, use only those *DEET* sprays labelled “Warning: Use of This Product Will Give You Cancer Immediately.”) Male hikers, remember to always wear a condom beneath your undergarments—otherwise the tick will make a swift break for your penis.

Eastern Forest Tick

Examined under a microscope, this minuscule parasite bears an uncanny resemblance to your childhood bully, right down to its mullet and Van Halen T-shirt. It gives its prey an undetectable autoimmune disorder that makes the sufferer feel mysteriously enervated, able to summon only enough energy to ceaselessly complain to exasperated loved ones. Meanwhile, back in the woods, the tick that bit you will become a paragon of efficiency and sensuality, the merest drop of human blood acting as a potent mélange of transcendental meditation, Bolivian cocaine, and praise from gorgeous strangers.

Low-Country White Tick

Beware this diminutive smidge of unadulterated malevolence, which enjoys nothing more than creeping along the neck of an unsuspecting hiker who, for some reason, craved an expensive weekend of “country air.” Remember: the only sightseeing activities you should plan for your vacation are meticulous tours of your bodily crevices as you conduct hourly panicky tick checks.

Hudson Valley Fox Tick

Although studies are still inconclusive, a growing number of entomologists believe that this tick is actually Adolf Eichmann, reincarnated into a billion little bastards and sent to Earth as an emissary of Satan. When the Hudson Valley Fox Tick finds you in nature—and it will—it burrows into your most

vulnerable exposed body part, which will rapidly swell to a size scientists categorize as “oh-my-God-what-the-fuck-is-that?!” Have fun locating a country doctor who will prescribe antibiotics within a two-hour window. Otherwise, you guessed it—autoimmune disorder! Bid farewell to your carefree days of eating carbohydrates without the assistance of a steroid injection. ♦

[Jay Ruttenberg](#) edits the comedy journal *The Lowbrow Reader*. He is the author of “[Gabba Gabba We Accept You](#).”

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By Roz Chast | One man's naval adventure, fuelled by hops.

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By Andrea Bajani | There was something absurd and distressing in that prelude to the domestic drama.

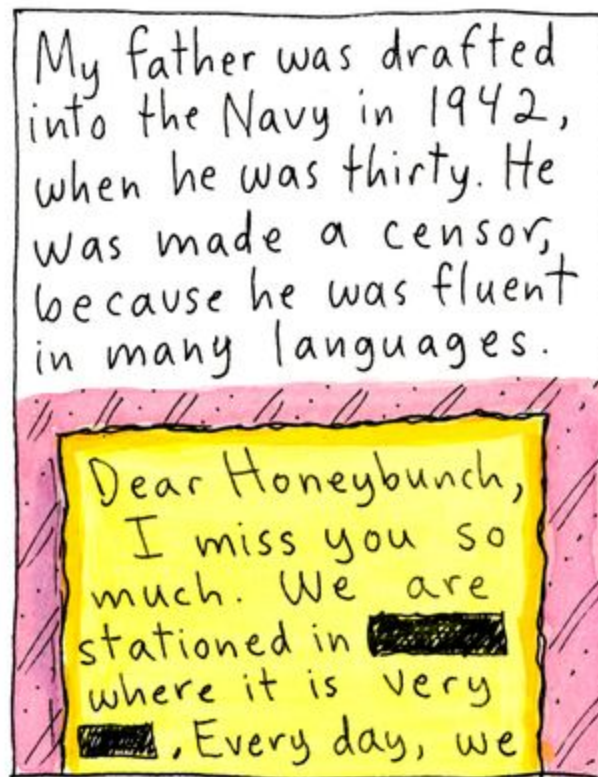
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A Dad Story, or, After Six Beers

One man's naval adventure, fuelled by hops.

By [Roz Chast](#)

June 8, 2026



He was older than the other draftees and wore glasses. They nicknamed him Professor.



He was physically timid,
possibly because of his
overprotective mother.



In spite of these things,
he was not only accepted
but well liked.



One day, the "fellows,"
as he called them, were
curious to see how he
would fare if he drank
six beers in a row.



My dad liked beer,
but having six in a row
was probably a new
experience for him.

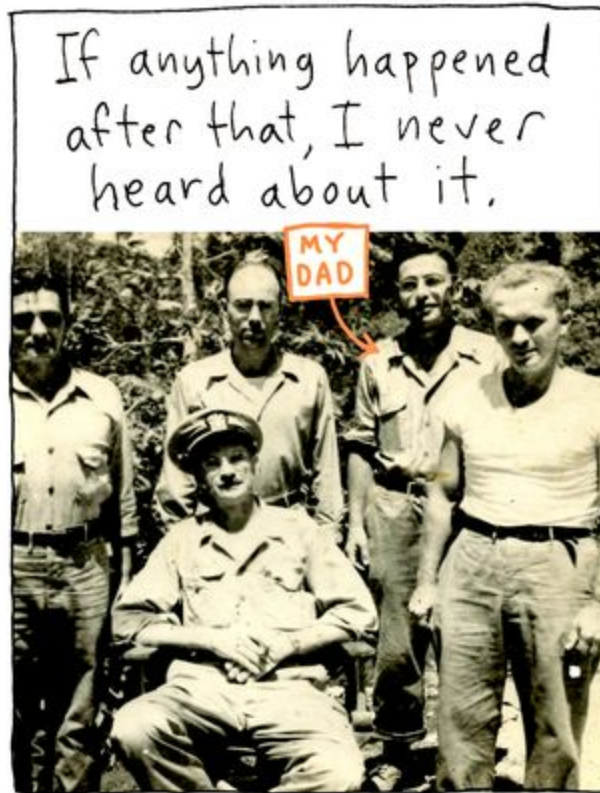


When he completed the task, he walked up to the blastery-est and braggy-est "fellow"...



...and announced,





R. Ch

[Roz Chast](#) has been a *New Yorker* cartoonist since 1978. Her books include the graphic narrative “[I Must Be Dreaming](#),” published in 2023.

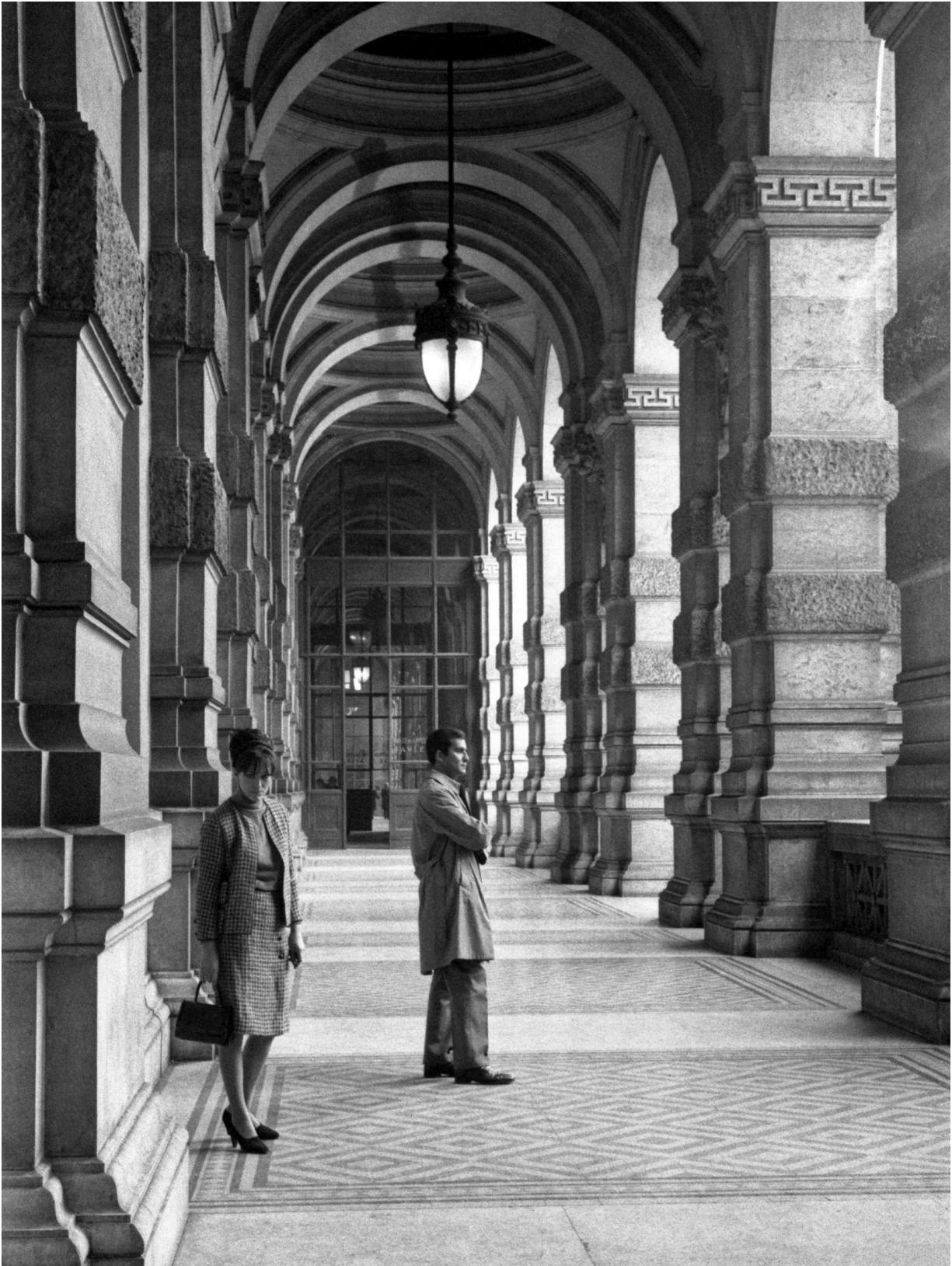
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[Fiction](#)

Constellation

By [Andrea Bajani](#)

June 7, 2026



Photograph by Marisa Rastellini / Mondadori Portfolio

When I think of the free time my mother spent with my father, in our small town outside Turin, this is the scene I usually picture: she's on the couch, working through *La Settimana Enigmistica*, a weekly word-puzzle magazine, while he reads a book. She looks bored; her glasses have slipped down the bridge of her nose, where they remain out of carelessness rather than to help her eyes focus. She's waiting for him to finish reading and decide what to do with whatever time remains before dinner. Did she find crossword puzzles interesting? Fun? I suspect they were mostly a way to kill time. In my memory, she's often distracted, looking out the window. Or, more often still, she's dozing off, pencil dropping from her hand, head lolling onto the back of the couch or to one side, mouth half open. I don't know if she had a passion for fitting words into boxes as much as a desire to conform to the version of herself that my father had laid out.

“This is a book for your mother” was my father's way of declaring that a novel wasn't any good. The phrase did contain a kind of affection, the perverse, frank, aggressive kind that follows, or underlines, an assertion of control. To admit such a book to our home library—which he, an eager autodidact, had gradually built over the years—was a concession he made to her. But labelling a book as “for your mother” meant, above all, that its proper place was in the bin.

I don't remember where all these supposedly second-rate novels came from, the ones that ended up on my mother's nightstand. I know some were gifts from my father himself, birthday or Christmas presents wrapped in bookstore paper. She'd unwrap them and say thank you. Eventually, even she began to say “these are books for me,” as if seeing herself through his eyes—holding on, through self-deprecation, only to the part of the phrase that passed for affection.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

I don't know if it was my father who bought those weekly copies of *La Settimana Enigmistica*. In any case, he never objected to the expense, because he needed to keep her busy, “give her something to do,” as he put it, so that he could read his books or do other things he liked: ski across the French border, go climbing. For her, the important thing wasn't so much that he be able to read or do his sports but that he see her as the person he

had decided she was. This amounted, perhaps, in my mother's view of life, to a wretched demonstration of love. That may have been one of the fundamental misunderstandings between them: he wanted her to be nothing so that he could be something; she wanted to be nothing because being nothing was, at least, something. Or maybe it wasn't so much a misunderstanding as a sort of unspoken, secret pact. The result was that she actually did erase herself, and his bitterness, scorn, and despair at having that nothing on his couch piled up the way those crossword magazines piled up on the table, week after week, before ending up in the trash.

And yet, of the two, only my mother had gone to college—a detail rarely mentioned in our household, and when it was, my father used it against her, as evidence that she could have been more than a woman who did crosswords. Her own father probably went no further than elementary school, but her mother, raised in an orphanage, graduated from a vocational high school and went on to become a secretary at a law firm where, over time, she proved herself indispensable. My mother, then, grew up among Rome's petty bourgeoisie, and she became the first in her family to aspire to college, attending a prestigious high school to prepare. What did she have in mind when she enrolled in that school? What future life did she picture? High-school teacher? Doctor? Lawyer? Did she believe she'd leave her parents' rental life behind and one day own her own home? It's hard to say, because we never discussed it. And, besides, that girl was so profoundly different from the woman I came to know over the course of my childhood and adulthood that, no matter how hard I try to imagine it, I struggle to see her face in my mother's. It's not that she hid any of this from me, and it's true that I could have asked her questions, investigated. But I, too, had adopted my father's official version: the crossword-puzzle woman.

He, on the other hand, chose high school out of inertia. His mother was born into Rome's commercial bourgeoisie, but she had essentially been disinherited, nose-diving into the working class with a pair of children to raise. My father's mother, then, lived two distinct lives, of which I only ever heard glancing mentions. The first was lived, you could say, in first class, and has been mythologized three times over: by her, through the lens of her regret; by my father, to fit a narrative in which he was the tragic hero and his mother the traditional scapegoat; and by me, with my innate urge to

rewrite my relatives' lives based on whatever facts I learned. Whether or not my grandmother's fall was brought on by an infidelity, as the three-headed family mythology posited, what's clear is that we were descendants of that second life—the fallen one.

For my father to go to high school made a kind of sense, given his mother's former life. At fourteen, he was already, in effect, an ex-bourgeois, and perhaps because he belonged to no class he had no real class consciousness. He was also fatherless, or, rather, his father left few traces in the family story. Just his name and his exit scene, the climax of which was in some ways comical: my grandmother, during an argument, whacked him on the head with a ladle. And there was one later scene: my father, a kid, telling his father to stay away from his sister—four years older but still female, so subject to his manly code—if he didn't want his face smashed in.

My parents met in class in the final years of high school. How he ended up at her school isn't clear. The point is they were the same age, and so they started out, as it were, on equal footing. But my father had no ambition, no desire for redemption, only an interest, it seemed, in getting out from under his mother's curse—which did nothing but fan the flames of my grandmother's guilt, as she surely wanted him to reclaim the life she had lost. When he announced at eighteen that he was dropping out, she bought him an old Simca to balance the scales, or so the official story goes. And it was with that car that he picked my mother up from school for their first date. Unlike her, my father had no qualms about breaking rules. His family had a history of failure, so he didn't fear it. That must have felt dizzying to my mother, who came from a family that had never had much and so carefully managed what little they did have.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice

[Listen to Andrea Bajani read "Constellation."](#)

In contrast with her parents' caution and her own gentle, disciplined nature, he offered adventure, with a sort of slap in the face of the future, all of it improvised with the windows down as they drove along the coast. The first consequence of their relationship was that her academic performance plummeted, and she graduated with the lowest grades possible, while he didn't graduate at all. Still, finishing high school by the skin of her teeth

didn't discourage her, or at least it didn't stop her, from enrolling in college to study literature.

I wouldn't be surprised if my father played a role in that choice, nudging her in that direction. Having her pursue literature may have felt to him like a shortcut, as well as a way to exert control in their relationship. He loved books, but he lacked discipline and couldn't abide being judged by others. My mother's course of study probably furnished them both with lists of novels and critical texts to spend their days with. I can easily picture them reading those books together, in a collaborative way, with him assuming—ironically, given his own academic history—the role of expert, and her acquiescing.

It was a good exercise of power to push her toward literature, but in the long run that direction would inevitably pose a threat to him. The time would come when things would no longer be in his control. And so, perhaps more by instinct than design, he did the only thing he could to stop the train that, having just left the station, was picking up speed. He pulled the emergency brake.

My mother got pregnant for the first time in the fall of 1971, just after turning twenty-two, and again in the summer of 1973. By early 1974, she was the mother of two children and could set her books and exams aside and return to her class of origin. It was up to my father, as he saw it, to find work, and without a high-school diploma he had to take what he could get, which turned out to be a sales job in a luggage shop.

Their new life is captured in a photo taken in the Piazza del Campidoglio in January of 1972, on the day they signed their marriage papers at city hall. My mother stands with her parents, my father with his mother. Maybe their brothers and sisters are there, too, rounding out the ceremony—I'm not sure, but I'll put them in. You can't tell from the angle that my mother is pregnant, but my sister, born five months later, is there in the frame. It's hard to read the emotions of the scene. Perhaps my mother's parents are trying to bend their apprehension into hope. Perhaps the exuberance on my father's side is tinged by their acquaintance with disaster. I imagine on both sides a reflexive cultural satisfaction at seeing their children settled.

That photo, in any case, documents the celebration of a new beginning. For my mother, though, it also marks an end. Or at least the closing of a life path that a college diploma might have cleared the way for. Had she become a teacher, that ceremony might have been unbearable for my father. But it was perfectly bearable now that she would merely be a mother, a wife at home, cooking and minding the children, with little interest in anything else—least of all in books or in literature, which from that point on he claimed for himself. Her role also provided him with an identity that had been culturally and socially sanctioned for centuries: he would be the husband-father who sacrificed everything out of duty to his family. That was the identity to which he now dedicated himself, and my mother accepted it because being a mother was still, after all, something. And we kids accepted it, too: our mother cooked, did crossword puzzles, and drowsed on the couch while our father read.

It's still not clear to me whether my father ever actually hit my mother, though there must surely be some record in the police archives of a call that our neighbor made, sometime in the mid-nineteen-nineties, to report shouts and thuds coming from our apartment. I know that my mother never pressed charges, that my father never stood trial or received any kind of sentence. Even the wound on her head—she had blood in her hair when I walked in and found her sitting in the kitchen with an officer—seemed all better the next morning. There had been no need for bandages or stitches, something that now, as I write, seems hard to believe. In fact, she told the officer, in a faint voice, “Everything's fine, thank you,” and he made his way toward the door, carefully avoiding the scattered debris in the living room, and waited there for his partner to emerge from my parents' bedroom, where he was talking with my father.

We never spoke of it afterward, and so I have no real sense of how things unfolded. There were no other witnesses, since my sister wasn't home that evening. According to my father's account, it had been an accident: he pushed her and she happened to fall—he hadn't hit her. He didn't comment on the push; he mentioned it as if it were beside the point. He said my mother had fallen and hit the back of her head on the edge of some wall—unclear exactly where—and that had caused the cut. She confirmed that version, apparently, which brought the officers' visit to a close. I can't

remember their faces or their ages. On their way out, they said that they were sorry and not to hesitate to call if it happened again. Then they pulled the door closed behind them.

Their departure was followed by a kind of thick, building-wide silence, when, just moments before, there had been voices in the stairwell, where at least three families had gathered to talk. They had made way for me when I had shown up, with no idea what was going on, and warned me that they'd had to call for help. The scene before me, when I entered the apartment, was one of devastation: the living room mostly dark; the ceiling light shattered on the floor, glass all around it; a cabinet door, torn from its hinges, leaning against the couch; the sharp smell of sweat mixed with whatever my parents had eaten for dinner. There was also a smashed bottle, a cracked floor tile, and other things besides.

But what I remember most is the silence in my temples, a kind of stillness I can name only now, some twenty-seven or twenty-eight years later: despair.

My mother remained in the kitchen, receding into the background even in that moment. But, for once, she didn't seem timid, or scared. I don't think I said anything to her, not because I didn't know what to say but because it was all real enough without words. Nor did she say anything to me, I think for the same reason. She wasn't embarrassed; she was tidying the kitchen as she always did, out of habit. Whatever just happened had already happened many times before, without the violence taking physical, visible form, without shattered glass or police. At least now she had a mess she could clean up.

She moved around the kitchen in her usual way, wearing her glasses even though one of the lenses had cracked. But it wasn't to be dramatic—nothing that had happened could be magnified by her behavior. She wore them for practical reasons: she was so nearsighted that without them she couldn't see anything and wouldn't have been able to clean up. I watched from the doorway as she cried silently—not for me, and not even really for herself, but for all of us, for everything. It was a soft, gentle weeping that hadn't begun in that moment and wouldn't end once the tears stopped rolling down her cheeks. She cried because things had gone as they had gone, and there was nothing more to be done.

That evening, I'd come by train from college, in Turin, and had walked home from the station, a twenty-minute walk through a fog that swallowed buildings and street lamps. Shortly before I reached my parents' building, the two police officers had run up to me, out of breath, to ask for directions to an address—our own. I lifted my arm, heart pounding, to point at the red six-story building a few hundred metres ahead. Did I know they were heading to my parents' unit? Why were they running instead of driving up in a squad car with sirens on? There was something absurd and distressing in that prelude to the domestic drama.

It could have happened on any day, and now it had. Finding the police at our place, then, wasn't really a surprise, and my pulse returned to its usual rhythm, oddly calmed by the fact that the dread had finally left my heart. I could see it now, measure it: the shattered glass, the broken cabinet doors. I set my backpack down on a chair and began to help my mother clean up, feeling a kind of crazed tenderness, a peaceful defeat.

I can't say what emotions reigned, and of course what I felt was not what my mother was feeling, but I don't think either of us believed that it was over, that we had reached the final act. Perhaps we even found some perverse consolation in the thought that, since it had happened now, it wouldn't happen again for a while, and that our tidying up—sweeping the glass into the dustpan, dumping it into the bin—was something that simply needed doing before the next day. I remember, though, that opening the kitchen window was a relief, because seeing ourselves, my mother and me, even just reflected in the window, was too much. I opened it, in truth, to let us out.

When we had almost finished cleaning up, we heard the bedroom door, and then the front door, open and close. My father had left, which spared us from having to say things in front of him that neither of us could have said, or that we would have said badly.

Minutes later, the intercom buzzed, and my father's voice filled the room, asking me to come down to the street. I found him waiting outside the front gate, in the car, engine running. My mind was blank—everything felt mechanical, precise—but I was no longer afraid, because the worst had already come to pass. I slid into the passenger seat, shut the door. We both

looked out through the windshield, at a section of the gate illuminated by the headlights. It lasted no more than a few seconds, a minute at most. He asked me to promise that I would graduate. I said I would. I don't remember him driving away, or me going back inside. I don't know whether I took the elevator, to avoid running into anyone, or climbed the stairs. Back in the apartment, my mother asked what he had said; I couldn't tell if she was worried or not. Then we finished cleaning up, but I left the cabinet door on the couch.

Looking back, I wonder how we decided that we would have to go to sleep while my father was who knows where. To do that required some measure of trust in the future, or at least in the idea that there would be more life after this, and that it would include us. And so we got ready for bed. Later, my father would tell me that when he asked me, hands on the steering wheel, to promise to graduate, he had been planning to take his own life, that he saw no way out but suicide. He had taken with him all the pills he could find in the house, but then gave up, afraid of failing, since all we had were over-the-counter medications.

At some point in the night, the front door opened and closed. I remember the four turns of the dead-bolt key in the reinforced door, my father's wildly disproportionate security measure, meant to guard our home from outside threats. I believe—but I know it's just a retrospective wish, another invention—that he then entered the bedroom, where earlier he'd been shut in with the officer, and lay down in bed next to my mother's body.

I don't know how we managed to pick the thread of our lives back up so naturally after it had snapped so violently. But that's what we did.

Then again, it was a common progression, one that had followed every blowup. For a few meals, my father would condemn the supper table to silence, we children would hope everyone would eat quickly, and my mother would ramp up her particular brand of post-tempest servility, in which everything she did in his presence was inflected by repentance. That meant carrying his dishes to the sink without so much as a thank you; keeping strict track, with an eye on her watch, of the exact number of minutes his tea bag had steeped before removing it and placing his cup in front of him; washing the dishes the moment the meal was over, then

waiting on the couch with a book in her hands, open to the same page, for hours. Waiting for what? For my father to string three words together, the unmistakable signal that life could resume as before.

I realize now it was only in the aftermath of violent episodes that my mother assumed a theatrical attitude. Her face, usually settled into a general look of detachment, would take on deeply significant expressions, all revolving around a plea for forgiveness. Everything she did was performative: her glasses slipping halfway down her nose and left like that all day, her slightly rumpled clothes, the hunching of her back as she put groceries into the fridge. Everything had an intentional air you couldn't miss. Even choosing a book over her usual crosswords was part of the script, as she waited for my father to break his punishing silence. It all conveyed the same message: I'll be a different wife, I'll be what you want.

Yet in my mother's bearing, that day after the world had fallen apart, I saw a kind of quiet contentment, or satisfaction, or at least a fullness of self, which is hard to explain now and was even harder to understand then. It contained a strength, a proud deliberateness, arising from something I can describe only as an exercise of power over my father.

As counterintuitive as it may sound, in those moments, my mother had the upper hand. She was no longer relegated to her usual invisibility, to watching the lives of others unfold outside our window. Now she was there, she was fully present in her own life, and in ours, and for however long that transition back to serenity lasted, she towered over my father. It was, in the end, the only revenge she permitted herself, and I'm sure she was aware of it: forcing my father to forgive her.

What I didn't see then was that, for my father, forgiving was the only way of asking for forgiveness, or at least of being absolved. And, without absolution, he felt condemned to the abyss, to his self-imposed, post-violence isolation. He had cornered himself, and only my mother could free him. This, then, was understood to be my mother's task, to make herself forgivable through self-abasement. And that was her power: to protect him from the harm he did to her. Or, rather, to protect him from the harm he did to all of us. Then she would vanish again.

To all appearances, so many years later, this was a mechanism that had been thoroughly tested and that worked perfectly well. It required only that, once forgiveness was granted, life go on as before, that absolution erase all traces of what had occurred. Indeed, that ritual of forgiveness was the only thing that allowed life to go on. But it came with the unspoken warning—directed especially at my mother—never to mention the incident, not to him and certainly not to anyone else, on pain of yet another explosion.

And so it went that time, too. My mother's cracked lens was replaced, the cabinet door was reattached, and my father, after some span of time I can no longer recall, began to speak as before. Only once afterward did he refer to that night. He told me that a neighbor had pounded on our door, yelling at him to calm down and let my mother out. My father opened the door and just stood, silently, in the doorway. He then closed the door in the man's face, while the man yelled down the stairs for his daughter to call the police.

Life returned to normal, as it always did, with a walk. I remember my father standing at the door and my mother, dressed and coiffed for absolution, hurrying to join him, almost cheerful as she called out, "Coming!" I wonder how it must have felt, for both of them, to walk down those stairs, past the neighbors' doors, across the courtyard of that building where everyone knew what there was to know, where some may have even glimpsed the scene from their windows. But it doesn't matter that I wonder, because it simply happened, and my sitting in the kitchen, after they left, crying about it—and not about everything else—was, I think, my way of understanding.

Like so many episodes of household violence, that night came to seem like a hallucination, a lurid memory of something that wasn't connected to our life together and so would eventually, lacking any handhold, fade away.

Those hallucinations punctuate our family history like fires in the night—rare enough that one could choose not to mention them and speak only of the surrounding darkness, telling a story like so many others, full of more or less memorable moments of ordinary life, which for many years made up the bulk of ours, together with the beautiful, which, of course, I also remember. The pizza outings in the summer; the evenings after swim meets; the hikes in the mountains with my father; the delicacy of his hands, which

I could only sometimes perceive; the sight of him dancing alone in front of the stereo, sure that no one was watching; his devotion; the times he carried me on his shoulders; the way my mother said my name; the easy ordinariness of sitting with her in the kitchen, talking aimlessly about nothing in particular, the warmth of that.

Or, instead, one might bring together those points of blinding light that, like fires, consume the memories around them, maybe even the facts themselves. One might bring them together, as I'm doing here, and draw lines connecting them to see the shape that emerges, the outline: that of an ill-fated family. ♦

(Translated, from the Italian, by Geoffrey Brock.)

This is drawn from “[The Anniversary](#).”

[Andrea Bajani](#) won Italy's Strega Prize in 2025 for his novel “L'anniversario,” which has also been translated into English “[The Anniversary](#)” (August, 2026).

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Did a Rowdy English Nobleman Mastermind the American Revolution?

America's fight for independence is often considered a battle fought and won at home. A new book argues that it was propelled by a transnational elite an ocean away.

By [Adam Gopnik](#)

June 8, 2026



The Duke of Richmond collected Sèvres porcelain, loved Paris, backed John Wilkes, befriended Thomas Paine, and helped create the ideological underpinnings of the American Revolution. Illustration by Ben Wisman

Americans want to Americanize the American Revolution. We accept the existence of a handful of single-named philosophical grandfathers—Locke and Montesquieu and the rest—and we recognize the help of a few super-friends, like Lafayette, who, in our imagination, arrives to play Aquaman to

Washington's Superman (and Hamilton's Batman) in an Enlightenment Justice League. But the idea is always that it was made by the forces here at home. Witty Jefferson, stolid Washington, disputatious Adams, Franklin simpering and laughing and making love—we want it to be a kind of farm-to-table act of ideological localism. We resist the notion that the Revolution might instead have been a product of an élite, cosmopolitan, educated transnational set—what one could call the Voltaire class—given to sexual adventure in Paris and political agitation in London as well as Boston. We want it all to have happened right here.

Yet, in recent years, there has been an [explosion of well-wrought histories](#) that do indeed see the Revolution as arising from this country-crossing cohort. In Justin du Rivage's [“Revolution Against Empire,”](#) from a decade ago, we were told of the ocean-spanning alliance of the so-called radical Whigs, whose ideology “flourished in Boston, Bristol, and Bengal, while fears of disorder and licentiousness provoked rural elites in both the Hudson Valley and the English shires.” (Du Rivage has since left academia, sighing that “for all of the criticism of American exceptionalism in American historiography I think a lot of historians still are American exceptionalists.”) More recent [French studies of Lafayette](#) emphasize his role less as a super-friend than as a supervisory ally.

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This view—that the American Revolution was forged by others and began elsewhere—has never been more aggressively stated than it is in the new book [“Radical Duke”](#) (Liveright), by the political theorist, classicist, and Harvard professor Danielle Allen. Although the work is, in format, simply a new biography of Charles Lennox (1735-1806), the third Duke of Richmond, it advances a singularly bold case for the English origins of the

American Revolution. “Every act that provided the drumbeat of the march to revolution in the colonies had been foreshadowed in Britain,” Allen assures us. “The rights of man, the theory of revolution, and calls for popular sovereignty—all of these developed earlier in London than in the colonies.” The book’s inciting incident (as the screenwriting guides call it) is Allen’s discovery, a few years ago, of a mysterious and very [early copy of the Declaration of Independence](#) in a West Sussex archival record derived from the Duke’s papers, and since then she has searched out the traces of Richmond’s fine hand in the violent disruptions that preceded and shaped our Revolution. In her account, Richmond indeed emerges as its progenitor—through his theorizing, his behind-the-scenes parliamentary and polemical maneuvering, and his patronage of Thomas Paine.

Richmond, Allen thinks, isn’t just the maker of the Revolution. He’s also one of the founders of the modern political party—cross-class gatherings of the like-minded—and the first person to envision the “district-based foundation of modern democratic representation,” with equally populated districts. As if all that weren’t enough, she adds, in a nice mustard *tache* of conspiracy, a persuasive theory that the notorious “Letters of Junius,” a series that, in the seventeen-sixties and seventies, shook the British establishment and the Crown, was secretly Richmond’s work, with her hero at the center of a cénacle of carefully chosen and well-masked radical writers, including Paine and Edmund Burke.

So who was this guy? Richmond, born in 1735, came from the upper crust’s upper crust: he was the great-grandson of the unfortunate King Charles I and inherited not one but two vast country estates. Extraordinarily good-looking as a youth—he had the long equine face of the British upper classes, Benedict Cumberbatch to the life—Richmond was also rambunctiously heterosexual, feeling up the Venus de’ Medici on his Grand Tour. (“I am in love with the Venus and take great pleasure to stroke her bum and thighs,” he wrote to an in-law.) He soon became an Army officer, but one has the sense that this was more like attending law school today than actually planning to fight battles—one of those things privileged people did while figuring out what they’d actually do.

What he did was politics. A member of the House of Lords, Richmond benefitted throughout his life from a class system that was, confoundingly, both more stratified and more porous to new participants than might have been imagined. On the one hand, he had huge holdings and an ancient and untouchable position—no one was going to mess with the Duke of Richmond. On the other, he was accustomed to dining and sharing conversation with people from far humbler origins, on either side of the ideological aisle: the [revolution-minded Paine](#) came from a family in the corset-making trade; the conservative Samuel Johnson, another friend, had an even simpler rural lower-middle-class background. Richmond was a nob without ever being a snob.

Why did he go radical? It seems to have been the inevitable human mixture of the personal and the political. He had been alienated, in the seventeenth-sixties, by the new King, George III, who, as Allen explains, was perceived, when he was a young man—before madness and America fell on him—as exceptionally open and well educated, a close reader of Montesquieu. But George had courted, and then snubbed, Richmond's teen-age sister Sarah, marrying a minor German princess instead. Making a marriage within the domestic aristocracy was, the King's courtiers thought, a very bad idea, since it caught him up in internecine Whig politics. (The British Royal Family after the Restoration was, by design, never entirely British.) And so Sarah was humiliated, to her brother's outrage, and then subsequently "crushed" by an illegitimate pregnancy. Luckily, she later became the second wife of George Napier, had many children with him, and restored her social place, which suggests that social disgrace wasn't quite as irrevocable as we're often told.

Richmond's politics were, in any case, not petty. Throughout his life, he knew that the triumph of a democratic ideal would limit the power of his caste and kind. And, like his spiritual grandson, Anthony Trollope's Plantagenet Palliser, he relished that ideal without necessarily expecting that the thing would happen in his lifetime. Indeed, he seems to have embodied the Whig virtue of being exceedingly sincere and almost completely disinterested, willing to follow a line of reasoning wherever it took him, damn the personal consequences.

Richmond's move toward political radicalism appears to have had three further catalysts: his experiences in France, both good and bad; the radical Member of Parliament John Wilkes; and, perhaps most dispositively, his improbable alliance and deep friendship with Paine. France, where Richmond journeyed regularly, was his favorite place. But his best friend in the Army, James Wolfe—who, as a general, would lead the battle that brought Quebec permanently into the British orbit—found Versailles repellent, and Allen is certain that Richmond agreed. After he and Richmond visited the court, Wolfe wrote of “a multitude of men and women” assembled “to bow and pay their compliments in the most submissive manner to a creature of their own species” (the French court evidently having the air of a Trump Cabinet meeting). But absolutism and amour ran together in those days, and, on annual summer visits to Paris, Richmond amassed a still unexampled collection of Sèvres porcelain and began a long, seasonal love affair with the great *saloniste* and beauty Madame Marguerite de Cambis—who was, as Richmond's sister wrote approvingly, in the polyamorous aristocratic manner of the time, “quite proper *dans toutes les formes*.” (Richmond, meanwhile, had made a companionate arranged marriage with a fellow-aristocrat back home.) Madame de Cambis brought him sagacity and sex as he needed it. Through absorption in her circle, he learned to embrace the French dissidents Diderot, Voltaire, and Rousseau. Behind it all was his reading of Montesquieu, who combined practicality and philosophy in a distinct way.

At the center of Richmond's public life was the London-based Society for the Encouragement of Arts, Manufactures, and Commerce, founded in the seventeen-sixties, which undermined autocracy by its very existence. The Society of Arts, as it came to be known, brought together traditionally low-order artisanal and engineering concerns—how to cultivate vineyards in Virginia, or weave silk in London—with higher-order philosophical and literary ones. Operating outside the usual bounds of British royal patronage, it was transformative, in part, because its inner workings and politics were actually, truly democratic. One man, one vote—and the membership even included, uniquely for that time, women with an equal franchise. As the archivist D. G. C. Allan has noted, enormous attention was paid to the elections to Society posts, exactly because they provided, in miniature form, the look and feel of what democratic elections might become. Indeed, the

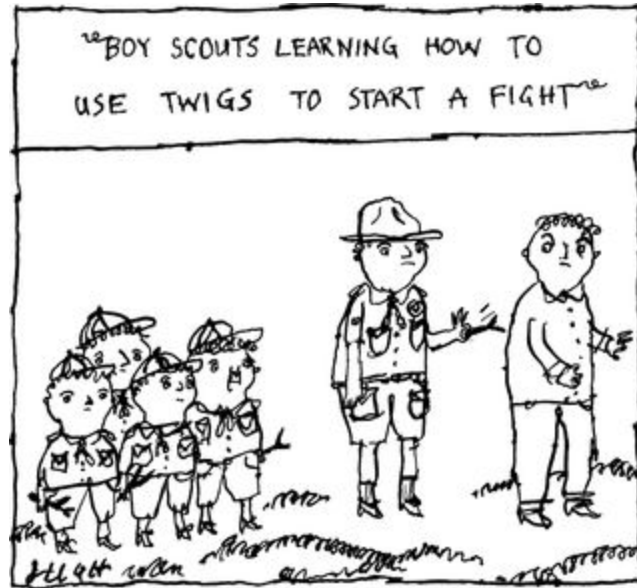
King would later establish the Instrument of Foundation of the Royal Academy as a more autocratic counterpart.

The Society of Arts was a model third-place institution, Richmond's own semipublic coffeehouse. But a more critical event in his life was a scandal involving [John Wilkes](#), who was famously ugly, brilliant, radical, and lecherous. Wilkes was a member of the supposedly licentious Hellfire Club, one of those groups (think of Led Zeppelin in our time) known for satanic pursuits that probably were mostly drunken stunts. Yet, despite his politics and reputation, Wilkes got himself elected to Parliament in the seventeenth-sixties—and was then expelled by the court party for having previously been convicted of seditious and impious libel. “Wilkes and Liberty” became the rallying cry of an entire generation, accompanied by a wonderful engraving by his enemy [William Hogarth](#) showing Wilkes as a hideous, grinning devil, although Hogarth was too good an artist not to also make his devilish figure irresistible. Surprisingly, Richmond took up Wilkes's cause—like John Kenneth Galbraith taking up Abbie Hoffman's side in 1968—and continued to support him through a series of trials and parliamentary debates that eventually ended with Wilkes's reinstatement.

It was during this period that Richmond appears to have first met Thomas Paine, then an aspirant polemicist whose talents and charisma he quickly recognized. In what seems a scholarly scoop, Allen places Richmond at the very center of a ring of anonymous writers who together planned and wrote the Junius letters, and had them published in the *Public Advertiser*. Eloquent, unafraid, and widely circulated, the letters were passionately democratic and vigorously pro-Wilkes; among them was a letter warning the King that the Crown, which was “acquired by one revolution, may be lost by another.” (The paper's owner, but not any of the anonymous writers, was then arrested, though acquitted in court.)

The identity of Junius has long remained obscure. Allen argues that Junius was actually a syndicate of authors acting under Richmond's general direction, with Paine and Burke among the principals. There is an anecdote in a very early biography of Adam Smith in which Richmond is told, by the M.P. William Gerard Hamilton, that there was a good Junius letter coming out, only for a baffled Richmond not to be able to find it in the *Advertiser*,

suggesting that Hamilton must have written it. We can now reinterpret this tale to mean that Richmond was playing the fool, spreading the tale in order to throw the hounds off his scent.



Cartoon by Roland High

Paine, then, was not the political innocent he claimed to be when he left for America, in 1774. He was what today might be called an “outside agitator,” sent specifically by Richmond to bring the new doctrines of democracy to the outer edge of empire—an Enlightenment Lenin sent to the Boston Harbor.

Then, on June 2, 1780, the Duke of Richmond stood in the House of Lords and introduced a motion calling for universal male suffrage, without property or class restrictions. “It was the first such motion in British history,” Allen writes, and “quite probably the first in the modern world”; given that even Athenian democracy had many qualifications for voting (you not only had to be a man but had to have served in the military), it was likely the first of its kind in Western history. The proposal rested on a simple idea, absorbed from Montesquieu but not dependent on him, that the egalitarian rights of citizenship had to be defined before you could even start talking about the power of the executive.

Things went wrong, of course, as things do. The agitation of the time produced not a popular democratic revolt but merely the Gordon Riots—an

insurrection whose ends were perverted, to Richmond's despair, into narrow, anti-Catholic sentiment, just as the New York City riots during the Civil War turned genuine discontent with the class-based nature of conscription into anti-Black rage. Richmond's ideal was defeated, and he knew it.

The strange thing is that, though his maximalist ideals had lost, his political power only grew after the British Army was defeated at Yorktown. Richmond went into government and began a tacit collaboration with that Montesquieu-reading King; together, they came to a sort of implicit constitutional settlement. The King was still at the top but was to be somewhat bounded by constitutional restraints, an arrangement that, essentially, is still in place today.

Richmond's last years were odd. His protégé, Paine, came back and became obsessed with a plan to build an iron bridge over the Seine. But Allen convincingly argues that he also brought with him a gift: an original copy, from 1776, of the Declaration of Independence, which Paine saw Richmond as having fathered. Paine and Richmond had a violent falling out, or, rather, Paine—a lightning bolt of a man who flashed and then shocked in equal measure—turned against Richmond, as he did sooner or later with all his benefactors. Richmond, exasperated, seems to have folded up Paine's gift into quarters and buried it within his papers.

Reading Allen's pages, one thinks again and again about a single question: How did the Duke get away with it? Offering views that would have been treasonous coming from others, he breezed past objections and went in and out of government as he liked. Some of this was a matter of the insolence of riches and pride of place. But some of it was from those grooved-in habits of tolerance which groups like the Society of Arts and the "talking shops" around it nurtured, and which the late Jürgen Habermas celebrated: coffee saucers as an altar of Enlightenment. Among the most delightful episodes of English-language biography is Boswell's account of an improbable dinner party in the fateful year of 1776 that was attended by the hyper-radical Wilkes and the reactionary Samuel Johnson, who became and stayed friends. Both were part of Richmond's circle, and both were ready to debate an idea without deleting the debater. There were other approaches. Some

years later, the Jacobins realized that one way of dealing with dissent was to kill the dissenters, a lesson that they passed on to the revolutionaries and radicals of later eras. The chatter of cosmopolitan élites is the most reviled of all discourses right now. But, by reconciling opposing practices, it has often proved the most reliable ally of liberty.

Do we buy the larger thesis—no Richmond, no Revolution? Certainly, a monocausal account of anything is likely to founder. Inevitably, the Revolution was accomplished by a coalition of many kinds. One only has to think about the British fight against Nazism to be reminded that it was made of imperialists, constitutionalists, stick-in-the-mud aristocrats, and the socialists who first helped put Winston Churchill into power and then five years later helped push him out again. The coalition that made the [American Revolution was equally miscellaneous](#).

Yet it took place in sharp contradistinction to the English Revolution of the previous century, which remained, however much egalitarian afflatus may have flown in its wake, essentially religious and schismatic. The American Revolution was, at heart, frankly and undeniably secularist. In Richmond's writing, there seems to be a single notable religious referent in which he rather cagily points out that all men can be members of a democracy, just as all are members of a church. But this remark seems more a strategic argument than a deep-rooted impulsion. Indeed, the argument it makes is that the Church, to be taken seriously, must be universal, not sectarian. Certainly, when Richmond later summed up life's points and pleasures in a memo to his nephew, there was not a single piety among them.

His central idea was that citizenship overrode creedal community, and though he wasn't the only person to have this idea, he was the one man free to say it when it was hard to say. When he spoke of union with Ireland, he was insistent on a decentralized government, with a new idea of a common humanity—a union, as he said, “of hearts and hands, or affections and interests.” The novelty of the American Revolution, in turn, was the introduction of a word that George Washington could use unself-consciously: “liberal,” and the concepts that went with it. And this vocabulary was the special property of just the kind of educated international class that subsequent polemics have tried to immunize us

against. Montesquieu's words were fed into the mind of Voltaire, who then got busy speaking them into Madame's ear, who shared them with her boyfriend, the Duke, who offered them to Burke and then sent the package off to America with Paine. . . . It did happen here, but it happened here because it was imagined elsewhere. Its secular cast was not its only imprint. But it was its originality.

Our task, in the year of the United States' [two-hundred-and-fiftieth birthday](#), is to deprovincialize the Revolution, without unduly deprecating its originality. The American Revolution embraced a cosmopolitan and secular set of doctrines and beliefs: coexistence of many kinds, no preference for any one faith group, and, above all, the reliance on a system of dependable and more or less disinterested justice which we call, weakly, the rule of law.

These Richmondian revolutions, performed by human beings, had predictably human results. The American Revolution installed an admirably designed system that tolerated the continuance of slavery. The French overthrew millennia of arbitrary hereditary rule but soon devolved into terror and war. (The Duke's mistress had to flee to London.) They were not ideas that grew from American soil; they were part of a wind that blew across the Western world and were the possession of a handful of progressive visionaries before they were shared with the citizenry. Like the Wilkes agitation, they began with the erudite, indignant few, and lit a popular flame with the equally indignant many.

Today, some writers eagerly ascribe the shortcomings of America's founding documents to the treason of the educated élite, while refusing to acknowledge that it was only an educated élite that could ever have produced them. The ideas that they encapsulate are still remarkable and unique in history: the coexistence of competing faiths, beliefs, and kinds, not as a grudging concession by the majority but as the most natural arrangement for all.

Washington's postwar letter to a Jewish congregation in Rhode Island continues to be worth celebrating as a succinct statement—from a conservative, slaveholding military man—of beliefs that could not have been publicly expressible half a century earlier: “It is now no more that toleration is spoken of as if it were the indulgence of one class of people

that another enjoyed the exercise of their inherent natural rights, for, happily, the Government of the United States, which gives to bigotry no sanction, to persecution no assistance, requires only that they who live under its protection should demean themselves as good citizens.” The views here about tolerance and citizenship were at one time so radical that it took a duke to voice them. They remain so radical today that they are under perpetual assault. The most American thing about the American Revolution was its revolutionary claim that belonging need not be fixed by birth, blood, or station, that citizenship could be chosen, extended, and remade. It was once the kind of idea that only the very rich and powerful could safely say out loud. Then a revolution happened, and everyone could. ♦

*[Adam Gopnik](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 1986. His books include “[The Real Work: On the Mystery of Mastery](#).”*

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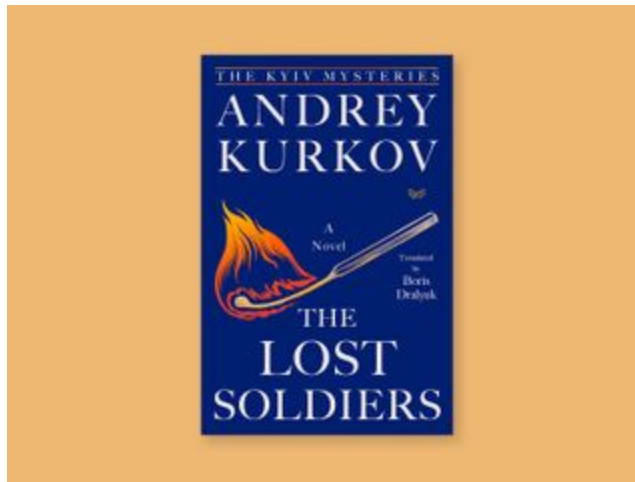
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[Books](#)

Briefly Noted

“The Lost Soldiers,” “Homebound,” “Once Upon a Time There Was Truth,” and “My World Is Melting.”

June 8, 2026



The Lost Soldiers, by Andrey Kurkov, translated from the Russian by Boris Dralyuk (*HarperVia*). In this madcap detective story, Samson Kolehko, a young investigator in Kyiv, is assigned a seemingly impossible case. The year is 1919, the midst of Bolshevik takeover in Ukraine, and twenty-eight Red Army soldiers have vanished into thin air, last seen at a bathhouse. Kolehko must track them down. He gets little help from the absurd locals, who range from obstinately useless to selfishly malicious. Kolehko is a kind of anti-Poirot—a fairly conventional man whose powers of detection lie not in a dazzling intuition but in a supernatural severed ear, which has a bug-like ability to pick up dialogue. In Kurkov’s hands, his efforts offer both serious meditations and page-turning diversion.



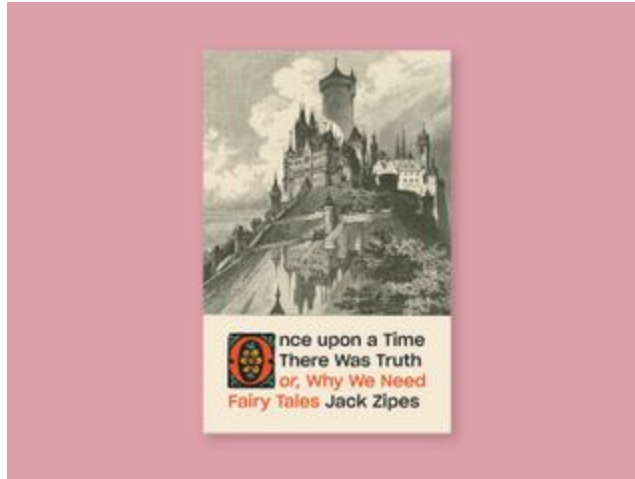
Homebound, by Portia Elan (Scribner). This imaginative début novel takes place in two settings: Cincinnati, in the nineteen-eighties; and a flooded world, six hundred years later. In the latter time line, Yesiko, a middle-aged ship captain who is burdened by medical debt, picks up some mysterious passengers—including a moody robot—who promise to pay handsomely. In Cincinnati, a teen-ager named Beck ponders an unfinished video game designed by her late uncle, who has died of an H.I.V.-like disease. At once a work of dystopian science fiction and a tale of lesbian self-discovery, the novel is ultimately concerned with “what it means to show up even when you’re afraid.”

[What We’re Reading](#)

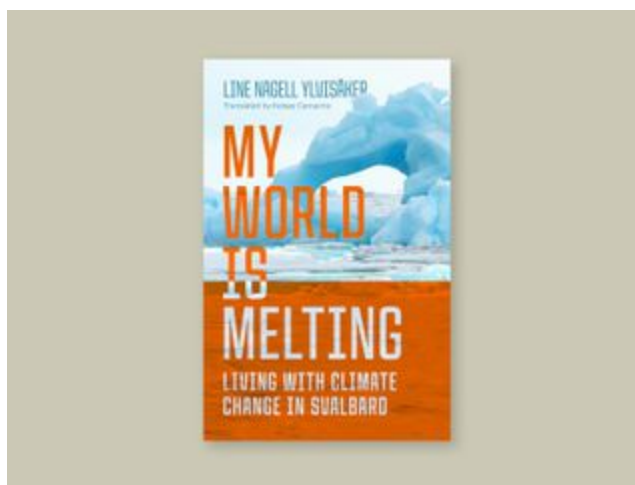


Illustration by Henri Campeã

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Once Upon a Time There Was Truth, by Jack Zipes (Yale). Zipes, an accomplished scholar of fairy tales, explores the genre’s enduring appeal and its social functions in this erudite essay collection. He acknowledges the long global history of folk stories, but focusses on the Western “literary” fairy tale, charting its emergence out of oral tradition—aided by the printing press, the standardization of vernacular languages, and the rise of modern nation-states—and the process by which it became oriented primarily toward children. Examining both classics (“Hansel and Gretel”) and commercial empires (Disney), Zipes illuminates the fairy tale’s often contradictory tendencies, among them its propagation of conformist values along with its subversive potential, and its power to either “domesticate the imagination” or liberate it.



My World Is Melting, by Line Nagell Ylvisåker, translated from the Norwegian by Kelsey Camacho (Wisconsin). The islands of Svalbard are the

world's northernmost inhabited region; they are also experiencing climate change at an accelerated pace. In this memoir, Ylvisåker, who is from Longyearbyen, a small town in the archipelago which was hit by a deadly avalanche in 2015, documents Svalbard's transformation. She interviews a trapper who testifies to the changing patterns of the native animals he has interacted with over the past half century, and shows locals struggling with the pressures of a "last-chance tourism" boom. Her portrait of residents pinched between floods and receding sea ice is a testament to their love of this vulnerable land that is their home.

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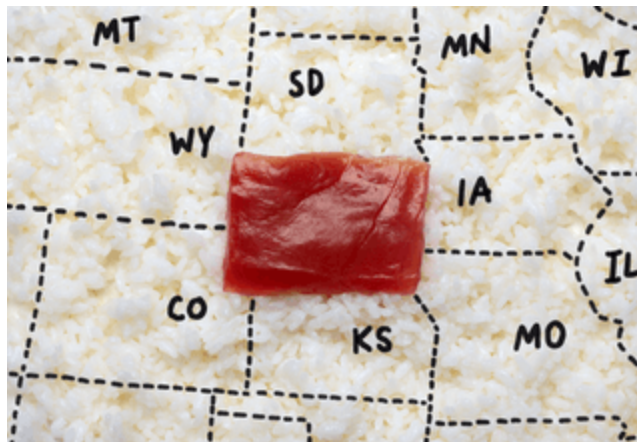
[On and Off the Menu](#)

A World-Class Omakase in America's Most Landlocked State

For the chef David Utterback, the sense that Omaha is underestimated is a source of both pride and torment.

By [Hannah Goldfield](#)

June 8, 2026



Utterback has an in with Yamayuki, Tokyo's top tuna broker, which "only deals to the Michelin guys." Photo illustration by Jason Fulford and Tamara Shopsin

It's well-known lore, particularly in Omaha, Nebraska, that Warren Buffett—the ninety-five-year-old investor and philanthropist, who is also the city's most famous living resident—usually gets his breakfast from a McDonald's near his house. One inference that an outsider could draw from this information is that McDonald's is the best restaurant in Omaha, good enough for one of the richest men in the world, at least. This is the sort of thing that drives the chef David Utterback a little crazy. Not far from Buffett's preferred McDonald's is an ambitious Japanese restaurant called Yoshitomo, which Utterback, who is forty-four and half Japanese, opened in 2017, in what was formerly a Subway. Right next door is Ota, a sleek eight-seat sushi counter where, once a week, Utterback serves something you

might be surprised to find in America's most landlocked state: a world-class omakase.

On a recent Friday night at Ota, Utterback presented me and my fellow-patrons with the first of eighteen artful and inventive courses: tiny tarts, their crisp, fluted shells made from deep-fried nori, the iodine tang of the seaweed playing off a luscious filling of scallop carbonara, punchy with XO sauce and feathered with Parmesan. As he began to prepare nigiri, he offered a stern yet good-natured proclamation on the form. Each piece is meant to be enjoyed immediately, he explained—"Don't wait for your dining partner, just live in the moment, be selfish"—and eaten as a single perfect bite. "You have been living life up to this point in the Multiple Bite Sushi Club," he intoned. "This is your chance to do better. You can change. Life will be good."

An omakase, as with any tasting menu, can lend itself to preciousness: hushed, nearly tortured precision in the plating, obsession with ingredient pedigree. Utterback wasn't exactly beating the charges. For nigiri made with tilefish that he'd flown in from Nagasaki, then dry-aged and cured in seaweed, he painstakingly placed a single shiso leaf on each piece, then used a rare Japanese weasel-hair brush to apply a layer of soy sauce infused with preserved cherry blossom. But he was also clearly driven by an exhilarating streak of rebellion. "All through the north and south of Japan, the construction of sushi changes," he said, while serving something that resembled a meatball—fat, sticky grains of vinegar-seasoned rice flecked with chewy, briny bits of firefly squid, which glows a bioluminescent blue in Toyama Bay. "As long as you have sushi rice and literally anything else, it's sushi."

On the stool to my right was Josh Foo, an Omaha-based food photographer and a friend of Utterback's who told me that he'd recently recovered from a heart attack, a shock considering he's forty-two, trim, and sprightly. "At the hospital, this nurse goes, 'You're never gonna have rice again,' and I remember being, like, *I'm Asian, don't say that to me*," Foo said. From his hospital window, he could see the road that would take him to Yoshitomo and to Au Courant, a beloved farm-to-table restaurant across the street known for handmade pastas and scrupulously sourced local produce. "I

unhooked myself from everything, and I went, *I'm done*,” Foo told me as Utterback listened, smirking. “I was going to come to Au Courant, come to Yoshitomo. I was just gonna eat as much as I could and die at the bar. And then I got caught, and they sent a psychologist to my room.”

Many of the commercial strips in Omaha, a city of about half a million people, have the air of a nineties college town, with low-slung blocks of row houses punctuated by dive bars and cafés, thrift stores and record shops. If the city is known for anything, food-wise, it's beef; from the mid-nineteenth century to the mid-twentieth, it was a hub of American cattle trading and meatpacking, home to one of the largest livestock markets in the world. The Reuben sandwich may or may not have been invented in Omaha (New York lays claim to it, too), and the city's iconic restaurants are mostly steak houses, such as the Drover, a sixty-year-old Midwestern time capsule with a full salad bar and whiskey-marinated fillets.

The sense that Omaha might be underestimated, even by the people who live there, is a source of both pride and torment for Utterback. We'd first met in Los Angeles, a city whose sushi doesn't particularly impress him, a few months prior to my visit; he travels widely to meet other chefs and invite them to Omaha to eat and collaborate. “In Omaha—and outside of Omaha, too—there's this assumption that, because something exists in a bigger city, it's inherently better, right?” he said. He is quick to point out that he has an in with Yamayuki, Tokyo's top tuna broker, which “only deals to the Michelin guys,” and that he began dry-aging fish—a process that enhances both flavor and texture—long before it was fashionable. “We're out here blazing a trail, and every night someone will go, ‘This is definitely the best sushi in Omaha,’ ” Utterback said. “I don't even get the state, the region, the surrounding Zip Codes! If we were in New York, if we were in L.A., people wouldn't say, ‘This is good for L.A.’ They would say, ‘This is one of the best I've ever had.’ We never get that. No one's ever tried to change it.”

Utterback's parents met on the Japanese island of Okinawa, where his mother was born and where his father was stationed with the U.S. Air Force. They settled in Omaha when Utterback was ten. Utterback's mother, Hiroko Ota, took cooking cues from her fellow military wives; the family

ate a lot of goulash, cottage cheese, and spaghetti, sometimes in a modified *yakisoba*. “She didn’t really make stuff. She just sort of . . . made stuff out of other stuff,” Utterback recalled. “Nobody was excited about dinner.” Special occasions, though, were almost always celebrated at Sushi Ichiban, a restaurant affiliated with the Unification Church, whose members are known as the Moonies. The Church’s founder, the Korean messiah claimant Sun Myung Moon, was largely responsible for popularizing sushi in the United States, driven by a belief that the seafood industry was a divinely inspired solution to world hunger.

In his twenties, as Utterback dipped in and out of community college and played in punk bands—it’s not hard, even now, to imagine him in a mosh pit, with his buzzed hair and tattooed biceps—he got a job cooking at a restaurant called Blue Sushi Sake Grill. By 2014, he was the head chef of the restaurant group that encompassed Blue and had started to experiment with omakase as a side project. On a trip to Japan a few years earlier, he had eaten at Sukiyabashi Jiro, the Tokyo restaurant that would be made famous by the documentary “Jiro Dreams of Sushi.” When Utterback told Jiro Ono and his son that he was a sushi chef from Nebraska, they laughed at him, but also agreed to his request for an internship—so long as he moved to Tokyo for at least three years, ideally a decade. Utterback, who’d just gotten married and bought a house in Omaha, instead devoted himself to learning on his own, poring over books, making regular trips to Japan, and befriending masters of the craft.

In the years since, Utterback has often struggled to reconcile his culinary ambitions and the demands of the local market. In 2024, he jumped at the chance to buy Sushi Ichiban, which had been renamed Sakura Bana, and to upgrade it slightly, paring the menu down to its best-sellers and improving the quality of ingredients. But, when he raised the price of a lunchtime bento box from twelve dollars to fifteen, “everyone freaked out,” he said. “I got literal handwritten hate mail—on paper, put in an envelope, anonymously mailed—every week.” Within a year, he shut the place down, shouldering a huge loss. “I messed with everyone’s nostalgia,” he said. “I ruined their favorite sushi restaurant—and mine.”

It's easy to sympathize with the plight of the best sushi chef in Omaha. Utterback's cooking is as sophisticated as what you might encounter at equivalent restaurants in New York or Chicago, a feat he pulls off without the infrastructure and specialized talent pool that you can find in bigger cities. He craves recognition and commercial success, yet he wants neither to leave Omaha nor to see the city change too much. About a week before my visit, the annual Berkshire Hathaway shareholders' meeting had flooded the city with deep-pocketed patrons, including a pair of "sushi bros," Utterback told me, "very rich people who should have just been at a sports bar." Instead, they'd booked seats at Ota, and annoyed the hell out of him by loudly sharing their raunchiest strip-club stories. "And, like, I have those, too," Utterback said. "But, unless I tell you that, I have not told you that it's O.K. to behave that way at the counter."

On my last day in town, Utterback and I stopped by Shredder's, an irreverent pizza place that he was getting ready to open with one of his former bandmates. As he approved a pile of wall art—framed posters from early-two-thousands punk shows—I peeked at a rough draft of the menu, which included the DJ Rangoochi, a pie topped with crab and fried wonton-wrapper strips. From there, we walked to Koji, an *izakaya* that Utterback opened in 2022, where we sampled some of the menu's most popular maki rolls, such as the Royale, a flamboyant concoction of spicy salmon, crab, and avocado topped with sambal salsa—the kind of thing that sells better than, say, firefly squid.

Utterback's initial vision for Koji was to showcase an array of superlative yakitori: behind the bar, a designated chef, one of Utterback's few Japanese employees, was carefully tending a *binchotan* grill, basting bronzed cubes of pork belly in *tare*, a classic mix of soy sauce, mirin, sake, and sugar, and rotating skewers of plump, smoky *tsukune* meatballs, to be finished with an egg-yolk sauce. "I thought people would be really excited about it," Utterback said wistfully. He quickly learned that his customers didn't share his enthusiasm. The yakitori is what he calls the "dog" of the menu, losing him money every day, yet he can't bring himself to give up on it. "I just love it too much," he said. ♦

[Hannah Goldfield](#), a staff writer covering restaurants and food culture, received a 2024 James Beard Award for her [Profile of the chef Kwame Onwuachi](#).

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[The Art World](#)

Edmonia Lewis, the Misunderstood Sculptor Who Brought Stone to Life

She was a Black and Indigenous woman who became famous for working in white marble. But the focus on her race can obscure the subtle, often contradictory triumphs of her art.

By [Zachary Fine](#)

June 8, 2026



Works such as “Forever Free” (1866-67) slyly undermine the tropes of their era. Art work by Edmonia Lewis / Courtesy Howard University Gallery of Art / Art Resource; Photograph from the Metropolitan Museum of Art

When the sculptor Edward Brackett arrived at the jail in Charlestown, Virginia, in the fall of 1859, he found the most notorious man in America in less than ideal condition. John Brown was badly wounded. During his raid on the federal arsenal at Harper's Ferry, he had been stabbed with a sword and smashed in the head, and now he was spending his last days in a cell, mostly horizontal on a cot, living in his own stench. Commissioned by two abolitionists to capture Brown's likeness before he was hanged, Brackett made a marble bust that turned his face into a sort of cross between Moses and Socrates, with Brown's iconic beard rippling out of his chin like a white flame. "The bust as you see it, is a little poeticized," Brackett wrote, explaining his vision. "John Brown was not himself a great man, but rather a forerunner of great things. He was a blind instrument, blindly cutting the way to the death of thousands and the birth of a new age."

This might as well be a defense of American sculpture in the second half of the nineteenth century, which lost itself in such a frenzy of Civil War monuments, memorials, plaques, and busts that you would be hard pressed to find a single sculpture of a person who doesn't look like an instrument of some creed or cause. There are no kitchen workers scouring pots or raconteurs drinking rum punch; most of the figures seem utterly incapable of offering directions or telling a joke, much less running, sweating, or allowing blood to flow through their veins. They are rigidly ideal. Even one of the most historically astute and naturalistic sculptures of the period, Augustus Saint-Gaudens's "Memorial to Robert Gould Shaw and the Massachusetts Fifty-fourth Regiment" (1884), has an angel swooping down from above, as if providence, not the decisions of human beings, were guiding the soldiers toward their deaths.

A young woman named Edmonia Lewis saw Brackett's bust of Brown and, with a letter of introduction from the abolitionist William Lloyd Garrison, went to study with Brackett in his Boston studio in 1863, just as the momentum of the Civil War was swinging toward the Union. Standing there with her mallet and chisel, Lewis must have seemed like a strange comet to Brackett: she was four feet tall, had a firm handshake and an unplaceable accent, and was a Black woman of Mississauga descent. She was also a quick study. First, she learned to model hands and feet out of clay, then she progressed to a medallion of John Brown's face and a marble bust of Robert

Gould Shaw (hot commodities in abolitionist circles). Within a few years, she was producing neoclassical sculpture to international acclaim, eventually attracting the notice of Frederick Douglass, Ulysses S. Grant, Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, and Pope Pius IX. But the enthusiasm for her art was always nicked with caveats and doubts. Some of the same white abolitionists who supported Lewis would say that her hands were not “educated enough to work in marble,” that she was better off sticking to stucco or wood. The irony of her medium wasn’t lost on her: she had mastered the aesthetic ideal of a civilization that was determined to undermine, if not destroy, everything she represented.

There’s a Lewis revival in full swing right now, with an ambitious survey that began at the Peabody Essex Museum, in Salem, Massachusetts, and is now heading to the Georgia Museum of Art. “Edmonia Lewis: Said in Stone,” curated by Jeffrey Richmond-Moll and Shawnya L. Harris, assembles the stray pieces of Lewis’s life and work, bringing together the biggest scholarly haul since Kirsten Pai Buick’s “Child of the Fire: Mary Edmonia Lewis and the Problem of Art History’s Black and Indian Subject” (2010). There’s also a book out in June, “Moving Stones: About the Art of Edmonia Lewis,” by Jennifer DeVere Brody, with its own deft archival research. Solving the mysteries of Lewis’s art hasn’t been easy. To give a sense of what scholars are up against: her most famous piece, “The Death of Cleopatra,” almost three tons of marble, was shipped from Rome to Philadelphia for the Centennial Exposition of 1876, and then spent the next century on a Forrest Gump-style journey, reappearing in a Chicago saloon, then on the grave of a racehorse, then in a junk yard, only to be discovered, in the nineteen-eighties, in the storeroom of a suburban strip mall. Again, that’s Lewis’s most famous piece.



Edmonia Lewis around 1870. Photograph by Henry Rocher / Courtesy Harvard Art Museums / Fogg Museum

Together, the new research presents a meaty challenge to our understanding of nineteenth-century American sculpture. Although Lewis did lots of standard neoclassical fare—high-society busts, church commissions, funerary monuments—the savvy of her work is the way it twists the rhetoric of marble sculpture to new ends, both personal and political. She’s credited with various firsts: the first African American to be a professional sculptor; the first African American and Indigenous woman artist of international fame. But the exhibition and the scholarship, though occasionally a bit fawning, show why the value of Lewis’s art doesn’t hang on these distinctions. If anything, they’ve been used to discredit her. Henry James once described Lewis as a woman “whose color, picturesquely contrasting with that of her plastic material, was the pleading agent of her

fame,” as if her race were announced with every piece of marble, to hector you into liking it. Had he even bothered to look at her work?

The exhibition opens with Lewis’s sculpture “Forever Free” (1866-67). Roughly three and a half feet tall, it shows a man and a woman who’ve just heard the news of the Emancipation Proclamation. The man, shirtless and in cropped trousers, raises his broken shackles in one hand and puts his other on the shoulder of the woman, who’s kneeling, her eyes cast toward Heaven. Seen through the lens of the Civil War and its aftermath, the piece subverts every expectation. Lewis’s clientele, mostly white, would have expected her to make Lincoln the executor of freedom, as Thomas Ball did in his “Emancipation Memorial” (1876), on Capitol Hill, but, instead, she has her enslaved subjects manumit themselves. That might seem empowering, but is it? The woman is shrunken, subservient; the facial features of the two figures have been diluted to make them racially ambiguous. Then, there’s the marble itself: an antique medium applied to a historical event barely three years old, a medium full of associations of purity and racial hygiene put to the tune of liberation. (A bold decision, if you consider sentiments like Henrik Ibsen’s, from 1874: “I would rather see the head of a negro executed in black than in white marble. Speaking generally, the style must conform to the degree of ideality which pervades the representation.”) In sum, Lewis’s piece is a welter of contradictions. It’s timeless and bracingly new, regressive and cutting-edge. It’s the most conservatively radical sculpture I’ve ever seen.

Lewis made “Forever Free” after she arrived in Rome in 1865. Throughout the nineteenth century, American sculptors flocked to the Eternal City to be closer to the source—to the abundance of antiquities but also to the Apuan Alps in the north, with their marble quarries. Lewis found a space on Via Gregoriana, a former studio of Antonio Canova, the grand eminence of neoclassical sculpture, and was only a stone’s throw from the Villa Ludovisi, with its impressive collection of antique statuary, including the “Ludovisi Gaul”: a Hellenistic sculpture of a man who has just killed his wife and is driving a sword into his own chest, and a possible reference for the composition of “Forever Free.” Although Lewis seems to have led a vibrant life in Rome—hosting dinner parties, playing guitar for friends, attending the opera—her circumstances were different from other artists’.

The reason she had left America, she told the *Times*, was “to find a social atmosphere where I was not constantly reminded of my color. The land of liberty had no room for a colored sculptor.”

From childhood onward, Lewis’s life seemed to ricochet between misfortune and luck, one person’s cruelty and another’s kindness. Born in upstate New York, in 1844, to a free Afro-Caribbean father and a Mississauga mother, she was an orphan before the age of ten. She was taken in by her maternal aunts and learned how to make souvenirs, such as beaded moccasins and birch-bark baskets, that were sold to tourists around Niagara Falls. The details of her childhood are patchy, and it’s possible she wanted to keep it that way: “My early life cannot interest you,” she told an interviewer. “It glided along smoothly, with no event of any importance, until I became seized with the idea of becoming a sculptress.” With the financial support of her half brother Samuel, who seems plucked from a story by Mark Twain—he lived various lives, as a tightrope walker, a barber, a gold miner, a sleight-of-hand showman, and a property developer—Lewis was able to afford a private liberal-arts education at New York Central College, and then at Oberlin, the first coed and racially integrated college in America. In the end, that didn’t make much of a difference. Lewis was accused of poisoning two white female housemates, assaulted by a white mob in response to the charge, and acquitted in court, only to then be accused of stealing art supplies and prohibited from reënrolling. Fortunately, she met Frederick Douglass as he was passing through Ohio. He praised her student drawings and paintings, and urged her to “seek the East.” In 1863, Lewis moved to Boston and started her apprenticeship with Brackett. Two years later, she was in Rome.

There are twenty-nine sculptures by Lewis in the exhibition—the earliest from 1864 and the latest from 1880—and, even though she received commissions into the eighteen-nineties, most of her surviving work belongs to the first two decades of her career. Her busts of wealthy abolitionists and famous men, such as Lincoln and Longfellow, come across as the meat and potatoes of a commercial artistic practice, but her group sculptures are tantalizingly tricky. Each one is like a Russian nesting doll of political self-consciousness, one kernel of meaning hidden inside the next. Are they works of activist art masquerading as decorative kitsch, or the other way

around? Are they designed to flatter progressive sensibilities or provoke them? Of the various group sculptures in the exhibition, including “The Old Indian Arrow Maker and His Daughter” (1866-67), “Hiawatha’s Marriage” (1866-70), and “Indian Combat” (1868), the piece I kept returning to, and crashing up against, was “Columbus” (1865-67).

Baudelaire, in an essay titled “Why Sculpture Is Boring,” argued that one of the disadvantages of sculpture was that it “shows too many surfaces at once,” unlike painting, which can offer a single and coherent point of view. As a person ambles around a sculpture, perspectives multiply; interpretations are born and dissolved; shadows play on the surface and complicate the interpretive field, making hair look like spaghetti or a nostril look angry. The funny thing about Baudelaire’s argument, of course, is that it’s a wonderful explanation for why sculpture *isn’t* boring. The freedom to move around the object, to mentally embroider a narrative on bits of motionless metal or stone—that’s what makes the form interesting. This became clear to me in the case of “Columbus,” particularly with regard to his face and his, um, penis.



"The Old Indian Arrow Maker and His Daughter" (1866-67). Art work by Edmonia Lewis / Courtesy North Carolina Museum of Art

The sculpture shows the Italian explorer gallantly holding up a blanket behind a naked Indigenous woman who's kneeling at his side. It looks like he's about to clothe her, to bring her into the fold of civilization. Her hand is pressed to her chest in a gesture of gratitude, as if to thank him for colonizing her land. (She's likely an allegory for America.) The exhibition catalogue reminds us that, in the nineteenth century, Columbus wasn't seen as an agent of genocide but as a symbol of liberation, and argues that the work is "peaceful, even tender, in the figures' mutual devotion to Christian progress"—that Lewis has turned the Indigenous woman into an active agent of American prosperity. That seems like a bizarre reading to me. For one, Columbus's face wears the haughtiest, most cocksure expression in Lewis's body of work. He has the air of a smug and slightly evil magician: the arched eyebrow and the disdainful little smile playing on his lips, the ta-da-like flourish of his cloak to introduce his new acquisition, a sneaky-

looking Swiss roll of parchment sliding out of his left sleeve. Unlike “Forever Free,” there’s not a hint of warmth between the man and the woman at his feet. She’s just a casualty of his self-regard.

Looking at Columbus from a slight angle, to the left or right, you’ll notice a very small knob of fabric over his groin. It’s less a bulge and more the intimation of an erection. I initially dismissed it as an incidental fold in his cloak, but then a friend who accompanied me to the show, as well as a few other visitors, remarked on the protuberance. Perhaps it’s from a haphazard strike of the chisel; perhaps the erection doesn’t exist at all. But it matters insofar as it slyly punctures the heroic myth: now it’s a frisson of sexual excitement motivating this civilizing encounter between the Old World and the New. Sleight of hand and the tightrope were Lewis’s brother’s talents, but I’m increasingly convinced that they were hers as well: balancing her own political commitments with those of her patrons, creating a commodity that pretends to say one thing while doing another.

With “Columbus,” as with “Hiawatha’s Marriage” and “Arrow Maker,” the standard line is that Lewis uses marble sculpture to humanize Indigenous subjects, to “counter pernicious stereotypes.” The latter two pieces borrow scenes from Longfellow’s poem “The Song of Hiawatha” (1855), a fictional American epic based on a mistranslation of a work by the Anishinabe poet Bamewawagezhikaquay (Jane Johnston Schoolcraft). Within two years of being published, Longfellow’s book had sold fifty thousand copies, and Lewis recognized the commercial appeal of hitching a sculpture to a popular story. Where the stereotype-busting appears is in Lewis’s choice of scene and details. “Arrow Maker” shows a Dakota woman named Minnehaha sitting next to her father, braiding a mat of rushes while he works on an arrowhead; “Hiawatha’s Marriage” shows Minnehaha clasping hands with an Ojibwa warrior, Hiawatha—a bonding moment between two warring tribes. Instead of sculpting a sensational Trail of Tears scene of violent removal, Lewis opts for something tranquil. And she lavishes attention on the accessories: the bear-tooth necklace, the jasper arrowhead, the soft buckskin.

Still, the argument that Lewis’s everyday harmonies and material detail reflect some radical artistic program seems like a stretch. Lewis participated

in Black activist circles in Boston, and donated sculptures to religious organizations that supported women's rights, but her work could also play handily into the status quo. "Indian Combat," for instance, is a vortex of three half-naked men fighting to the death, with one trying to rip another's scalp off. The piece was tucked into an alcove off to the side of the Peabody Essex exhibition, as if it were a counter-argument the show didn't want to countenance. In all likelihood, Lewis knew that Indigenous violence was a sale she could bank on. Working in marble is punishingly expensive, from the material itself to the shipping costs, and she spent years struggling to make ends meet. "You know," she said, "we must sell our work if we want to live."

Lewis died in London, in 1907, and was buried in an unmarked grave. The word "art," which usually seems so large and capacious, somehow starts to feel inadequate when thinking about her work. For Lewis's sculptures to succeed, their art wasn't sufficient; they were expected to be more—proof of her humanity or monuments of collective uplift. Even today, she's remembered for commemorations like "Forever Free," though part of me wonders if her most enduring pieces are the grace notes. At Peabody Essex, I kept returning to "Clasped Hands of Gerrit and Ann Smith" (1872), a marriage portrait of two life-size hands. Gerrit Smith, one of the Secret Six who funded Brown's raid at Harper's Ferry, operated a station of the Underground Railroad with his wife, Ann, from their home in New York. You can tell the hands have been close for years. Neither clenches or grabs; they fall into each other, naturally locked under their thumbs. It's a kind of realism that's powerful enough to suggest an ideal without stating it. The Smiths were well-known activists, and so the sculpture could serve as an instrument of the abolitionist cause, a symbolic pact. But it is also a simple expression of love. ♦

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[The Theatre](#)

The Rise of the Meta-Gay Show

In “Can I Be Frank?” and “Heated Rivalry: The Unauthorized Musical,” gay fandom generates funny and moving new material.

By [Emily Nussbaum](#)

June 4, 2026



In “Can I Be Frank?,” Morgan Bassichis delivers a cross-generational celebration of the performance artist Frank Maya. Illustration by Adams Carvalho

In the opening moments of Morgan Bassichis’s bright, mournful “Can I Be Frank?,” they stand center stage at the tiny Soho Playhouse, clutching a mike and shrieking a denunciation of a closeted celebrity: “Liberace, Liberace, can you hear me, Liberace? You *died*. You lied. You died of *AIDS* and you lied. . . . You could have helped so many people—sorry, Gloria, can we get the lights?” Bassichis twitches as if emerging from hypnosis, then apologizes: it’s not really *them* yelling, they explain, it’s a bit by Frank Maya, an artist who died of *AIDS*-related complications in 1995. And Maya’s uncut rage may be too hot a way to open this one-person show—so can they start over? And add some context?

The context: Bassichis, a nonbinary performance artist, became obsessed with Maya after meeting his brother at an artists' residency and thrilling to the parallels between their work. Maya, like Bassichis, did an act that was a bit standup, a bit performance art, broken up by dreamy, oddball songs. Maya, too, was a confessionalist and a pop-culture obsessive—he was known for his “rants,” manifestos that involved “tearing to shreds” other gay artists, a tradition that Bassichis describes, puckishly, as “one of our ancestral healing practices.” And Maya, like Bassichis, craved fame, the mainstream sort that he was tiptoeing toward when he died at forty-five, just as drugs for *AIDS* were becoming available. As a result, he became a cultural footnote, having exited the scene two years before Ellen DeGeneres's “Yep, I’m Gay” *Time* cover hit newsstands, two decades before the Supreme Court legalized same-sex marriage—and long before the hideous backlash of recent years, as school boards and state legislators worked to snuff out the queer history that Bassichis's show celebrates.

The performance is intended as a sort of séance, an attempt to summon the spirit of Maya—and, through him, the queer demimonde lost to the plague. But Bassichis's arch joke is that what we're watching is only a rough draft, a “preview” in which one thirsty artist struggles to celebrate another, only to get derailed by their own solipsism. There's no pretense that Bassichis is truly embodying Maya: the real Maya, whose work is on YouTube, was, as Bassichis acknowledges, more butch and more chill, with a regular-dude affect. (His energy reminded me a bit of Tony Danza's, and was surprisingly similar to that of another gay pioneer, this one fictional: Jodie Dallas, Billy Crystal's character on the late-seventies TV show “Soap.”)

Bassichis has their own bracing charisma: an elegant schnoz, sparkling eyes, and a slinky body that wriggles like a Squirmls toy as they glide over the stage, tugged to and fro by audience banter. That craving for attention is the aspect of Maya's work that Bassichis focusses most closely on, as they tangle themselves in the mike cord like Liza Minnelli on *quaaludes*, then cue up audience members to read sycophantic questions off notecards. There aren't a lot of details here about Maya's life: it's a very different project from, say, Matt Wolf's brilliant documentary “Pee-wee as Himself,” which gently but insistently cuts to the core of Paul Reubens's mystique. Instead, it's more of a vaudeville act with YouTube links, or a campy riff on “Pale

Fire,” a clinging vine of commentary wrapped around Maya’s act, concealing as much as it exposes.

At times, this approach can wear thin, the air quotes so enormous that they dwarf what’s inside them. But, when the method clicks, it captures something profound: the deep craving to understand, cross-generationally, queer art that refused to play it small. At one juncture, Bassichis recounts a routine that Maya did about coming out as gay to his father, a devout Catholic who reassured him that their family would pay any price for a cure. Maya wisecracked that everybody already knew the cure for homosexuality—fame. Then Bassichis explains the gulf between then and now: when they first heard the joke, they thought the point was that gay men were showboaters, striving class-president types, whose traumas got healed by the limelight. But Maya’s real joke was that getting famous meant you could no longer *be* gay—you needed to retreat to the closet, like Liberace and Reubens did.

At times, the show reminded me of David Drake’s “The Night Larry Kramer Kissed Me,” from 1992, in which Drake argues that the then popular Chelsea “clone” aesthetic wasn’t about vanity so much as self-defense: get bashed enough and you, too, might adopt a shield of muscle. Bassichis argues for something similar: that gay-male narcissism can be a form of political defiance, a refusal to be ignored. Watching them, I was flooded with memories of that lost era, back when debates erupted in response to *OutWeek* magazine, which took shots at all the famous figures who chose security over solidarity. Mostly, I flashed back to Buddy Cole, a character created by Scott Thompson on the Canadian sketch show “The Kids in the Hall,” which debuted in 1988. It was my first glimpse of the razzle-dazzle of gay fury: Cole, a haughty queen who held court from his barstool, similarly took aim at his peers, tearing into homophobic comics such as Sam Kinison and Andrew Dice Clay, during a time when grabbing the mike back from bigots was a radical act. “Can I Be Frank?” performs the opposite of a takedown—it throws its arms around the painful past, as if it were an old friend you might never see again, someone who might have a few sharp ideas about how to survive the present.

Just uptown from the Soho Playhouse, you can find a more cheerful variant of queer fandom in “Heated Rivalry: The Unauthorized Musical,” an adaptation of last year’s surprise television hit about closeted gay hockey players, one sweetly Canadian, one gloomily Russian. You might assume, not unreasonably, that this parody would be dumb, disposable fun—for superfans only. You’d be wrong! To my shock and delight, “Heated Rivalry,” written with unsettling swiftness by Dylan MarcAurele, is a flat-out terrific musical, no caveats necessary. I saw it with somebody who hadn’t watched the show, and she loved it, too.

Like “Can I Be Frank?,” “Heated Rivalry” arrives in ironic air quotes: a trio of horny housewives, all named Susan, sing a rollicking homage to their preferred binge-watch, a series about “Hockey players, with big butts / Sucking dick, but they’re *sad*.” The prima donna of the group (the fabulous Ryann Redmond, in a haystack wig) explains that this is all a sacred ritual, an attempt, during the show’s hiatus, “to keep the spirit of Shane and Ilya”—the show’s central couple—“alive through this endless winter.” Yet what Susan narrates, as she guzzles “Ambien margaritas,” is not a rude satire; in fact, it’s actually a pretty solid distillation of the show’s narrative. For all the raunchy puns about “heavy loads” and meta-references to the fandom (the YouTube videos of Connor Storrie, the original Ilya, come into play), the show delivers much of the same emotional kick of the series, from its enemies-to-lovers frisson to the psychic burden of the celebrity closet. That makes sense, really: Aren’t Broadway musicals and romance novels the art forms best designed to tap buried feelings that can’t be repressed?

All the songs are good, from Ilya’s hilariously mournful introductory number, “Big Ass, Cold Heart,” to the peculiarly affecting ballad “This Fuck Is Different,” a romantic-breakthrough number delivered with such resolute, distressed sincerity by Jimin Moon, who plays the Canadian goofball Shane Hollander, that a man near me clutched his chest. Key sequences from the show—like a cruising scene in a hotel gym—are reproduced, efficiently, using basic props. The sex is staged vertically, up against mattresses, or using “Avenue Q”-esque puppets; the Susan trio juggle multiple roles, from Ilya’s cruel dad to Shane’s hovering mom—and,

each night, one lucky audience member is invited onstage to play the hunky zaddy Scott Hunter.

Best of all are the adorable Moon and Jay Armstrong Johnson, as Ilya, who do much more than mug as the star-crossed lovers. It's impossible to say how Frank Maya might greet a crossover phenomenon like this: As schlock? As progress? But, in the midst of a Broadway season overflowing with high camp, from "Titanique" to "The Jellicle Ball," there's some room to spare for a humble, handmade valentine, découpaged with X's and O's. ♦ [Emily Nussbaum](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2011, is the magazine's theatre critic. Her books include "[Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV](#)."

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Still Life of Mom in Her Garden (Bodegón de Mamá en Su Jardín)

By [Isabella DeSendi](#)

June 8, 2026

Some afternoons are like this—
the stupor of Florida light
leaning between a vulture's black wings
while he picks apart a garden snake
on the road outside our house.
On the road outside our house,
an *ICE* agent surveys our block like a bird
whose hovering means death
is nearby. Nothing really changes. Mom still doesn't believe
in the dishwasher, thinks the only way
a plate can get clean is if you scrub it
by pressing the whole weight of your body
against the grime that grips the glass
until it glimmers white as a country
devoid of people like us. We tell Mom to stay in and rest
but she refuses. Her hands can't stay still,
which is why she planted the small garden
that she tends to every morning.
It is not about the vegetables. The dirt is dry and futile
and the bed floods every June, leaving her no choice
but to start over again. First seed then dirt then rain then light.
Then, finally, a small sprig that keeps her
hopeful, in prayer of new blooms. Today, when she walks out
to the garden in her muumuu, hair knotted
and unkempt, and submits her brown knees

to brown dirt under the undying heat
like a saint at the foot of an altar,
I watch the man in the truck watch her
the way a predator watches a small thing
it can trick, and feel like the young girl I was
once, kneeling beside her in a pew, asking God
to make some small miracle of our life.
Imagine a blessing like that now: Mom's garden flush
with peppers, carrots, little crowns
of broccoli sprouting. The snake uncrushed.
The small root she unknots from the earth
the only thing plucked from this home.
O God, if you do nothing else, cover me
in just a crumb of the courage
Mom maintains standing in her yard
in the beautiful conflagration of this country:
one brown hand holding a small gift the soil has given,
the other waving at the officer as if to say,
You are welcome. Come inside and eat.

[Isabella DeSendi](#) is the author of the poetry collection "[Someone Else's Hunger](#)."

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Watching Cartoons on a Saturday Morning

By [Christian Wiman](#)

June 8, 2026

Nothing more of love
than to watch the bright beings
spurt across the screen
their elastic lives, their un-sad
disasters, their obstinate glee.
To press one's face close to theirs
until the curse and hurl upstairs
cackle and razzmatazz
and synch with the beak
of a duck. Oh, what luck, these creatures
come of storm, these avatars of form
and color and unconsciousness
dying back to life with a laugh.
Cuckoo wobble, tuba walk,
boing boing and the whistling thribble.
Closer and closer to the screen
until even the credits mean
just this flickering inconsequence,
this everlasting present tense.
Let face with the rake be struck.
Let the schmuck tumble downstairs
with a happy clash of cymbals.
Ring the king's head in the dented pail.
Let the lost child drop. Let gravity fail.

This is drawn from “[The Dance](#).”

[Christian Wiman](#) is an author whose books include “[Survival Is a Style: Poems](#)” and “[Zero at the Bone](#).”

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The Crossword: Monday, June 8, 2026

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June 8, 2026

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[Patrick Berry](#) has been publishing puzzles since 1993 and lives in Athens, Georgia.

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